

A man and a woman are shown in a close embrace, nearly kissing. They are both wearing white tank tops. The man is on the left, and the woman is on the right. They are positioned in front of a large, red, textured object that resembles a boxing bag or a large flower. The background is a warm, orange-red gradient.

KENNY WRIGHT
TRAINING
TO LOVE IT

A Wife Watching Romance

ONE

I was watching something mindless on TV when Erin came home from the gym. Slumping against the front door, she let out a heavy sigh.

“Good workout?” I asked.

“Too good. I’m sore everywhere.”

“It’s definitely paying off.”

She rolled her eyes, but I knew she appreciated it. Erin had been working hard over the last couple months. Not that she needed to before—she had genes that let her get away with doing nothing and still look good—but after two kids, she’d started feeling self-conscious about the softer parts of her body.

Her cropped yoga pants and tight tank top confirmed my statement: her workouts were definitely paying off.

“So the personal trainer was a good investment?” I asked.

“I don’t know about that. I’ll let you know when my body’s recovered.”

I watched her disappear into the kitchen, checking out her ass. Her hips were wider than when I’d first met her and she had a rounder butt, but I liked her more pronounced curves.

Pulling myself off the sofa, I followed her. I had no right to feel this exhausted—not after the workout that Erin had just come home from—but it had been a long day, topped off by the chore of getting the kids down for the night.

I found Erin at the fridge, bathed in the bright glow of its interior, downing a bottle of Gatorade. As always, her dark hair was pushed back by a headband and gathered into a high ponytail to keep it out of her face. Her face seemed slimmer, the hard workouts bringing her beauty into crisp focus.

I wanted to tell her how beautiful she was—how incredible she was. Instead, I just watched her drink and enjoy the cool air from the fridge.

“You know, I could always turn on the A/C.”

Erin laughed, shutting the refrigerator door. “It’s only May. No need to do that. Kids in bed?”

“Went down without a fuss.”

It was a new thing we were trying. Our kids, particularly our youngest, Mary, were used to their mother doing the nighttime routine. Erin never said she minded—she was a wonderful mother—but after spending most of the day with them, I could tell she needed a break. So we decided that twice a week, after a light dinner, Erin would go to the gym and I’d handle the bedtime ritual. The first week had been tough, but after that, the kids adapted. It was actually really nice: I got to spend quality time with them, Erin got her break, and the kids got to see more of Daddy.

“Thanks for watching them.”

She melted into my arms and kissed me. She tasted salty. Her skin was still flushed from the workout.

I reached behind her and cradled her buttocks. “It’s definitely a good deal.”

“So did you put the child safety locks on the cabinets upstairs?”

Just like that, domesticity crept back in. I released her ass. “No, I...couldn’t figure them out.”

Erin snorted, pulling back. “Fine, I’ll do it myself tomorrow. You may be the only man on this planet who can’t find his way around power tools.”

It was a playful jab, a joke shared between us over the years, but there was some truth to it. I held up my hands. “These hands are meant for signing documents, not hard labor.”

Erin laughed, turning for the stairs. “I’ll let you get back to signing your documents. I’m going to grab a shower.”

Zeroing in on her butt again as she ascended the stairs, I considered joining her, but in the end went back to the television. It had been a while since we'd made love—and years since we'd done it in the shower—but I was too exhausted to even think about the contortions needed to do that, let alone actually do it.

So instead, I sat in front of the television and let the cop drama resolve itself at the end of the hour. Not that I processed any of it. I didn't process anything until the credits rolled and it was time to head upstairs.

I checked on the kids. Martin and Mary were still tucked into their beds. Mary had her stuffed panda bear pulled against her, breathing softly. Her hair had started to come in, dark and wavy like Erin's, and she'd seemingly gone from baby to toddler overnight.

"Our little angel," Erin whispered behind me. The fresh scent of her shampoo filled me with nostalgia. Erin had been using the same brand of shampoo since I'd met her, way back in her early twenties. The light, fruity aroma had become synonymous with her.

"All clean?"

"Squeaky, but still sore." She wrapped her arms around me and hugged me close. "Come on, let's go to bed."

Erin wore nothing but a white towel, and I couldn't take my eyes off her. I lagged behind her a couple paces, drinking in her shapely legs and the supple contours of her bare shoulders. When she crossed over to her dresser and nonchalantly dropped the towel to the floor, I wondered: how in the world had I taken her for granted?

She reached into the top drawer of her dresser and retrieved her pajamas, keeping her back to me as she did so. We'd been doing that for a while now, I realized—preserving our modesty like we weren't an old married couple but a pair of roommates. I fought the urge to avert my eyes, instead staring at her heart-shaped buttocks until her pajama pants covered them. Her t-shirt went on next.

“What?” Erin asked, seeing me staring when she finally turned around.

“Nothing, just...I wish you hadn’t put on your PJs so fast...” I almost winced at the suggestion, like it suddenly wasn’t something appropriate for a man to say to his wife. I relaxed when Erin shot me a quick smile.

“Oh? I can take them off just as easily as I put them on, you know.”

This felt closer to the Erin I knew—the pre-children, pre-everything Erin. I went to her, gathering her in my arms. It was familiar, yet good. “Can you? You’re very talented.”

“I do my best.” Erin giggled. “But I’d rather you take them off me.”

“That’s what husbands are for, right?”

We kissed some more. My hands traveled down her back and up under her top. Her skin was still flush from the shower, warm and soft beneath my fingertips. I pulled the shirt up, breaking the kiss long enough to get it over her head.

I palmed a breast, feeling her small, dark nipple come alive under my thumb. They’d returned to their natural B-cups since she’d stopped nursing, but still sat high and round on her lean body. She’d complained about the loss in cup size, but I thought they suited her better this way.

Hooking the thumb of my free hand in her pajama bottoms, I pushed it down over her hips. With a wiggle, it pooled around her ankles, once again leaving her naked.

“There. Now wasn’t that more fun?” she said.

“Way more.” I moved in to kiss her once more, caressing her nudity as we made out, harder and deeper than we’d done in what felt like years. We fell into bed like that, our tongues dueling and our hands exploring.

“You’re wearing too many clothes,” Erin said, tugging at my t-shirt.

I whipped it over my head as she went to work on my jeans. The rasp of the zipper felt illicit, despite Erin being my

wife. My breath caught as she looked up at me from between my legs, her damp hair cascading around her face. Oral sex had been put on hold since Mary was born, it seemed, but for a second, I thought the abstinence was over.

Then Erin glided up my body again as I kicked off my pants, and I didn't care anymore—not with the toned body rising over me.

“God, you're so hot.”

Erin laughed. “As my husband, you have to say that.”

I know it's a cliché, but she really did look better at 33 than she did at 23. She wouldn't be confused with a twenty-year-old, but I also don't think she'd want to be.

“I'd say it even if I wasn't—”

My breath caught as she rubbed the head of my cock along her pussy, teasing me with the soft curls of her trimmed bush.

“You have to say *that*, too,” she said.

I wanted to tell her that she was wrong. I wanted her to understand how honest I was being. But when she shifted over me, lining my cock up with her pussy, all I could manage was a moan.

Erin moved over me with a grace I hadn't remembered until now, her sleek body rippling like a great cat's. It had been long enough that we had to work at it before I was fully inside of her.

“It's been too long,” Erin said with a pained laugh. “You feel huge.”

I rested a hand on her hip, but not to guide or control. I simply wanted to be a part of her smooth undulations. She tipped her head back, eyes fluttering closed, and nibbled on her lower lip.

I watched her beneath the heavy lids of my own eyes, unable to vocalize my agreement. Too long. Why didn't we do it every single night?

I reached up, pulling her from her revelry to kiss her. I could feel something awaken in that kiss, the quiver of something stretching after being asleep for too long.

I rolled us until she was on the bottom, shifting my kisses to her neck and along the back of her ear. "You feel so good," I whispered. She groaned in response, wrapping her long legs behind my back.

Her heels dug into my lower back, encouraging me. I pumped her faster, letting the slippery friction take me away.

Erin's voice came at me husky and strained. "Are you close, Tom?"

"Yeah," I replied, my breath short.

"Me too."

She bowed beneath me, my grunts matching her gasps as we entered the home stretch.

"Yes, Tom. Yes!"

I buried my face in the fan of her hair, intoxicated by that oh-so-familiar scent. This was Erin. This was my wife, my partner, the love of my life.

"Come, Tom! Come!"

She drove her pelvis into mine as I filled her. Her climax escaped through her clenched teeth. Her nostrils flared. She fought to keep it quiet.

I wanted to throw my head back and roar, but instinct bred from years of having kids in the house stopped me short. I settled for a stifled, barking sigh before collapsing onto her in a gasping tangle of arms and legs.

"That was awesome," Erin said through a laugh. "Remind me why we don't do that more?"

I rolled off her, pulling the sheet across my nudity as I sucked in air. "I was thinking the same thing."

Erin snuggled against me, tracing her fingers up my chest. She tickled the French tips across my nipples. "Thanks for doing all the work. After tonight's session with the trainer, I don't think I could have kept up."

"I feel like I've had a workout now, too. And speaking of trainers, I thought you didn't like Lisa?"

The personal trainer had come with her gym membership. She liked the personal attention—and the forced regimen that came with it—just not the trainers. She hadn't clicked with either Adelaide, her first trainer, or Lisa, the replacement.

"Lisa's fine, if you're into that bubbly blonde airhead thing."

"Go on..."

Erin twisted my nipple. "Hey now."

"What?" I was the picture of innocence. "So did you trade her in for someone new?"

"Yeah." The feistiness vanished as quickly as it had arrived. She released my nipple, suddenly interested in the tight little curls that dappled my pecs.

"Anyone I know?"

She shook her head. Did she just take a breath before looking up at me? "He works the evening shifts."

"*He?*" For whatever reason, my heart skipped about a dozen beats.

She looked away, cuddling deeper into my arm, and pulled the blanket up over her shoulder. "Yeah. When I went and complained about Lisa, the manager suggested AJ. He's supposed to be one of their best trainers. He mostly works at the downtown location, but comes over and does the night shift at our gym every few days."

"I see." I didn't know what to say. Wasn't a male trainer for a female client a little unusual? Then again, Erin was a demanding client. "You like him?"

My question felt like a fist closing around my gut. The half-beat hesitation before answering squeezed it harder.

"I mean, he's definitely better than the uni-boob bimbettes."

I laughed, but the jealousy lingered. Brushing it off, I kissed the top of her head. "Sounds like a winner then. So

does that mean Lisa's free now?"

And then she went and teased me, delivering a line that would stay with me in the days and weeks ahead:

"Sure, if you're okay with me and AJ..."

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TWO

The next day, a Friday, wasn't like any other day. No. Last night, I'd gotten laid, and I walked into work with a spring in my step. Can you see my tail feathers? Can you see me strut?

That glow lasted until ten o'clock, when the first of my meetings began. After that, the slow grind of discussing strategy and ROI whittled last night's memory to nothing. We had a policy of no meetings on Fridays, so of course it seemed like every Friday filled up with meetings until the next thing I knew it was late afternoon and Erin was calling me on the phone.

"Hey, don't forget about our dinner over at the Hughes'."

"How could I forget?" Except that I actually *had* completely forgotten about it.

"You remember that you were going to stop by the fish market downtown and pick up some fish to grill?"

"I remember," I lied.

"You know I'm on to you, right, Tom?" I could hear the smile in her question. It made me smile back.

"I know that, too."

She laughed. "Okay, well as long as you get the fish and come home soon, all will be forgiven. Now tell whoever's in your meeting that you need to go, and *go*."

I glanced into the conference room, where I really did have a meeting going on—this one on market segmentation in the commercial real estate sector. We had some experts in and they were rattling on and on with no one really listening.

"I will. See you soon, hon."

"I better. Bye!"

*

Haley and Lucas Hughes were our attractive friends. I think every couple has them. She was a demure blonde with paper-white skin and a dazzling smile; he was 6'4" of tall, broad-shouldered masculinity—complete with beard and a handshake that felt like a vise.

I kind of liked them, and by kind of, I mean that I liked Haley. Lucas was just not my type, although I dealt with his kind all the time in the commercial real estate industry. He walked through life like the world revolved around him, a trust-fund kid who'd learned that success wasn't earned but delivered on a silver platter by men in white gloves. He ran his father's business now, something to do with private security, and owned the largest house in town.

"Don't be like that," Erin said as we walked through the crisp May evening. She held Mary in her arms. Martin had sped ahead on his scooter and was waiting at the corner for us to cross together.

"Like what?"

"I know you don't like Lucas, but Martin likes their son Andy, and Haley's my friend."

"Hey, I'll play nice, like always. We can talk about baseball or something. It'll be fine."

"Just stay away from politics," she warned.

I thought of that time the elections came up. That had been a huge disaster. "Right. No politics."

Haley had met Erin a couple years ago through our oldest, Martin, and their youngest, Andy. It had been a hard transition for Erin at the time. We'd moved out of the city, leaving most of our close—and childless—friends behind. She'd officially quit her dental hygienist job to take care of Martin. Erin was feeling isolated and lonely, so she joined a mom's group. I still remember when I came home the night after her first get-together—she'd come alive again. "There are others like me!"

Since Martin and Andy had entered preschool, the mom's group had largely stopped meeting. We still had dinner with the couples we'd grown closer to, though, like tonight.

Lucas's older child, Tess, greeted us at the door. "Uncle Tom, Auntie Erin, come on in!"

Tess was a good kid. Already twelve-years-old, she was the product of Lucas's first marriage, but despite the messy divorce, had turned out really mature. One of the things that I did love about dinners with the Hughes was that Tess usually took care of Martin, Mary, and Andy, leaving us grown-ups to socialize and feel more like adults than parents.

"Thanks, Tess," Erin said as we stepped into the foyer of the Hughes home. When they'd moved into the neighborhood, they'd torn down the modest original and erected the current McMansion in its place, although I had to admit that as far as these things went, the new construction was tasteful.

Andy darted out of the basement. "Hey, Marty, come check out my new Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles! Dad got me all four!"

Martin and Andy scampered around Lucas as he emerged from the kitchen, chuckling at the kids' excitement. "Be careful, guys," he shouted as they disappeared. "Well, hey, you two."

Lucas's eyes lingered on Erin enough to spike my jealousy, but that was nothing new. I ignored it just as I always did.

"Tom, how's it going?" Lucas said. I steeled myself for his handshake, yet still winced when the tight squeeze came. "Erin, you're looking great as always."

"You too, Lucas."

I knew she was just being nice, but her compliment still bothered me.

"Hails, the Smiths are here!" he shouted up the stairs.

"Be right down," came Haley's soft reply.

"That the fish?" Lucas asked, nodding to the cooler in my hand. "Come on, let's get the grill on."

*

Lucas and I shared a beer by the grill outside as Haley and Erin chatted on the patio. The kids squealed and played on the jungle gym in the far corner of the yard as the sun sloped low on the horizon.

"We have a pretty good life, my friend," Lucas said. The fish sizzled on the grill, along with a row of asparagus spears. It looked and smelled amazing.

I sipped my beer and nodded. "We do."

"Nice neighborhood. Nice jobs. Great kids." He grinned, looking over at Haley and Erin. "Hot wives."

"It's a good life."

"Erin's looking fucking great."

Even though she couldn't have heard, Erin covered her mouth and laughed out loud. Haley nodded, buoyed by my wife's laughter.

"She does. She's been working out."

She did look great, but in a pair of jeans and a short-sleeved sweater, she was still the familiar Erin who I'd known for years, the woman who bounced our daughter on her knee when she was sad.

"At City Fitness? When? I'd love to see her prancing around in spandex."

"You're an asshole." I said it with a laugh, but I actually meant it.

"Oh, come on. It's not like I'd be the only one. A chick like Erin in a room full of guys who only care about image? She probably gets hit on all the time."

That idea froze my blood. I hadn't considered that. Lucas read my expression.

“Don’t worry, my man. Erin’s probably used to handling it. I mean, look at her.”

I did, and this time, I saw her the way Lucas did—the way anyone did who hadn’t been married to her for eight years. She brushed a loose coil of dark hair out of her face and looked our way, like she felt us talking about her. Her face beamed as she smiled and offered a wave.

“You’re a lucky SOB, Tom. Think about it this way: all those guys can only fantasize about that pretty face between their legs, sucking them off. You actually get to see it.”

Between shock at such an explicit statement, and a little embarrassment that it had been a long time since Erin had done that to me, I didn’t know what to say. So I did the guy thing and raised my beer. “Ditto, Lucas. To having hot wives.”

Lucas grinned. “To hot wives...although if I caught any guy looking at Haley that way, I’d break him in half.”

I don’t think Lucas even realized how hypocritical that statement was, but I didn’t doubt him. If I’d said the same thing to him that he’d said about Erin, he probably would have tackled me.

Erin and Haley wandered over to us, my wife’s smile leading the way. “What are you two talking about?” she asked.

Lucas spoke for us. “That it’s been too long since we all got together.”

Erin shot me a skeptical look before answering Lucas. “Tell me about it. Actually, Haley and I were just talking about getting together every morning to jog.”

Haley added, “I’ve been meaning to ever since spring started, but it’s hard to get motivated. Erin was telling me about her personal trainer and how he’s really helped push her.”

Did I imagine the quick exchange between the two women? Erin’s face looked flush, but that could have been

the setting sun. Either way, I felt the heat of jealousy rise along my neck.

"A guy personal trainer, huh?" Lucas said. "You should have just asked me. I would have done it for free."

Lucas stretched his shoulders back and puffed out his chest. He did have a swimmer's build, and I wouldn't have been surprised if he'd been an athlete in his younger days.

Erin said, "I've got pretty high standards. I don't know that you'd make the cut."

"You can always take me for a test drive," Lucas said.

I shifted my weight and looked over at Haley. Lucas's blonde wife rolled her eyes, but looked more amused than put-out. She put a hand on Lucas's shoulder and said, "If you've got all this free time to offer personal training sessions, why don't you start by doing a few chores around the house? You know where the vacuum is."

Lucas bristled. "I work all day."

"So do I." Haley said it in her soft way—it wasn't a challenge so much as a statement. To Erin, she added, "He doesn't think that taking care of the kids is really work."

Erin nodded. "It's definitely a full-time job."

"And you've got two!"

Erin glanced at me. "Sometimes it feels like three."

"Same." Haley laughed. It was like Lucas and I weren't there, a fact that really got under Lucas's skin. Before he could voice his protest, Haley diffused the situation. "But I don't think I'd want it any other way. I love that I can watch Andy grow up, and honestly, I don't think I could go back to working in an office. All it takes is for Lucas to come home and talk about office politics and I'm like, *Nope, not for me.*"

I knew that Erin sometimes missed being in the workforce—especially the socialization with adults—but she nodded agreement with Haley. "There's a lot that I don't miss, for sure."

I looked at the grill. The filets were nice and charred. I said, "Dinner's ready. You two set the table yet?"

Erin fixed me with a flat stare. “I’ll keep that in mind next time I’m folding laundry while you’re watching TV.”

Haley stifled a laugh. “Come on, Erin, let’s go put our aprons on and get the kids.”

As they walked up to the house, I risked a glance at Lucas, expecting him to look rankled. Instead, I saw him focused on my wife’s ass, as if memorizing the way the light stitching looked against her dark jeans. Once again, jealousy plucked along my spine—only this time, there was something more. Something I didn’t quite understand.

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We switched to wine over dinner, and that’s when I learned just how much of a light-weight I’d become. It’s not that Erin and I never drank alcohol anymore. I had the occasional beer after work, and we’d open a bottle of wine on the weekends now and then. But over dinner with the Hughes, I swear we downed four bottles of red by the night’s end.

We ended up putting the kids down at the Hughes’ home. Normally, Erin and I used the kids as a convenient excuse to leave these dinner parties at a reasonable hour, but we hadn’t settled down to eat until later than usual, and by the time we were finishing up our meal, we weren’t ready to go home yet.

Or Erin wasn’t, anyway, and after spending the last few hours seeing her in a new light, I wasn’t ready to leave, either. She looked beautiful with her hair down—something she rarely did these days. I found myself mesmerized by the way her dark hair fell in waves around her face, and the way she’d rake it back as she listened to something Haley or Lucas said.

“...and I walked in to find her getting tag-teamed by a couple of her bodyguards. It was insane. She was on all

fours, one guy stuffed down her throat as the other took her from behind. I don't think she even saw me."

Erin released a shocked laugh, covering her mouth. "No way!"

"She had a good body, too, although not as good as either of you."

Lucas was finishing up a story from a contract he had last year: working private security for some young popstar's last tour. Apparently this vixen wasn't as sweet and innocent as her carefully groomed public persona.

"I can't believe she had it in her," Erin said as Lucas refilled his glass first, then hers.

"You'd be surprised at some of the stuff we've seen."

"Like what else?" Erin asked. She'd been known to read her fair share of celebrity gossip—we had a subscription to US Weekly, after all—so was eating this stuff up. It wasn't lost on me that Lucas didn't seem to mind being on the receiving end of my wife's deep green eyes. I went for my glass as I tried to decide how I felt about that and found it empty.

"Should I open another?" I asked.

"Go for it, man. There's more in the kitchen. Bottle opener's in the top drawer next to the fridge."

I suppressed my annoyance at being dismissed like that and stood. Haley stood with me. "I'm going to check on the kids. Make sure they're actually sleeping up there."

"Thanks, Hails," Erin said, making no move to join her.

Now, I wasn't exactly leaving Erin alone with Lucas—the kitchen and dining room shared an open floor plan, and as expansive as the room was, they were still within sight. Still, I *felt* disconnected for a moment, standing on the opposite side of the space as Erin and Lucas seemed to lean into one another, him regaling her with whatever scandalous tale he had next. Every time she laughed, my gut clenched. And yet...

It had been a long time since I'd thought of Erin as a *babe*. She'd definitely been that once, the first time I'd met her at the local dentist's office: me sitting in that chair, her scraping at my teeth. A mask covered her mouth, but I still remember looking up into those large, green eyes and thinking: I want that. This was long before either of us had thoughts of careers or family, when we were young and reckless. And when I saw her as I checked out, clad in blue scrubs that didn't hide her slender body, I'd never been so happy to have cavities; I booked a filling the next week.

Not that she was easy. Even after getting a date, Erin made me work for it. When we finally slept together a couple months later, I was madly in love.

Now, as I struggled to work the cork off another bottle of pinot noir, it was Lucas falling into those large green eyes and infectious laugh. And as jealous as it made me feel, Erin's emergent beauty stunned me even more. I wanted to drag her home and fuck her silly. Instead, I struggled to open the wine.

"Here, let me."

I gasped. "Haley, I didn't hear you come down."

"I'm quiet like that." She took the bottle from me and made deft work of the cork.

Across the room, Erin covered her mouth again, shouting, "Shut up!"

To me, Haley whispered, "I'm glad someone else is here to absorb his stories."

I said, "Well, they're certainly more interesting than the stories I bring home from the office. Commercial real estate isn't the most scandalous profession."

"Well, don't worry, most of Lucas's stories are bullshit."

The blonde delivered the criticism with grace, like she was telling me that it was supposed to rain tomorrow. She passed no judgment beyond a smile that touched the corners of her lips. That's what I liked about Haley: she'd remain calm even in a crisis.

"It doesn't make you jealous? Seeing them like that?"

She raised an eyebrow. "Should I be worried?"

"Of course not."

"Lucas is a flirt, and Erin can take care of herself," Haley said.

At that moment, Erin looked over at us. "What are you two whispering about?" she shouted. "Still trying to figure out how to open that bottle?"

"He was struggling until I helped him," Haley said, sweeping up the bottle and rejoining the table.

"Sounds about right," Erin said with a nod.

My mind was still swirling. I stumbled after. "I can do *some* things myself."

Erin was quick with her reply. "You should start by remembering to put your pants back in your dresser then. And maybe make the bed from time to time."

Beside her, Lucas mouthed an *ouch* to me. I just laughed it off. "I said I could do *some* things. I'm not some kind of wizard."

Everyone laughed.

*

"So did you have fun tonight?" Erin asked as we ambled home. It was well past two in the morning. I couldn't remember the last time we'd been out so late—definitely not since Mary was born, and probably before Martin. We'd left the kids in bed at the Hughes's rather than wake them. Hopefully one of us would be sober enough to pick them up in the morning.

I slipped my hand into hers and sucked in the crisp night air. I could smell the blossoming flowers and the sweet smell of freshly cut grass. It reminded me of times long past, when I walked her back to her apartment after a long night out. "Yeah, I did."

"Told you it wouldn't be so bad."

"I'm still not a huge fan of Lucas."

"No?"

"You like him?" My incredulous question came with a sizzle of jealousy.

"He's got nice teeth."

"Once a dental hygienist, always the dental hygienist, huh?"

Erin giggled. "Well, he does! But I know what you mean. He sure likes to talk about himself, doesn't he?"

Hearing Erin say that was comforting. Still, I couldn't help teasing her about it. "You seemed to be eating up his BS."

"Well, you have to admit that some of those stories were pretty crazy."

"You mean how he chased that assailant down through a snowstorm in New York as he made off with that woman's purse?" I said.

"Well, some of it may be a little embellished."

I stopped and pulled her into my arms. "I'll embellish *you*."

Erin giggled. "That doesn't even make sense."

Rather than answer, I kissed her. She tasted like wine and strawberries. She felt good in my arms.

"I love you," I said when our lips parted.

"I love you, too."

"You know, the kids aren't home, and it's been a long time since we've done it in the living room."

Erin touched my face. "I like the way you think, Tom."

*

"Oh Tom. Oh yes!"

I squeezed Erin's hips as I drove into her from behind. I had her bent over the arm of the sofa, naked but for her lavender bra—a bra that matched a thong that I recognized without ever noticing. As we'd kissed and tugged at our

clothing across the living room floor, I swore I'd never take her pretty underthings for granted again. Digging my thumbs into her buttocks, I wondered how such a beautiful ass in a plunging thong could have become so commonplace.

"Erin, you're so sexy..."

She moaned in response, bending deeper over the armrest. She clutched at one of the seat cushions, bowing it back as I fucked her harder. "That feels...so good...Tom!"

She was close. I could hear it in the cadence of her hurried breaths. Eight years of marriage and it was easy to recognize. I rose onto my toes, shifting the angle of my thrusts to drive across her g-spot. A few rapid strokes and she was there.

"Oh, Tom! Tom!"

My breath caught as I thought of the kids sleeping upstairs, only to remember they were blocks away.

"Uh! UH!" She groaned, loud and rapid. I drove hard, synchronizing with her cries. Our skin slapped. I felt my balls seize and bit my lip to keep from coming. The room spun around us, from lust and the buzz of booze. Erin turned her head to the side, fighting to breathe as she came.

I nearly joined her. I could feel the walls of her pussy quiver around me, coaxing me toward sweet relief, but somehow, I staved it off.

"You didn't come," she said.

I withdrew. "Not yet."

Pulling her to a stand, I kissed her wetly as I unfastened her bra. My hand drifted down between her thighs, brushing through her soft, dark curls, now moist with her excitement. I kissed along her neck, feeling her sigh against my lips as I worked my fingers inside her.

"Oh, Tom, that's so good."

"God, Erin, you're so sexy."

I closed my mouth over a nipple, feeling it tighten into a hard knot as I swirled my tongue around it. She rocked her

head back, her breath catching.

"Come on, let's get more comfortable," I whispered.

Directing her to sit with her ass on the edge of the sofa, she followed my lead. With a coquettish smile, she opened her legs, setting a foot up on the edge of the cushion.

A coil of hair caught in the perspiration of her jaw, a paradox of innocence against her wanton pose. I surveyed her body, shimmering like satin in the darkness of our living room. Her breasts rose and fell above the hint of her ribs and the sweep of her flat stomach. I could just make out the startling pink of her pussy through her pubic thatch, and for a charged moment, I considered crawling between her legs and going down on her. How long had it been since I'd done that?

But my cock had other plans as it took over. Her body was too much of a temptation to tease any longer, and when I looked up at her bright eyes, I knew I wouldn't get a more obvious invitation.

"Uh, Erin, you feel so good." I sank back into her already primed pussy. Her arms enveloped me, one hand bracing against the nape of my neck as the other clutched my shoulder.

"That's it, Tom." Her voice was barely a whisper. "Fuck me. Fuck me."

Looking down at her, her eyes were closed, her head resting on the back of the sofa as she welcomed my driving hips. In that moment, for whatever reason, a crazy thought jumped into my head: Was it me she was thinking about? Or was it Lucas?

He's got nice teeth.

And out of nowhere, my balls seized with my ragged breath. I barked out a grunt as my orgasm ambushed me. Behind my tightly shut eyes, it was Lucas pounding Erin into the sofa. It was Lucas's neck Erin's nails were digging into. It was Lucas fucking my wife.

"Jesus, that was intense," Erin huffed when it was over.

“Did you come?”

“No, but I’m okay. You took pretty good care of me already.”

I felt bad about leaving her hanging. I started to withdraw, but she grabbed me. “Hold on, Tom. We don’t want to leave a stain on the \$2,000 sofa.”

And with that, adulthood and reality returned. We had a family. We had appearances to keep up. We had responsibility. The logistics of extracting myself from my wife without leaving a pool of come on our expensive things killed the last of the charged mood.

Still, I couldn’t help but feel like something had shifted, ever so slightly.

“Two days in a row,” I said as we gathered our clothes and carried them upstairs.

“I know, right? I could get used to this. I love you, Tom. Tonight was fun.”

I nodded in agreement, pushing back that niggling feeling that something had changed. Tomorrow. I’d deal with it tomorrow. Right now, I just wanted to sleep.

“Come on, we can clean up in the morning.”

And with that, we dragged our tattered selves to bed.

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THREE

I didn't deal with that niggling feeling the next day. In fact, I completely forgot about it until the following Tuesday night, when Erin came home from the gym, exhausted yet oddly desirable.

"Good workout?"

Erin sighed heavily and dropped her gym bag at her feet. "AJ says it gets easier, but I think he's full of it."

AJ. Her personal trainer. Her *male* personal trainer. His name hit me like a lance in my gut.

"He's supposed to push you."

"I think he's trying to kill me."

I gave her a once over. She looked good in her tight, black pants and turquoise, racerback tank top—taller, for some reason, although maybe it was just the outfit.

"Well, it's worth the risk."

"You *would* think that. Did you have any trouble with the kids?"

"They were fine. Stop worrying. I'm a pro now." I didn't mention how long Mary called out for *mommy*. She wouldn't remember in the morning.

"A pro, huh? Let's not go too far until you've spent a few days home alone with them." She picked her bag back up. "I'm going to take a shower."

I watched her drag herself over to the stairs. When she paused and looked over her shoulder, she caught me looking at her ass and smirked. For a second, I thought she was going to ask me to join.

The moment passed and she moved on her way, an extra wiggle in her hips.

I sat there in front of the TV as it splashed multi-hued colors across my face. People talked. Plots started to resolve. There may have been a foot chase. But I saw none

of it. Instead, something that Lucas had said last week crawled out of the dark corner of my brain: *A chick like Erin in a room full of guys who only care about image? She probably gets hit on all the time.*

I didn't even need to close my eyes to see her ass and the way her black workout pants molded to it. Did everyone else in the room notice that, too? Did AJ?

Even as the question released a swarm of something squirmy in my gut, I felt a new tingle—like the heat of a fire just before it burned. It sizzled across my scalp. When I stood and shut off the television, I realized that my cock had begun to thicken.

Shame crashed around me. I looked around, like there was someone in my living room, ready to point and laugh. Like I was in middle school, caught daydreaming about the teacher.

"No," I said to no one. "Just...no."

Upstairs, I could hear the hiss of the shower and the splash of water as it rolled off Erin's body in sheets. She was humming something I could just barely hear under the spray. I paused at the door, my hand at the knob as I considered joining her once more, when the pitch of her voice changed.

My heart skipped a beat. My ears perked up. I stopped breathing to listen, and it came again.

"Uh..."

Water slopped over the tiles. The hissing shower drowned out almost everything, but—

"Ngh..."

But I could hear Erin moaning. I knew that sound better than anyone, but I'd never heard it when I wasn't there. I listened harder, pressing my ear against the door. Filtering out the rush of water through the pipes, I could just hear her faintly: Erin's heavy breathing coming in short rhythmic bursts.

My cock surged. My heart hammered away. I closed my eyes and imagined her in there, water racing around her naked body, one hand working her nipple, the other between her legs. We'd done the mutual masturbation thing before, and I knew she wasn't a stranger to self-pleasure, but I'd never caught her doing it.

A gasp leaked through the door, like a valve releasing pressure. "Haa..."

What was she thinking about? The gym? The attention of other men?

She probably gets hit on all the time.

"No." My voice, quiet as it was, immediately silenced Erin's moans. I froze. Embarrassment lit up my face—not for being caught listening in on Erin, but for Erin being caught.

Slowly, I stepped away, careful to avoid the creak of the hardwood floors. I don't think I breathed until I was on the opposite side of the room. I glanced at the door to the bathroom. The splashing sound was gone; only the steady spray of water remained; Erin was just as frozen as I was.

Raising my voice so she could hear me, I spoke before I could fully think things through. "No, tomorrow's fine. I can definitely have a report prepared by then."

I even held my phone to my ear, keeping up the ruse as if Erin could see through the door.

The splashing returned. Erin had bought it. Hopefully she'd think I'd been on the phone the whole time and that her secret was still a secret. A moment later, she shut the water off. She was back to humming a song—back to the old Erin.

When she emerged from the bathroom, pink and fresh, I was in bed.

"So how was work?" she asked, turning her back to me as she dropped the robe. We were back to modesty.

"Busy. Full of meetings. I've got a thing out in Woodbridge tomorrow." It wasn't a lie—I did have a meeting

out in the Virginia exurbs—but it also reinforced my fake phone conversation.

Erin nodded at the lie. I felt terrible.

“Make sure you’ve got enough gas.” She pulled on her pajama bottoms. I caught a flash of the side of her breast before the top went on. Crawling into bed, she kissed me sweetly. “I love you, Tom.”

And I loved her smile. “Love you, too.”

She’d already reached for her Kindle.

*

I’m not sure when I fell asleep, but it was long after Erin had turned out her light and rolled away. I listened to her breathing in the dark, rolling close and spooning up behind her. She felt the same as she always had—same fruity aroma in her drying hair, her sleeping body too hot to hold for long. But I’d just heard her playing with herself in the shower. That changed everything.

I rolled onto my back as my erection formed. What had she been thinking about? *Who* had she been thinking about?

In the dark, I saw her at the gym, wearing the same dark pants and bright turquoise top. In my imagination, she was with her personal trainer—a faceless young man in a City Fitness blue polo shirt; he stood behind her, showing her how to do a proper squat, his hands sliding across her bare arms and out the flare of her hips. In my mind, he was tall and fit with the body of a triathlete, not a body builder; his hair color shifted, sandy brown to dark to shaved, but the sexual chemistry between him and my wife remained constant.

Was she thinking about him in the shower? I thought back to last week, when we’d made love for the first time in a while—which was coincidentally the same night as her first session with AJ. The jealousy arrived, but so did something else—something that I didn’t want to admit to,

but made me hard—made me want to reach between my legs and touch myself.

Eventually, I got to sleep. I think. One moment, I was racked by jealousy and lust. The next, the morning light was streaming through the windows and I was alone in the bed. Downstairs, I heard Erin with the children. I groaned and checked the time. I was going to be late for work.

*

I try to work out during lunch on Mondays, Tuesdays, and Wednesdays. Not only is it a nice break from the office, but I wasn't about to let Erin watch me soften up as she got toned. I knew how that story usually went.

Only the day after I'd heard her in the shower—a Wednesday—I considered skipping. It was juvenile, I know, but according to Erin, AJ primarily worked downtown—at the gym I went to. The prospect of actually meeting him felt too real.

So I kept putting it off, hoping that someone would fill my lunch hour with an unplanned conference call or meeting. When none materialized, I still considered just grabbing lunch and eating in my office when I realized how silly I was being.

The downtown location of City Fitness was smaller than the one out in the 'burbs, where Erin went. Due to spacing issues, it was split across four floors, the weights divided on the lower two, cardio and the studios up higher, where large windows looked out over the street below. It also didn't have the full range of amenities—no Olympic-size pool or climbing wall, of course—but with its location, it served office workers during the day and college kids in the evening. If I were to zone a gym space—something I've done before—I'd go with this spot every time.

Only on this visit, I wasn't thinking about the gym's location, or how few machines were available at this hour,

or its lack of amenities. All I saw were the blue polo shirts of the City Fitness employees. They were everywhere, a swarm of azure in the crowded space.

The cute blonde behind the desk smiled at me as I swiped in. “Afternoon,” she said.

“Afternoon.”

She went back to talking to the guy beside her, a man with shaggy hair that hung over his face. He was handsome in a grungy sort of way, lean and broad-shouldered. Could he be AJ? Was he Erin’s type?

I moved on before the guy caught me studying him. It only took one sweep of the room to realize that potential AJs were everywhere. I started sizing them up as I went about my workout, trying to figure out who fit my idea of *AJ* based on what little I knew.

He went by AJ. What kind of person goes by their initials? Someone cocky, for sure, with a bit of jock in him. Someone who was as skilled at catching a beer can in one hand as he was at talking to women. Most of the guys in blue fit that mold—they worked in a gym, after all.

Digging deeper, I thought about background. Sounded like he was good at his job—he didn’t just work at the gym, after all, he was a personal trainer. Probably college educated with a degree in sports medicine, or something like that. A brainy jock. That started sounding more like someone Erin would be into, but that didn’t help me much with my search: did the blonde guy folding towels look like a college grad? Or maybe the dude with the goatee looked like the type of person who’d go into sports medicine to meet girls?

None of it helped, so I went into what I thought was Erin’s type. Tall and handsome were a given, and I couldn’t shake the hunch that he was more athletic than muscle-bound. Erin had never been impressed with the body-builder type—guys who spent more time on weight-lifting than cardio. Still, that left most of the male employees in the gym

—and there was a good chance that AJ wasn't even working now.

A few people had personal trainers with them, although not as many as I imagined in the evening. What surprised me were how many pairings were mixed gender: female PTs putting out-of-shape guys through the paces, and vice-versa. I watched the male trainers closest of all. These guys really could be AJs, and all fit Erin's *ideal type*, as determined by me.

My stomach roiled with nervous energy, but even more uncomfortable was the semi-erect state I was stuck in. I didn't want to give anyone the wrong impression—especially since I seemed to be staring at the dudes more than the chicks—so I cut my workout short and jumped in the sauna.

I don't remember working out, although I must have done something because my arms and chest were screaming as I stood from my last machine. On my way to the locker room again, I passed through the cool-down area. Mats were spread out as men and women stretched and relaxed, preparing their minds to return to the working world. I'd tried that a couple of times, but found the sauna much more effective for me.

One of the personal trainer/trainee duos I'd been watching was stretching as I walked by. I'd ruled him out—he was just a little too bulky to be someone Erin would be into, although he had a carved-in-stone handsomeness that women probably liked. He stood above his trainee, an attractive blonde just a few pounds on the heavy side, as he worked her muscles. Holding her sneaker-clad foot against his body, he leaned across her, stretching her quads as he worked a hand down her calf. She closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

"Just relax. Let's get that tightness out," the trainer said. His voice was a pitch higher than seemed right for his body. He switched legs.

“God, that feels so good,” the woman said, making eyes up at her trainer.

This time, as he lunged forward to stretch her legs, I thought of Erin in this same position with her AJ. Did she stare up at him like that? Did the motion look so sexual with my own wife?

I shook my head and pushed into the locker room, doing my best to banish those thoughts and get back into work mode. Unfortunately, even the sauna didn’t help. I carried the vision of that trainer stretching Erin—it was now firmly Erin in my head—and the way they looked at each other, a secret in the middle of everyone.

Back in the office, I fought the temptation to go onto City Fitness’s website and look him up. I was having a hard enough time reminding myself that AJ was Erin’s trainer, nothing more. My imagination was running rampant; I didn’t need to help it along by looking up what the guy looked like.

*

And then Erin came home from the gym Thursday evening, looked right at me from the doorway, and shot me a smile that promised sex—the kind of smile I hadn’t seen curl her lips in years.

“Good workout?”

“Uh huh.” She bit her lip and looked towards the stairs. “I need a shower. Want to join me?”

I’d spent all evening trying *not* to think about Erin being stretched by AJ, and by extension, fighting back a rising excitement that I still refused to acknowledge. Did I want to join her in the shower? I didn’t need to be asked twice.

My cock was hard before I even reached the bathroom. Luckily, I could easily blame it on my wife as she peeled off her black workout pants.

“Very nice,” I said, tracing her cotton thong with my hand.

“Don’t want VPLs. You taught me that, I believe.”

I pulled the edge of the panties down her hip. “You could just go commando.”

“Uh huh.” She pulled her sports bra off, her breasts bouncing into view, high and ripe.

I stepped into her, close enough to feel her body against mine. We kissed as I filled one hand with a breast and pushed my other inside her thong. She was wet, the soft mat of curls slippery even before I reached her slit.

“Uhh...” Erin broke our kiss, turning her head away to bare her neck. I took the offering, tasting her sweat as I ran my tongue up her supple column. Inside her panties, I slipped two fingers into her slick embrace, drawing a louder moan.

“You’re so wet,” I whispered.

Erin didn’t say anything immediately, although I wasn’t sure what kind of response I expected. After a couple pumps of my fingers, she took a deep, steadying breath. “It’s been almost a week...”

After eight years of marriage, a week’s abstinence was nothing, but I felt the same way as her. We hadn’t had sex since our drunken session after the Hughes’s barbecue. That felt like ages ago.

Erin pulled me close, balancing on my hand as I fingered her and kissed her neck. Her moans and gasps reminded me of Tuesday night, when I’d heard them come from the shower—when she’d taken matters into her own hands. It lit a fire inside of me.

“You’re incredible.” I ground my palm against her clit and nipped at her ear. She quivered against me, an escaping moan encouraging me to work her faster. Her eyes were shut tight, her mouth open. I twisted my fingers inside her and found her clit with my thumb. She gnashed her teeth. Her moans grew sharp.

Who was she thinking about? Me? Or someone else? Was she really so wet because it had been a week?

Erin's body collapsed in my arms as she came, a marionette with her strings cut. I caught her, holding her lissome body against me as she drew long, ragged breaths. When she recovered, she attacked me with a ferocity I wasn't expecting. There was no *thank you* in that kiss, no *that was nice*. Her orgasm had been just a beginning, and as she tore my clothes off and pulled me under the hiss of the shower, the real excitement began.

The hot spray washed the exertion from her toned curves, turning her skin slick. I groped her, cupping her ass with one hand as I palmed a breast with the other.

Erin reached down and circled my erection. "You're so hard."

"Your fault."

"After all these years, I'm surprised I can still do this to you."

I groaned as she pumped me a few times. "You're crazy."

"Maybe a little." To my shock, she dropped to her knees and looked up at me. "Nothing wrong with a little crazy, right?"

She took me into her mouth before I could form the words. I had to reach behind and splay a hand along the tiled wall to keep my balance. She hadn't gone down on me since Mary was born. Not that I was complaining—she hadn't lost her technique in all that time.

After a few bobs, she angled my cock against my abdomen and ran her tongue along my balls. I grunted as she sucked away and switched to the other. If it had been a while since she'd given me a blowjob, it had been forever since she'd sucked my balls.

"God, Erin, I can't take much more of this."

"Good," she said, then swallowed my length back into her mouth.

Christ, she was hot. How many guys wished they could see her like this, her lips wrapped around their cocks, her

cheeks hollowed and those gorgeous green eyes looking up at them? How many at the gym had fantasized about it tonight?

That thought nearly did me in. My world rumbled. It took me a second to realize that was me. Moaning. I tore my gaze away from Erin, looking up and forcing my thoughts to other things: like the way the steam condensed along the ceiling, or that it would soon be time to repaint the walls.

Erin's mouth and the wicked swirl of her tongue brought me back. Even the slurp and squish of her jacking hand along my cock teased me closer to orgasm. I cast my mind away again, to a time when Erin used to do this all the time. To a time when she'd admitted to me how much she loved giving head when she was really worked up. At the time, I thought it was odd, since most people preferred to receive pleasure than give it. Now, all I could think was: what made her so horny?

And like that, I was back at the gym again, imagining some fit and faceless trainer working Erin through her post-workout stretches. His touches turning her on; the way she'd looked up from the floor and see a hot young man with lust in his eyes.

Without more warning than a quick grunt, I exploded down her throat. She pulled back after two bursts, letting me spray the wall behind her with my come. All those dangerous, forbidden thoughts were released with it. As I sank to a crouch, guilt and embarrassment joined me on the floor.

Erin snuggled close and kissed me on the corner of my jaw. "That was fun."

Relief filled me. She didn't know what I'd been thinking. My secret was safe.

"So what was that for?"

Erin stood, a smile from ear to ear. She pushed her damp locks back, reaching for her loofah. "Just paying you back. We need to do that more often."

“You won’t hear any complaints from me.”

“I better not,” she said with a laugh. “Want to soap up my back?”

She started soaping her body, rinsing away the last of both this workout and the real one. She rose like a goddess over me, curves where it counted, lean muscle and supple skin filling in the rest.

Suds raced through her cleavage and across the flat plane of her stomach. I traced my hands along her legs as I stood. Between her thighs, soap mixed with her excitement, making it easy to dip my fingers back into her sex.

Lined up, face-to-face once again, I wanted to just come out and ask her about the night: *why are you so worked up? or were you thinking about your personal trainer just now?*

Instead, I turned her away, took the loofah from her hands, and scrubbed it down her long spine. Without her looking at me, though, I took a risk. “I bet all the guys at the gym couldn’t take their eyes off you.”

She laughed, half-looking over her shoulder. “Doubt that. I’m old. You should see some of these girls who go in there.”

I swished the sponge back and forth between her shoulder blades. The rivers of soapy water detoured into the divots of her lower-back dimples. Fuck, I loved lower-back dimples, and I loved them on my wife even more.

“Please, they’ve got nothing on you.”

“They’ve got perkier boobs. I can’t compete with that after two kids.”

I dropped the loofah and reached around her, scooping her tits into my hand. They were still soapy, the warm flesh soft and swollen beneath my fingers. I sought out her nipples, finding them hard. “I think you compete just fine.”

I thought about Erin in her tight workout clothes, moving about the machines; I knew where my eyes would have been. Sure, the gym was filled with hot and hard-bodied twenty-somethings, but it was always the more mature

women who drew my attention—the wives and young mothers. For the younger chicks, those bodies came effortlessly. For women like Erin, their drive to stay in shape was as sexy as the results.

I seriously doubted that I was alone in thinking that.

“Are you hard again?”

Sure enough, I was, my erection nudging along the valley of her ass. My face grew hot. I choked back embarrassment, thankful that she was facing away.

“Just thinking about you at the gym. I wish I could watch that.”

“Yeah right.”

“Don’t believe me? I swear, this is all for you.”

I bent my knees, steadied my cock with a hand, and rose. My cock slid smoothly into her overheated pussy.

“Oh!” Erin flattened her upper body against the wall, lifted up onto her toes, and rolled her hips back into me. I guided her as we worked through the awkward logistics.

Erin pushed her wet hair out of her face as I eased her legs further from the wall, giving me a better angle to enter her from behind. The shower spray hit me in the face, sending water up my nose before I could look away and readjust. Our angle shifted again, putting pressure against Erin’s g-spot.

“God, you feel huge like this.” Her words tumbled out, half a laugh, half a sigh.

“And you’re so tight.”

“Feels...so good.”

And it felt even better as I began to pump her. I started slowly, worried that the constant flow of water would wash away our slick connection. It only took a moment to realize that both of us were more than horny enough to keep up.

Erin’s hands, forearms, and elbows formed a triangle above her head, bracing herself against my slapping onslaught. The rest of her swooped down and away, her

long torso demonstrating a flexibility that only served to remind me of her post-workout stretches.

I placed a hand on her lower back and the other on her shoulder, helping her bow down more. *That's it, that's it.* I imagined being Erin's personal trainer. Being AJ. Was this what he thought about as he worked his hands over her muscles? And what about my wife?

"Uh, Tom, I'm—" The rest of her sentence was lost in a throaty hiss.

I pushed on her back harder. My fingers dug into her shoulder, pinning her there as I fucked her through those final moments. Our wet skin clapped together as water splashed around us. Beneath it, I heard her moan—heard my own moans. My throat was raw from it.

I took a deep breath, intending to say something—*I love you, you feel so good, you're so fucking hot.* Whatever it was, I lost it in a flash as my balls crashed one last time along the padded rise of her mound. I pushed myself as deep as I could, arching back as if to roar. The water raked across my face and chest, but it was too late to stop me. I was there, releasing my second load of the night.

We met on the floor of the shower again, tangled up in each other. This time, recovery didn't arrive quite so swiftly.

"My legs are on fire," I said.

"I bet." She touched my quads. "A practical demonstration of why squats are so important."

I laughed. "I may have to skip the gym tomorrow. Not sure I need it after tonight."

Erin reached out and traced up my arms and over my shoulders. "You're looking good. Have I told you lately?"

Erin's compliment washed over me, warmer than the shower above. "I have to keep up. I've got a room full of hot, young guys to compete with, not to mention your trainer."

Erin laughed, but I swore I saw something pass across her face. "Don't be silly. They've got nothing on you."

I wanted to continue this conversation, but I also wanted to be done with the shower. "I'm all pruny and I think the hot water is about to go."

Erin kissed me softly. "Thanks for helping me wash my back."

"Any time."

By the time we were ready for bed, we were *ready for bed*. Any further conversation would have to wait.

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FOUR

When morning came and I dragged myself into the shower for work, I thought of our encounter again, and again the idea of Erin on her back on a mat with her faceless trainer brought a flutter to my heart and strength to my cock.

I just couldn't muster the courage to bring it up over oatmeal and coffee. Or later that evening, when we parked ourselves in front of the television and started clearing space off our DVR. And as weekday yielded to a weekend filled with family fun, and I watched Erin chase Martin up a nature trail with Mary perched on my back, I decided to put the whole conversation on hold.

For a couple weeks, I did. Then Erin's college friend Josephine visited.

Jo was yang to Erin's yin. We all have these types of friends: individuals who act as foils more than anything. She was a wild child in the truest sense: raised by hippies who drank with her in high school and supplied her first joint. These stories make me cringe as a parent, but Jo turned out alright in the end. She landed a job in an advertising firm and worked her way up to VP, and did it all in less time than any of her peers.

I'd say she'd mellowed, too, but I knew otherwise.

"Hey, girl, you look fantastic!" Jo bellowed from the airport terminal. The vivacious blonde wrapped Erin in a bear hug and squeezed my laughing wife. "It's been too long. Too *fucking* long."

"Shh, Jo. The kids," Erin chided with a laugh.

"Oh, shit, sorry." She clapped her hand over her mouth. "Sorry."

"It's good to see you, too," Erin said.

Jo turned her bright smile on me, giving me a not-so-subtle once over.

“And Tom, looking damn sexy as always.”

“Hey, Jo. Ditto to you.”

I was never quite sure how to deal with Erin’s best friend. I still remember how she’d pulled me aside during our wedding reception and said, *I wanted to give myself as a gift on your wedding night, but Erin vetoed it, the bitch*. I didn’t know how to react, as I wasn’t entirely sure that she was joking.

But my *ditto* to her wasn’t a lie. She was damn sexy. As always. Even dressed for travel, she pulled it off and still looked hot. Gray yoga pants (did I mention how much I love them?), pink zip-up hoodie, aviators pushed into her curly blonde hair, she reminded me of a model returning from some exotic photo shoot.

“God, your kids are so grown up.” Jo crouched down beside Mary and Martin, doting on them like the aunt she was not.

We piled into the minivan. I was relegated to the back with the kids so that Jo and Erin could catch up. Not that I minded. Since Erin stayed home with the kids, she didn’t get a whole lot of adult interaction. This visit from Jo would be good for her.

*

“So we all set to go out tonight?” Jo asked Erin over dinner. It was Friday night and Erin had mentioned that they were getting a drink somewhere. At the time, I hadn’t thought much of it.

“All set,” Erin said. “I just need to help get the kids ready, and change.”

“Awesome. Have you heard about Chic?”

Erin shook her head. “If it doesn’t have to do with kids, then I have no idea. I’m a little out of touch on the bar scene.”

"It most definitely has nothing to do with kids. It just opened downtown. Supposed to be one of the hottest new clubs in the area."

"Doesn't sound like a jeans and t-shirt kind of place."

"Oh, Erin." Jo laughed. "No, not jeans and a t-shirt place, unless you're talking designer. But don't worry about it. I'm sure we can find something appropriate for you to wear. You need to show that body off, anyway."

That's about when my ears perked up. Just what did Jo have in mind?

Erin and I went through the bedtime routine for Mary before she left me to get ready. I got Martin into his PJs and tucked him in, and was done before Erin.

I went to check on her when I heard Erin and Jo laughing hysterically. "I can't wear that!"

I left them alone, descending the stairs like a zombie, lost in my head.

Erin was going out to some trendy new club.

Without me.

And there would probably be guys there.

And she would probably dance with them.

Each separate thought ratcheted up the tightness around my chest. I felt jealous. I felt confused. But most strongly, I felt aroused.

When Erin and Jo finally emerged, all three of those emotions amplified a hundred fold.

"Wow. You look...wow."

Erin turned to Jo. "See? I can't wear this."

"Why not? You look awesome," Jo said.

For a second, I didn't recognize her miniscule, little black dress. When I did, I realized why: the last time she'd worn it was on our honeymoon, although I didn't remember it being quite so short. She'd paired it with the tallest black heels that she owned—killer Jimmy Choos that I'd bought for her a couple Christmases ago—a little black clutch, and her pearls.

Her face was bright red by the time my eyes made it that high. She looked at me apologetically, as if to say, *This is not my idea.*

"I think you look amazing," I said.

"I'll change."

"No way. You're going to be late if you do," I blurted out.

"It's only 9:30. There's time," Erin insisted.

"Go! Dance. Have fun. Try not to think of a poopie diaper."

Erin smiled. "Are you sure?"

"100 percent." *Really?* "I'll take the kids out tomorrow morning so you can sleep in. And there's plenty of Gatorade in the fridge."

"I love you, honey." She kissed me gingerly, careful not to smudge her lip-gloss. "I'll text you with updates."

"Don't worry about me. Just have fun. You remember how?"

Jo, who was looking just as hot in her red dress, wrapped her arm around my wife and smiled. "Don't worry. I'll be there to help remind her."

And with that statement, I was left alone, fully charged with my mixed emotions and little hope for sleep.

*

First thing I did was pour myself a glass of Scotch. Tonight was a Scotch drinking night if ever there was one. Second thing I did was attempt to wrestle with this dark fantasy I'd been trying to deny.

Erin had always received attention from guys. Sometimes it made me jealous, but most of the time I barely noticed it. She was a beautiful woman; it would have been exhausting to react every time a guy looked twice at her. In a lot of ways, the fact that my wife received so much attention was flattering to me because in the end, she'd chosen me over all the others.

Now...now I couldn't *stop* thinking about every time a guy looked at her twice. And every time, it felt like touching a live nerve. In that black dress and without a man at her side, she'd be getting attention all night long. Guys would be falling over themselves to buy her a drink, or get her out on the dance floor. To pull her close as she shimmied her tight body against them.

My chest tightened. I took another sip and ran my hand through my hair. It came away damp.

"Cool it, man," I said to no one.

I tried to go about this logically. I was getting turned on by the thought of other men wanting my wife. In the past, while I'd felt some jealousy, I'd also felt pride to have a wife like Erin when they looked. Only now, it turned me on to think of something more happening. So was this fantasy just an amped up, twisted ego trip for me? If she went out there and fooled around with another guy...

"You're insane, buddy."

Despite my words, my thoughts tumbled on. If she went out there tonight, had fun with some random guys, and came home to me at the end of the night, wouldn't that be even more validating than a few stares as she walked down the street?

Sure, but it also made me a giant asshole. Erin was more than just an accessory to my masculinity. She wasn't a trophy wife. She was my partner. My equal in everything. I didn't marry her because she was hot—although maybe that's why I was initially attracted to her; I married her because she had a personality behind her smile. She had her own interests, her own opinions, and together, we made a great team.

Maybe that had something to do with it. Since the kids, her world had narrowed to Sesame Street and finger painting. I was happy to see her get back into the adult world again, even if that adult world included other men's interest in her.

I got my first text an hour after they left.

-long line. we just got in. i definitely don't feel cool enough to be here.

When was the last time we'd waited in line to get into a club? I thought of the two of them standing outside in their little dresses. Maybe there were a couple of guys behind them, checking them out. Maybe after the first half hour, the guys started chatting them up.

-just follow jo's lead. you'll be fine.

I knew that was bad advice, but the Scotch started having an effect on me. I felt the buzz of adrenaline join the boozy one. I started typing a second line even before Erin texted back her *OK*.

-and honey, i really do want you to have fun. you're single tonight. i promise I won't get jealous.

Her response came a full minute later.

-OK

And that was it for the next two hours.

Talk about pins and fucking needles. *Promise I won't get jealous?* How could I promise that when I felt jealousy's acidic arrival even as I typed it? I moved my things to the deck off the back of our house, needing to get some fresh air.

Out in the suburbs, you could just make out the stars through the light pollution of the city. She wasn't so far away. It had cooled off since sunset, but it was still early summer, when it never actually got cold. Crickets chirped in the grass. Cicadas hummed in the trees. The world kept turning.

Erin loved me. I had no doubt about that. Did that change if she let some guys flirt with her? Of course not. Dance with her? The answer was still an easy *no*.

I thought about the few times I'd been on my own over the years, out at conferences or business trips, and had a pretty young woman come on to me. It had been exhilarating, but that didn't mean I loved Erin any less. Of course, things had stopped at a few flirty words.

Did she love me any less if the guys went further? This is where things got prickly and my insides started to protest. How different was a grope on the dance floor than a flirtatious exchange? That, I could live with.

What about a kiss?

I was hard. Ignoring my erection, I lifted my glass and found it empty.

What about wandering hands? Blowjobs? What about fucking?

"Stop," I ordered the night air.

This was purely academic. She wasn't going to do any of that, so why did I insist on torturing myself with the hypotheticals?

I brushed my hand along my erection, which had hardened the more extreme my imagination got.

"Because maybe it turns you on?"

The chirping crickets didn't answer.

I went back inside, tried to drown out my thoughts with SportsCenter and an edited-for-television version of the *Matrix*. It helped a little, although the nervous buzz stayed with me, keeping sleep at bay.

Around 12:30, I got another text.

-thinking of you. love you.

What had prompted her to text that? Guilt, maybe? In front of me, Keanu Reeves ran around kicking ass in a black trench coat and I didn't see any of it.

-i love you too. hope you guys are having fun

A fast moment later, she replied.

-you're still awake! go to bed, silly. i haven't forgotten your promise to take the kids in the

morning. i'm going to NEED it!

I could almost hear the drunken excitement in her voice. She really was having fun. That, more than any other remedy I'd tried, dampened my anxiety. She was having fun, and she loved me. What was there to be afraid of?

I shut off the television and got ready for bed. I hadn't put down the mixed bag of emotions, but it felt lighter. Or maybe I was just too tired to deal with it. Either way, when I crawled into bed, I thought maybe, just maybe, I could actually get some sleep.

I must have dozed off, because the next thing I knew, I was woken up by the sound of the front door shutting, followed by shushes and giggles. They were back. I checked the clock. 3:20. Jesus.

"Shh, shh, don't wake the kids." Erin's whisper was loud enough to travel up the stairs, and her laugh louder still.

I heard their muffled exchange grow quieter. Maybe the fridge opened? I waited for them to stumble up the stairs for the next ten minutes, but they didn't emerge. By that time, I was fully awake.

Getting out of bed, I tiptoed to the door and listened. I heard their quiet conversation downstairs in the living room, punctuated by the occasional laugh. Erin was giggling more than usual, a sure sign that she wasn't sober.

Just as I was about to turn and head back to bed, Jo said something that stopped me dead in my tracks.

"So that guy was hot."

The last, sandy bits of sleep blew away with the statement. I was awake now, straining to hear Erin's reply. I wasn't able, but caught Jo a moment later.

"Come on, just because you're married doesn't make him any less attractive."

Now I had to hear the rest of this. I crept out of the bedroom to the top of the stairs, my heartbeat thundering in my ears.

Erin said, "Fine. He was hot. And a really great dancer."

"He seemed to like dancing with you, too. You two looked pretty cozy. Didn't I see him give you his number—"

"Jo..."

"What?"

My chest tightened. Jo's boisterous laugh didn't help.

"Come on, don't tell me having some crazy hot guy want you isn't fucking sexy."

"You'd know, slut."

Jo laughed. "I would... Oh come on, don't look at me like that. You loved it."

"And I shouldn't have. I feel awful now."

For a second, I thought I was going to be sick. I clutched the wall and sank to a squat on the floor. My pajama pants pulled tight, outlining the hardest erection I'd had all evening, and when my nausea passed, excitement took its place.

Jo was talking, her voice consoling.

"Then tell him. You've got nothing to hide. Didn't Tom tell you that you're single tonight? Maybe he'd even be into it."

I took a step back as my breath caught. That was a little too close to reality.

"I really doubt that."

"Hey, you never know. I've definitely been with more than one guy with that kink."

Erin said what I was thinking. "Seriously?"

"No, not *seriously*. I mean, I dated a guy who liked hearing about my encounters with other men, but it wasn't serious." She giggled. "Hand me that Gatorade. I'm going to be feeling this one tomorrow."

In the silence as she took her sip, I tried to process what she was saying. I knew this fantasy wasn't unique to me, but it was still new to me. More than anything, though, I wondered what Erin thought of it.

"We weren't exclusive, of course. I thought it was pretty hot, honestly, but after a while, he became fixated on the idea. That got annoying."

"To watch you with another man?"

"Yeah."

"So you broke up with him before that?"

"No, I set it up. He watched from the closet as I brought another man home and fucked him. Jesus, it makes me horny just thinking about it. I mean, I love sex—you know that. But knowing he was in there watching me made it even crazier."

Was I really hearing this? Or was this a dream and I'd wake up any moment back in bed?

"You really are a slut."

"Hey now, don't judge. You know you love hearing my stories."

"I'm sorry. I do. It's just...that's a crazy story!"

The women laughed, then quickly muffled the noise as though realizing they'd gotten loud once again.

"I don't think that's Tom, though. He's not...I don't know the right word. *Open-minded* isn't quite right, but...that just seems too out there." She paused. "He can get pretty jealous."

I could?

"Oh, there was jealousy with my watcher friend, too. Actually, that's why we broke up in the end. After that encounter, he just couldn't handle it."

"I'm sorry," Erin said.

"Don't be. It had run its course, anyway, and I got a fucking wicked experience out of it."

More silence. More time for my thoughts to fumble in the dark. So it hadn't worked out. What had been a fun fantasy had been the end of them. I needed to remember that before things got out of hand.

"Thanks again for tonight. It was great. I haven't had that much fun since before the kids."

"Do I need to have a conversation with Tom?" Jo said.

"Nah, that's not what I mean. My friends these days are my mom friends. We go on playdates, not out clubbing. They're in a different place, you know?"

"*You're* in a different place, too, Erin. You've got a good thing here. Sometimes, I get a little envious of it."

"Now I know you're lying."

"Seriously. It gets lonely out there. Don't take this for granted."

I heard the rustling of them getting off the couch. "There are clean towels on the bed. You know where the shower is. I'll see you in the morning."

"Night, Erin."

I faded back into the room and crept back into bed, snuggling in just before Erin entered. She moved quietly in the dark, cursing as she stubbed her toe on our dresser. She shut the bathroom door before switching on the lights and brushing her teeth.

I tried to slow my breathing, but I was too worked up to sleep. I wasn't even close when she emerged from the bedroom and slid in behind me. She was naked, I realized, feeling the soft heat of her breasts on my back.

"I love you," she whispered and kissed the back of my neck.

I turned, feigning that I'd just woken up. "You're home."

"Go back to sleep."

I ignored her. "Did you have fun?"

I brushed her dark hair from her face. Her eyes glittered in the dark. "Too much fun."

I could smell the alcohol on her breath, even beneath the mint of toothpaste.

"Did you dance with anyone?"

"With Jo..."

My heart quickened.

"...and a few random guys."

I smiled. "Lucky them."

“You’re not jealous, are you?”

I pulled her closer, pushing a knee between her thighs. “Not really, but I’ve always been there, ready to take you home.”

“I’m home now.”

“You are.”

She was wet against my knee as I pressed against her harder. Her voice came unsteadily. “I wish you’d come out with me,” she said.

I ran my fingers down her back, tracing the sweeping contour of her body. “If I had, then those random guys would’ve missed out.”

“Too bad for them,” she said.

“Admit it. Part of you liked the attention.”

“Tom—”

I silenced her with a kiss. My hand finished its tour of her body, ending at her ass. Taking hold of a taut cheek, I pulled her hips against mine, pressing her sex harder into my thigh.

“Admit it.”

“Sure,” she sighed. “Part of me liked it. But it’s not a big deal—”

“I told you, I’m not jealous. In fact, I think it’s kind of hot, too.”

She studied me, trying to determine if this was entrapment or not. I understood her confusion—it was mine, too. I blundered on, like it was me who’d had too much to drink. “So tell me truthfully, did you enjoy feeling their hands on you?”

At first, I thought she might lie. That would have been my first instinct. But Erin didn’t lie, not even to the kids when it would have been more convenient.

“It was nice.”

“Did it turn you on?”

“Tom...”

“It turns me on thinking about it.”

Again, the shock—this time from both of us. I pushed forward until she felt my cock slide across her hip. She looked down at it, then back up to me.

“Really?” she asked.

I bet you this isn't the only one you felt against you. This time, I had the sense to keep the thought to myself.

Erin curled her hand around it like it was an illusion. “It’s so hard.”

“It’s been waiting for you.”

She rolled me onto my back and mounted me. I groaned when I discovered how wet she was. She sheathed herself with little resistance.

I wanted to keep up this conversation. I wanted to keep digging for more information. What had happened with this *crazy hot guy*. What did *cozy* really mean?

I hesitated and the moment passed. She rutted over me, lost in her own thoughts. Her dark hair spilled forward, hiding her face. She bit her lip and stifled a moan as she raced to a quick orgasm.

Was she thinking of her dance partner? Or maybe AJ? Was she fantasizing about being in Jo’s shoes, fucking her boyfriend as I hid in the closet?

My balls tightened. Suddenly I couldn’t breathe hard enough. I arched back, clutching the sheets, and exploded inside Erin’s tight pussy.

“Oh, Tom...” she moaned. A hand shot between her thighs as she worked her clit furiously, joining me a moment later in bliss.

The come down was swift. With all that pent-up anxiety finally released, sleep latched onto me bodily and dragged me beneath its sweet, dark waves.

*

The next day was rough, but at least I wasn’t hung-over. I got up, left Erin passed out in the bed, and took the kids to

IHOP for breakfast. With morning light streaming through the restaurant's windows, a stack of pancakes in front of me, and two squirming kids, it was easy to pretend I hadn't said the things I'd said the night before.

But I had. And that reality was hard to dismiss. I dreaded the conversation that waited for me at home. Without alcohol to lubricate Erin's inhibitions, what would she think of me? I'd told her it turned me on thinking of other guys groping her. Was she going to throw me out as the pervert that I was? Worse, would she be disappointed, judging me silently?

Turned out, it was neither. When I got home, Erin and Jo had showered and dressed, looking as fresh as ever. I envied them, although I suspected concealer and coffee helped.

Nothing was said of last night. I kept waiting for it, like the proverbial shoe to drop. Whenever they laughed, I worried that they were laughing at me. When Erin and Jo stayed in that night and had wine on the back deck, I wondered if it had something to do with my admission. It was paranoia, I know, but I'm not ashamed to admit that I was fucking paranoid. I loved Erin. I didn't want to lose her over some stupid fantasy that I didn't even understand.

As I sat out there with them on the deck, listening to the crickets fill the night air, I thought about the conversation I'd overheard last night.

Oh come on, don't look at me like that. You loved it.

And I shouldn't have. I feel awful now.

"Hey, I think I'm going to head up to bed." I stood before my plan was fully hatched and the words had time to sink in for any of us. "I'll leave you two to gossip about whatever you talk about when I'm not around."

I winced. Too obvious. I covered by going to Erin and giving her a soft kiss.

"Night, Tom. Love you."

“Love you, too. And don’t worry about the kids tomorrow. I can take care of them again.”

Erin waved the offer away. “I don’t think I can handle another night like last night, but thanks for the offer. I may take you up on it anyway.”

She kissed me again and I stood.

“Night, Jo.”

“You, too, Tom.” Her blue-eyed stare made me nervous. I retreated before either of them noticed my shaking hands.

I got ready for bed as normal. I brushed my teeth and washed my face. I put on my pajama pants and an old t-shirt. But when it came time to slip beneath the sheets, I stopped short. The night was still, so quiet that I could hear the cicadas chirping outside. I knew what I wanted to do. I also knew what was the right thing to do. Unfortunately, these two things were mutually exclusive.

A peal of Jo’s laughter drifted in from outside, muffled enough that it could easily have been my imagination. Didn’t matter. It helped me make my decision.

My heart thrummed in my ears as I crept into the bathroom at the back of the house—the one the kids used that overlooked our back yard. We’d left the window open a crack to let in the night air; I took it as a good sign.

It took a moment to settle against the sink. I could hear them, but couldn’t understand them at first, like listening to a conversation under water. The adrenaline coursing through me made it nearly impossible to settle. I tried a couple breathing exercises, wishing I’d paid more attention to Erin when she’d taught me a few yoga basics.

Then, comprehension arrived, and with it, the electric zip of anxiety all over again.

“...but you like the attention.” Jo’s voice. Not quite a question.

“I mean, I guess so...” Erin said. I could practically see the exchanged looks in the pause. “Fine. It’s nice.”

“Nice? Or sexy?”

“What do you want me to say, Jo? That it turns me on when we’re together? I mean, I pay him for that attention, you know. He’s a personal trainer. He’s supposed to look after me.”

I think my stomach leapt into my throat. I was glad I was leaning against something. Everything grew foggy.

“He’s supposed to ask you out for drinks?” Jo said with a skeptical laugh.

“I told you, I shut that down. He knows I’m married now.”

“Doesn’t matter. Guys like him see a ring as a challenge, not a barrier.”

“Then maybe I should throw him back and rehire uniboob,” Erin said.

“Please. We both know you’re not going to do that.”

Erin hesitated less than I’d expected before answering. “He *is* a great trainer.”

Jo laughed. “Nobody works your body as good as AJ, huh?”

“Jo!”

“Oh, stop being all contrite. It’s harmless flirting, and I think that’s good for any relationship. Just like last night.”

I had trouble remembering to breathe. This conversation felt like a rollercoaster.

“What about last night?” Erin asked, then: “Oh, no more for me. I’m already pretty buzzed—”

“Come on, help me finish this. Don’t make me drink alone.”

“Fine. Last glass.”

“So last night, sounded like Tom benefited from all the attention you got from your dance partner.”

“You heard?”

“I did.”

My ears burned. What had she heard, specifically? Had she heard what we were talking about? Did she hear me tell

my wife how the thought of her dancing with other men turned me on?

"God, that was so hot, hearing you come. Reminded me of old times." Jo laughed.

"Funny, because the way I remember it, it was usually the other way around."

"Don't get all holier than thou, Erin. You had your fair share of boyfriends, and you weren't playing Scrabble in your room *all* the time. But stop trying to change the subject. Let's both agree on a few things, K?"

"Let's hear them first."

"You had a good time at Chic last night."

"Sure."

"And part of what made it so fun was all the attention you got from the guys."

Erin didn't immediately answer. I imagined Jo giving her a look. "Sure. Yes, that made things interesting."

"Made you horny, you mean."

"I really did mean *interesting*, but fine, horny, too."

"Especially the one guy."

"Sure, he was sexy and a good dancer. What can I say?"

"Did you keep his number?"

"No!"

"Shame. You should have at least given it to me."

"Slut," Erin said with a laugh.

"Whatever. When you got home, you couldn't even wait for the morning before working that energy out on your husband. And it didn't sound like he was complaining. My point is that just because you're married and a mom, you are also a woman—and a really sexy woman, I may add. Flirting doesn't hurt anyone—and in fact can be pretty fucking awesome."

Nicely put. I could have hugged Jo in that moment. Then Erin asked the next question:

"So that was just flirting last night?"

"In my book it was," Jo said.

"You've got a pretty loose definition."

"Hey, you've got a nice ass. Even I grabbed it last night while dancing."

He grabbed her ass? My breathing came faster. Heat flashed through me. I shut my eyes, like that would somehow block out this conversation. Instead, I saw Erin as she was last night, dressed in a tiny black dress, backed into the corner with some broad-shouldered, handsome guy.

"Jo, he tried to kiss me. And I almost let him."

I gasped. Suddenly, there wasn't enough oxygen to breathe.

"You should have let him. I bet he was a great kisser."

"Jo!"

I gripped the edge of the sink, worried I might pass out.

"Plus," Jo continued, "you wouldn't have ruined my night, either. Things were just heating up for me."

Erin's reply dripped with sarcasm. "I'm so sorry about that." She took an audible breath. "I really needed to get out of there."

"To fuck Tom while you thought about another man," Jo said.

"God, I'm terrible."

"You're a hot-blooded woman. I'm sure Tom approves."

"You're a bad influence on me, you know that, Josephine Davies?"

"And you'd be boring without me."

"So you're between guys right now?"

"Between boyfriends, but not without guys," Jo corrected.

"Of course not..."

I crept away now that they'd moved past the "confessions of a naughty wife" phase of the evening. Normally, I enjoyed hearing Jo's sordid tales as much as Erin, but my mind was on other things—troubling, upsetting, heart-wrenching, yet profoundly erotic things.

Erin had almost kissed another man.

I swooned, having to catch myself as I swayed down the hallway. I wondered if I'd be sick. Vomiting felt like the appropriately dramatic reaction to this discovery. But the steely erection that neither my boxers nor my pajama pants could hide stood as a concrete reminder that no matter what I *should* have felt, the indiscretion turned me on.

I was in our bathroom tugging my pants down my thighs before I realized what I was doing.

Erin had almost kissed another man, and had been fantasizing about him while she fucked me.

And here I sat, a raging hard-on pinched between thumb and forefinger. I began stroking it as I worked through the conversation, a penitent lashing himself for sins he enjoyed committing.

Not only had she almost kissed someone else last night, but she had an active crush on her personal trainer—a guy who helped her stretch, who had an excuse to put his hands all over her, who fucking asked her out already!

I came, erupting so quickly that I nearly missed it with my wad of toilet paper.

I took a deep breath after it was over. The buzz of the wine and adrenaline fled with my release. I slumped forward as fatigue ambushed me. I didn't want to think about what I'd heard anymore. I didn't want to consider the implications of my actions.

For the moment, my trembling orgasm had released me, too. For the moment, sleep came swiftly.

FIVE

When Jo left Sunday afternoon, I didn't immediately broach the subject. I didn't know where to start. With her night at Chic? With her crush on her personal trainer? Or maybe Friday night was a better starting point, with my admission of getting turned on by her flirting with other guys.

With the wealth of choice, I ended up choosing to do nothing. Jo left. Erin, Mary, Martin, and I had dinner, and I returned to work Monday morning after the longest weekend in ages.

I could almost pretend that nothing had changed, except that I knew so much had changed. Erin did, too. I saw it in the moments when I caught her watching me from across the room.

Work should have been a nice distraction. Instead, I was too distracted to work. I couldn't hide it any longer. People began to wonder if everything was alright. One coworker who I was pretty tight with, Doug, asked me if everything was okay. "If you want to talk, you know where my office is."

I actually considered it. Doug was about my age and in a similar situation as me: two kids, happy marriage, busy career. Maybe this was the early onset of a midlife crisis? When I played out that conversation in my head, though, I nearly ran from the building.

I could just imagine it. His eyes wide, his head forward, saying, *You want to watch your wife do what?!*

I was so distracted that I'd forgotten that it was Tuesday until I came home and Erin met me at the door, dressed in a pair of gray Lycra shorts and a zip-up hoodie over her top.

"Hey, honey. Dinner's in the oven. I'll be a little late since you're late."

Tonight was a workout night.

"Ah, I'm sorry. I completely lost track of time."

"It's okay, Tom." She kissed me in that familiar way that couples who'd been together for years kissed. "I called ahead. AJ has no one scheduled after me, so he shifted our session."

It was weird, hearing her mention AJ so casually like that.

"Great. I'm glad I didn't cut into your time."

"I love you. See you a little later than usual."

I stole one last look at her ass, displayed so well in those tight workout shorts. And with that, she was gone. Gone to AJ.

*

The next few hours were mostly taken up by my fatherly duties. I assembled and disassembled puzzles with Mary as Martin jumped around in front of the Xbox. He was a little too short for its motion detection to recognize, but he still had fun trying.

Mary went down first, although she moaned and called out for *mommy* from her crib for the next hour as Martin and I watched *Bob the Builder*.

Aside from the unexpected kink that Erin's gym evenings had started, they also gave me a greater appreciation for the hard work that being a stay-at-home mom was. The kids were in constant need of entertainment. I couldn't so much as check my emails on the phone before one of them came stomping up, ready for the next activity.

After two hours, I was exhausted and ready to go to bed myself.

Once Martin was down and I was sure Mary was asleep, I let myself think about my wife and where she was right now. This was around the time she was normally back, but she'd left a half hour late. Subconsciously, I started a clock, ticking up to some unknown time when she arrived, like bonus time after a soccer match. 15 minutes passed. 20. 30.

At 40 minutes past her usual return, my nerves kicked into overdrive. Where was she? What was she doing?

The gym closed late on weekdays, but it was usually pretty empty by this time of night. Erin and AJ would have the place to themselves. I could almost hear their laughter echo off the high, painted brick walls as AJ made some joke that Erin found funnier than she should have. My pants tightened with my heart as I imagined him setting his hands on her arms, correcting her technique. Maybe his cock would brush the back of her ass as he demonstrated. Maybe one thing would lead to another. How easy would it be to sneak off to the empty locker rooms—or since he worked there, the offices?

She finally came home a few minutes after my real panic set in. Any longer and I would have cracked and started making phone calls: to her cell, to the gym, to the corporate headquarters of City Fitness if I had to.

“Shower with me?” she said. She didn’t even wait for my answer, just headed for the stairs. I dropped what I was doing and followed.

“So did you have a good workout?”

I stepped up behind her and helped her pull her sweaty tank top off. She still had her hair in a ponytail, freeing me to walk my lips up the side of her neck.

“I had a great one.”

“Were you with AJ tonight? “

“Mmm hmm.”

My heart quickened. I wanted to ask her directly what was on my mind, but chickened out. I took the coy route.

“Did he work you hard?”

“He always does.” She turned in my arms and pulled my shirt off, drumming her fingers against my chest. Was she comparing me to AJ? How did I measure up? “Hope that you’re planning on working me hard, too.”

What’s gotten into you? I almost asked, but again lost my nerve. Maybe I didn’t want to know. The answer I came

up with certainly worked a number on my gut. Had something happened tonight? Had AJ made a move?

I hooked my thumbs in her workout shorts and peeled them down. Her matted curls glistened, but was that from sweat or excitement? Had her inner lips always protruded like that, pink and full?

“How about I start here.”

Dipping my head between her thighs, I ran my tongue across those tempting petals and tasted the heady musk of her arousal beneath her salty perspiration. Something had her worked up, and it probably wasn't the thought of coming home to me.

“Tom...uh...”

I felt her shift above me, grabbing the shower rod for support as I tickled my tongue across her clitoris. She lifted a leg onto my shoulder, opening herself wider. I flattened my tongue against her sex and thought about that trainer helping his trainee stretch. I ran my hands along her upper thighs. Had AJ's hands been here? Did they go higher?

“Uh, Tom, baby. That feels so...oh, don't stop.”

I stood, shaking out my tired thighs, and pulled her into the shower stall. Grabbing the showerhead from its cradle, I sprayed her body down before resuming my position between her legs. This time, though, I was armed with a secret weapon.

“What are you—ohhh...”

Switching the head to pulse mode, I ran my thumb down her slit and aimed the spray against her mound. The reaction was almost instantaneous. She bucked forward, a moan torn from her throat.

She tried to pull her hips back. I held her close, clutching at her rounded buttocks. Pointing the pulsing water away, I dove back in to bathe her sex with my lips and tongue.

Erin sighed, her resistance melting away as she cooed over me. Her fingers threaded through my wet hair.

Encouraged by the tender touch, I lingered in the soft space between her thighs and the tang of her excitement.

And then, without warning, I switched back to the pounding fixture. “UH!”

Hard, soft, hard, soft. Rinse. Repeat.

“Tom, what are you...what are you...ngh!”

Hard.

I could hear the imminence of her orgasm in her cries and pulled back just before she found it. I sat back and looked up at her.

Erin huffed, staring down at me through the slits of her eyes. Her nipples were hard peaks on those glorious slopes. Her hair was wet and dark from the initial rinse.

“Was that good?”

Erin nodded, glancing at the still pulsing showerhead like it was a loaded gun. I could feel her tension. She was wondering if she’d get the hard touch, or the soft. I gave her the soft first with a slow swipe up her lips, then nipped at the short hairs of her bush.

“Do you have something to tell me about tonight?”

It was a weird feeling. I was on my knees, but I felt like I was in control—and that gave me the confidence to ask the questions I couldn’t before.

“No. What do you mean?”

I raked the showerhead across her sex, holding it against her clit. She seized up like it was electricity flowering out of the hose, not water.

“You came home horny. Why?”

She looked at my hand again. This time, though, she smiled. “I think you’re seeing things you want to *see*—”

Back with the pulsating spray, then as quick as it was there, I followed with my mouth. I hit her with the showerhead again, this time keeping my mouth in place as I flicked my tongue down her slit. My nose filled with water, forcing me back. This time, I didn’t let up with the nozzle.

“Did you enjoy all the men watching you work out?”

“Tom...too much...” Her voice was tight. Clipped.

“Tell me.”

“I didn’t notice...” I looked up. Her eyes were closed, her brow creased, but her lips were curled upwards despite the half-moan she was stuck in.

“Bullshit.” I tried a different tactic. “You had to notice at least one guy’s eyes. Tell me, do you think AJ gets as excited about these sessions as you do?”

No denials. No defensiveness. Not even the shake of her head. Instead, she reached out and dragged my mouth against her cunt. I kept the showerhead there, changing the angle so I could breathe as she rode my face.

I could just hear her cry over the hiss of the water. Her thighs constricted around me, and her hand tightened in my hair. I felt her shuddering orgasm against my lips moments before water filled my mouth and nose. I choked, yanking away from her and splaying back along the opposite side of the stall.

Erin sank to a sitting position, her eyes still closed as the bliss of orgasm burned through her. Her sigh turned into a laugh when she finally opened her eyes and fixed me with that bright green stare.

“You’re a naughty one, Tom.”

Just like that, the confidence I’d built up vanished. Had I said too much? “I’m sorry—”

“Please, don’t be. That was incredible. Where did you learn to do that?”

“You mean with the showerhead?” *Or bringing AJ into it?*

“Yeah. That.”

“It just sort of came to me in the moment. Don’t think I don’t know why you insisted on a handheld shower fixture.”

At least Erin had the grace to blush. That in turn reminded me of the orgasm I’d overheard in the shower. My cock stirred, harder than ever.

Erin said, “And the other thing? Did that just come to you in the moment?”

No, I'd been having those thoughts for weeks.

"Yeah, I guess."

She looked at me thoughtfully, then held out her hand. I set the showerhead back into its cradle, twisting it to spray setting before joining her on the floor. Warm water drizzled us from above.

"You know I love you, right?" she said. "And would never do anything to jeopardize that."

The reassurance felt good, but also, paradoxically, a little disappointing.

"Of course." I felt I needed to give more here. "But you're attracted to AJ."

She hesitated for just a moment, but it was enough that I knew she was going to tell the truth. "Yeah, I guess so."

My heart quickened. I kept quiet, letting her work through her thoughts.

"Want me to stop training with him?"

"Of course not. Why would I want you to do that? Do you have something else you want to tell me?" I added a laugh to the last question to break the tension.

"You wish I did, don't you?" She was smiling. Good.

"No." That was the knee jerk reaction. Then: "I don't know."

Erin pushed her hands through her hair. She tanned naturally, but never got too dark. At the height of summer, tiny freckles dotted the bridge of her nose and the peaks of her cheekbones. Those freckles had just started coming in.

"Well, you don't have to worry about me. Okay?" she said.

Again I felt that tickle of disappointment. I said, "I know. But it's sexy to think about sometimes."

Erin studied me. I felt self-conscious again. I'd said too much.

Standing, I kissed her quickly and stepped out of the stall.

“I’ll let you finish your shower. I love you, Erin. See you in bed.”

We made love that night, but there was no further mention of the fantasy.

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SIX

"No gym this week. At least at night," Erin said over breakfast a couple weeks later.

"Hm?"

"AJ's visiting his family, so I can go when the kids are in school."

"And we can get caught up on our DVR," I added.

"Yeah! We only watch three shows and we're always behind."

I pulled her into my lap and kissed her. "Remember back when we used to stay up late at night, drinking wine and watching back-to-back episodes of *Dexter*?"

"Our *crazy* days." Erin giggled, then slipped away from me. "AJ keeps wanting to talk to me about last week's *Walking Dead*, so getting caught up will be good."

"Huh, he doesn't strike me as a *Walking Dead* fan."

"*Everyone* is a *Walking Dead* fan, Tom." She slipped back out of my lap. "I'm going to wake the kids before they're late for school."

This was a new thing Erin had started to do, ever since the night I'd confessed my fantasy: Erin had started talking about AJ more. Not in a sexual way. She didn't invoke his name to elicit a reaction from me. She simply talked about him the way I did my coworkers.

It was all silly stuff—trivial details and anecdotes that didn't amount to much. But it did get his name into our everyday lexicon. I started learning more about him. Before, he'd been a giant mystery, a hole so big I didn't even know it was there. As time went by, though, it started to fill with details.

AJ drove a Camero (not surprising). AJ had already done two ironmans and was considering a third (also not very surprising). AJ owned a Kindle and admitted to reading 50

Shades of Grey (okay, *that* was surprising for a variety of reasons). He was from New Jersey, but had lived in New York City most of his adult life. Now in DC, he tended bar at a little dive downtown called Callahan's when he wasn't at the gym. He was 26.

Those details did not help with my sanity. Erin knew more about him than I'd thought, and more than anything, that caught me off-guard. Apparently they didn't just talk about fitness. They talked about everything. Television. Hobbies. Fucking *erotica*. If Erin had been afraid of making me jealous before, she certainly wasn't holding back now.

Not that these new details made me trust her any less. That was the weirdest part. The more real he became, the less nervous I was. He was no longer her fantasy man. They didn't click like soul mates being reunited. None of that. She complained about him as much as I complain about my coworkers. There were gripes and disagreements. When she found out that he'd voted for Mitt Romney, I swear she almost switched trainers again. All of that helped.

As for us, things were good. I'd admitted my fantasy to Erin—sort of—and she didn't treat me any differently. I wasn't relegated to the couch. She didn't look at me with that wariness reserved for a rabid animal. It was almost like the subject had never been raised.

Things were back to normal...for the most part.

I continued to resist the urge to look him up—I didn't want to know what he looked like; those were the details I was okay keeping vague. He was a personal trainer and Erin found him attractive. That was good enough for me.

The sex after her workouts continued to be hot. I'd never had so much shower sex in my life. We didn't need to mention the AJ fantasy for it to be with us. As I took her against the tiled wall, I imagined it was her personal trainer filling her—and even sexier was the thought that behind Erin's closed eyes, she was having the same fantasy.

Over the next few weeks, that was the trend. Erin brought AJ up more and more, and our sex life improved dramatically. Then, as spring yielded to summer and everything got hot, so did this game.

*

“Yes, yes...” Erin’s whisper tickled my ears, nearly inaudible. “Right...there...”

We’d forgotten to switch off the bathroom light after her post-workout shower, and the light silhouetted Erin’s naked body as she rode me hard. I’d gone down on her under the spray, but AJ had pushed her particularly hard that evening and she was feeling too drained to stand up for long.

I walked my hand into the dip of her waist. “God, baby, you feel so good.”

“So...do you.”

I held her hips, helping her through the rolling motions. This was good. We hadn’t actually had sex *in bed* in a couple weeks. It felt good to be able to lie back on something soft and feel Erin’s pussy caress me without fear of the shower getting in the way.

There was also something nice about being in the dark. The bathroom light cast the room in black and white. As Erin’s momentum built and her tits started to sway with each undulation, the crisp contrast of shadow and light felt artistic rather than obscene. We were making love.

Erin raked her fingers through her wet locks. Her hair had gotten long. Where it had once just barely brushed her shoulders, it now fanned out across her breasts and covered her nipples.

I reached out, touching a silky strand. She leaned into me, letting the rest of her hair cascade across her face and against my chest.

“Your hair’s so long.”

“Mmm hmm.” She pushed her pelvis into me and made this circular motion with her hips that felt fantastic. “AJ suggested I grow it out.”

Her words buried themselves into my gut like a physical blow.

I nearly came. I’m actually not sure how I didn’t. There was so much complexity packed into such a simple statement. Things went white and fuzzy, and when it cleared, Erin was stretched out over me, her lips on my neck.

“So you like it long?” she said. Then, a beat later, added, “AJ?”

That time, I couldn’t hold back. Clutching her ass, I rammed my hips up and emptied my balls. Erin’s gasping orgasm joined me, just as abrupt and even stronger than my own.

Sprawled over me, her body went limp, her breathing heavy.

I didn’t know what to say. The mention of AJ lingered like the sudden flash of a camera. She’d grown her hair out for AJ? Or just liked the suggestion?

“Mmm, that was nice.” She looked as contented as a cat stretching after a nap.

Were you serious about that thing with AJ? Just forming the thought brought new life to my cock. Erin hummed, squeezing my still-buried member with her pussy.

“So you like the length, AJ?” His name from her lips was all it took to put fire back in my veins.

I rolled her off and flipped her onto her stomach. She yelped, but didn’t put up much protest as I yanked her hips up and entered her from behind.

“Haaa...” Erin laughed through her moan. A quick check showed her eyes closed. Was she really imagining I was him?

Adrenaline awoke the animal in me. I fucked her hard, each lunge punctuated by a sharp cry. Reaching down, I

twisted my hand in her damp, dark hair and pulled.

“Oh, AJ, you know I like it *rough*—”

I pulled hard enough to lift her head and roll her shoulders back. She pushed up on her hands, fully on all fours, and hissed. She liked it rough? That was new. Ten years of knowing her and I’d never heard that.

But I was going to try to give it to her.

“You’re such a tease, baby.” My hips slapped against her ass as we fucked. “You know what those little outfits do to me.”

“Mmm...yeah.”

“This is what you really want, isn’t it?” I tightened my fist in her hair. “Isn’t it?”

“Gah! Yes...” Her panting came shallower. She teetered on the brink. “Fuck me, AJ. Fuck me with that beautiful cock.”

My balls tightened. Apparently they *did* have something left. I humped her harder. Faster. Rapid fire thrusts. Bam bam bam.

Sweat dripped off my face. I let go of her hair, clamping my hands onto her hips, and took control. “So...fucking...good...”

Head released, she dropped it between her shoulders, burying her face in a pillow to scream through her orgasm.

Squeezing those hips, I jammed as deep as I could get and gave her every drop I had in reserve.

Again, Erin laughed through her sigh, languid and satisfied.

“Wow.”

I threw myself onto the mattress beside her, my heart still fluttering. “Yeah. Wow.”

“So Tom...” Erin pushed her hair out of her face. “Do *you* like the longer hair?”

I had mixed feelings for almost everything we’d just done, but I couldn’t help laughing with her.

“I love it. Reminds me of when I first met you.”

She nodded. "He didn't really suggest I grow it out, you know."

"You're evil."

"And you love it," she said.

"I love *you*. And...sure, I can love a bit of evil, too."

She kissed me. "He likes the longer hair, though."

I wasn't sure if this was just more teasing, or this was real. I wasn't sure about much these days. "How do you know?"

"He told me."

"Is that true? Or another story?"

"Hmm...maybe I'll tell you in the morning. Good night, Tom."

Of course, when morning came, she didn't tell me a thing.

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SEVEN

A week later, I finally met the man himself, although I didn't know it at the time. I was working out at City Fitness's downtown location on a Thursday because my schedule had gotten screwed up. As usual, it was crowded at lunch, filled with corporate types trying to squeeze every ounce of productivity from the day.

Over the last few months, I'd gotten better at not focusing on the blue-shirted staffers, obsessing over who was AJ and who wasn't. I was able to focus on weights when I was lifting and running when I was on the treadmill. It was only between machines that my subconscious wandered and the questions began to assault me.

Does that guy with the long hair and the angsty expression look like an AJ? Does that blond dude behind the desk seem like someone who also worked part-time as a bartender? Is that guy with the shaved head someone who voted for Mitt Romney?

The staff didn't wear nametags, so my questions were purely academic. It was safe speculation—fuel to bring back home and power my fantasy. It was harmless.

I hit up the sauna, just as always, stripping down and grabbing a towel. Only one guy was in the wood-paneled sauna room as I pushed in: tattooed, deeply tanned, upper body speaking of more hours in the gym than I had available to give. Like every guy I ran into at the gym, I ran him by the AJ criteria.

Then wrote him off. Too Jersey Shore for Erin to have a crush on. He has a mustache-less goatee. He had a tattoo of a dragon that ran across his shoulder and up his neck. He was just a little too muscular for her. He had an earring.

All these details, plus the fact that he'd clearly waxed his chest, made me wonder if he was gay. Terrible

stereotyping, I know, but we're all creatures of instant judgment.

I leaned back, my arms resting behind me, and let my mind wander in the soupy humidity of the little wooden room. Inevitably, it wandered to AJ and the blue-shirted employees that I'd pretended not to see. They were all good looking, although I could rule out a number of guys who just were not Erin's type. A couple of the more body-builder types I scratched off the list, which included the African American trainer (although he probably would have stayed had he not been the size of a small car).

That did get me thinking, though. It had never occurred to me that Erin's AJ was something other than an All-American white boy. Her tastes ran the gamut. The thought of her flirting with a Spanish guy, or a black dude, put a whole new dizzying spin on my fantasy. I started to get hard, and that's when I realized where I was and how awkward this could be.

In the sauna, with nothing but a thin towel to cover me, I couldn't hide my erection no matter how I positioned myself. If I got up, that would only draw more attention to the situation. If I stayed, it was only a matter of time before things got really awkward.

So I tried to think about something else—anything else. The long-term strategy session I was facilitating at the end of the week. The quarterly budgets coming up. Anything to get my mind off my wife and other men.

But that's all I could think about. My mind filled with images of Erin in the sauna, naked but for her ankle socks and running shoes, servicing the guy across from me. My cock jumped. I glanced over at him and the situation got worse: he was hard, too.

Our eyes met for the briefest of moments before heat blossomed across my face. At least he looked just as mortified as I did, but why was he hard? Was he thinking about me? Did he think I—

“Hey man, it’s not—” I began. Someone else joined us before I could finish the thought, an older gentleman who didn’t even bother with a towel. I took the opportunity to slip out before things got even more awkward, heading straight for the showers. Mortified, I was going to need to stay away from this gym for a while.

That encounter was the sobering incident that I needed. The queasy grip of my wife-sharing fantasy (I was finally owning up to what it was) released me, leaving behind nothing but the embarrassing reality of the sauna moment. I wanted to curl up under the shower spray and forget the whole damn thing.

I cut the shower, toweled off, and wrapped it around my waist before braving the locker room. The guy wasn’t there when I dressed, and hope blossomed. Maybe I’d get away without seeing him—possibly ever again in my life. Then I realized I’d left my shampoo in the shower stall. Heading back, I literally ran into him coming out of his own shower.

His towel unraveled as he jumped back. I nearly lost my balance getting out of the way myself—it’s amazing how fast two guys can react when coming into unintended bodily contact. It was all a big mess.

At least he was flaccid, I thought, as I bent down and handed his towel back. Like the rest of his upper body, his cock was free of hair, so the size was probably an optical illusion, but even still, it probably made the ladies—or men—happy. I’m not into guys, but I’m not so insecure that I can’t identify a good-looking man, and this dude was good-looking, even with the tats and the earring.

“Thanks,” he said, securing the towel even harder.

“No problem.” I felt this needed to be more masculine sounding, so I threw in a *man* at the end.

I went to get my shampoo, my body numb, my face as bright as a fire engine. Back in the locker room, we were the only two guys. I stuffed my shampoo into my gym bag. Time to get out of there.

He met my eyes in the mirror before I could get away. At least he'd put on a pair of black boxer-briefs. After the last two encounters, that scrap of cloth was as good as a monk's habit. He started the conversation.

"About what happened in the sauna—"

I waved him off. No explanation needed. He pushed on.

"I wasn't... I'm not..." He scratched the back of his neck. He had short, dark hair that had begun to curl.

I said, "I'm not either. Don't worry about it."

Fuck did I want to get out of there, but now I was locked in.

He stepped into a pair of shorts and kept the conversation alive. "I was thinking about this chick from work. She always gets me worked up like that."

"Nice. Office romances can be hot."

"She's more like a client, but same difference. Same feeling." When he pulled his shirt on, I paused to gawk. It was the electric blue of the City Fitness employees. "Tuesday and Thursday nights are my favorite times of the week."

Erin met up with AJ on Tuesdays and Thursdays. My body started to go numb again.

"You work here? Personal trainer or something?"

"Yeah. Mostly here, anyway. I work at our Tysons location on occasion. I'm going there tonight, actually, to meet up with this hottie."

Oh fuck, *this was AJ?*

"Nice. You hook up with her?"

The question was out of my mouth before I could stop it.

"Not yet."

AJ grinned. He had bright, even teeth—the kind of teeth that Erin would be drawn to. "She's married, so it's complicated."

"And that doesn't bother you?"

I noticed him glance at my ring finger, checking on my marital status. I never worked out with my ring on.

“Not if they’re into it, it doesn’t. I’m not here looking for love. Just a sweet ride.”

“And this one’s a sweet ride?”

“Fuck yeah. She’s probably got one of the best bodies I’ve seen walk in here.” He made the shape of an hour-glass with his hands. “Great tits, narrow waist, flaring hips. And her ass...” He shook his head. “Love a chick with a little padding back there, you know?”

“Yeah.”

“Best thing of all, she’s not the type to back down from a challenge. I push her, she just asks for more. I flirt with her, she doesn’t shy away from that, either.”

His words leached the air out of my lungs.

“Anyway, I’ve got a plan,” he said.

“A plan?” I could barely find the breath to ask it.

“Yeah. I’ve been laying the foundation for the last few weeks. Can’t rush things with this one, you know? But I think that tonight’s the night.”

“Tonight?”

“Yeah, I think she’s ready.” He shouldered his gym bag and nodded to me. “Anyway, take care, man.”

And with the kind of nod that guys give one another, he pushed out of the locker room and into the bright, new world.

Panic set in before that swinging door had fully settled. I had to take a seat as the blood drained from my face and my heart rattled against my chest.

Tonight’s the night.

What the hell did that mean? And what the hell had been going on these past few weeks? The revelation added a whole new dimension to our post-workout lovemaking. Was that why she’d brought him up in the bedroom? Was she so bottled up that she couldn’t stand *not* mentioning his name as we fucked?

My erection started to return. I quickly dressed before the old man in the sauna joined me and I had yet another

awkward encounter. I tried to go back to work, but after staring at a spreadsheet for thirty minutes without registering a single detail, I decided that this was a waste of my time.

With a quick text to Erin that I was headed out early, I packed up my things and headed home, uncertain as to what I'd say to Erin.

*

"Daddy's home!" Mary cried as I walked in the front door. She was jumping vigorously on our sofa in the living room, a pile of other pillows strewn at its feet.

"Hey, Mary. Where's your mom?"

Mary just smiled, pausing long enough in her jumping to laugh and repeat, "Daddy's home!"

Erin emerged from the basement with a laundry basket full of folded whites. "Oh, Tom. You're home early."

With her hair back in a ponytail, a pair of cropped jeans and a t-shirt, she was the picture of domesticity. She even wore a small black cardigan to ward her against the A/C.

"I texted."

She set the basket down and pulled her phone out of her back pocket, where the rectangular shape had begun to wear against the denim. "So you did."

She ended up typing something in reply, smiling as she did so, although I didn't feel my own phone buzz. "A little too late to text back," I teased.

"Oh, that was AJ." And she left it at that.

They were texting now? The new development triggered a queasy uncertainty in me. It reminded me of my encounter with him. *Tonight's the night.*

Putting the phone away, she picked up the laundry basket again, stepped up to me, and gave me a chaste kiss. "Nice to have you home so early. We can have dinner together."

With that, she wandered upstairs, leaving me with a bouncing Mary on the couch and confused emotions swirling in my head.

I've got a plan.

I could still see that self-assured smile of his—a kind of cockiness that I always hated. It made me think of guys like Lucas Hughes. There was a reason that Lucas and I would never be friends, despite the closeness of our wives. What I couldn't wrap my head around was the attraction that Erin had for AJ, who was a rougher, less refined version of Lucas. She never struck me as the type of person who liked that kind of arrogance.

I've been laying the foundation for the last few weeks. Can't rush things with this one, you know?

I needed to warn her. It was the right thing to do. Something was going to happen tonight—something I had full confidence she'd rebuff—and she needed to know.

I just wasn't sure how to bring it up. *Hey, I ran into AJ at the gym today...*

It just sounded bad, like I was checking up on him, and in turn that I didn't trust Erin. I cringed, feeling like a creep—even knowing that it was all just a coincidence. Still, I owed it to Erin if AJ was going to hatch his ultimate plan tonight.

But dinner came and went and I couldn't seem to work it into conversation. I had a few openings, like when Erin asked me how my day was, and later when she asked me why I seemed so distracted. It would have been so easy to confess.

I didn't, and the reason why I didn't was almost too shameful to admit. I wanted AJ to take his shot. I knew that Erin would never yield to him, so what was the harm, anyway?

I knew I was playing with fire. I knew I was taking a risk, but it felt controlled. It gave this game an edge that made my cock stiffen. My resolve almost broke down after dinner when I walked in on Erin getting ready for the gym.

"That's new..." My voice practically quivered.

Erin was fastening her bangs back with a hair band, the rest of her long locks tied back in a ponytail.

"You like it?"

"Yes."

My wife in skintight Lycra, what wasn't to like? The top and bottom were black with bright pink piping that ran along the seams. The pants were capris, the top crisscrossed her back in sexy straps. Ankle socks and tennis shoes softened the sexy look, but there was no doubt she was going to draw attention this evening.

"Good. Later, you can help me take it off."

"Hope I'll be the first."

She shot me a dangerous look, but didn't say anything back. Instead, she sidled up to me and gave me a soft, lingering kiss.

*

The next few hours were excruciating. Too much was going on. Erin in her Lycra outfit. AJ pushing her as she rotated through the machines. AJ's fucking proclamation: *tonight's the night*.

I trusted her. I did. And I reminded myself that I did over and over as I went through the evening's motions: cleaning up the kitchen, tidying up the playroom, putting the kids down for bed. I trusted her, but...

But what if something were to happen?

The question sent a lick of fire through me. I didn't bother with the television tonight. I grabbed a beer and slipped out onto the back porch, letting my thoughts take flight.

What if she had an affair? A fling? And it started tonight?

Asking those questions was like blowing on fire. The flames rose higher and hotter. Things started to crackle. I choked.

Anger flashed through me. Anger at AJ. At my wife. At myself for not doing a damn thing to stop it. “How could she do that?” I asked the night air, my voice sharp.

And yet...and yet I was hard—so fucking hard it hurt in the confines of my jeans. I thought about going inside and relieving myself—only the shame that came with that act stopped me.

So instead, I sat out back, listening to the crickets as I imagined my wife in her tight outfit and AJ’s eyes on her. I’d think of him touching her stomach or the inside of her thigh and I was sick with jealousy, yet dizzyingly aroused.

Would she come back late, with some kind of excuse about losing track of time? Would she be freshly showered, despite having never taken a post-workout shower at the gym?

I went over all the things we’d said in the past few weeks. I’d told her that the thought of other men checking her out turned me on. She’d admitted that she found AJ attractive. She’d pretended I was AJ.

Tonight’s the night.

Fuck.

And then she was home.

“There you are,” she said behind me. “Enjoying the night?”

I felt her hand on my shoulder and looked up to see her smiling, sweaty face looking down at me. Her hair was still gathered into a sleek ponytail, damp—but from perspiration, not a shower.

“It’s beautiful tonight.”

Erin nodded, settling into my lap. “Yeah, definitely. I love early summer nights.”

She wrapped her arms around me and I kissed her neck. I could smell the acrid bite of her sweat and nothing more—no cologne, no sex. I should have been relieved.

“Good workout?”

Erin sighed happily. "Great, as usual. I'm going to feel that one tomorrow."

Knowing what AJ looked like—his cut muscles and tanned skin leaping to mind—turned the imagined visual into something debilitating, but it lacked the same sting as it had just minutes before.

Nothing had happened.

Tonight *wasn't* the night, apparently.

It made it safer to tease. I ran my hands across her back, clammy with sweat. "Did AJ like your new top?"

"Maybe." Erin giggled, shifting to face me.

I ran my hands down, across her ass. Sure enough, she had nothing beneath those pants. Had AJ noticed? He had to. That got my motor running once again.

I kissed her neck. She sighed over me. She whispered, "He didn't say anything, but he seemed especially... distracted."

My breath caught. Erin looked at me, a coy smile lighting up her face.

"You caught him checking you out?"

"Oh, yeah." She wiggled her hip against my crotch, finding me hard. "Get this. AJ asked me to train for a triathlon with him."

My mouth went dry. My heart nearly exploded. Was that what he'd been alluding to? I didn't trust my voice, so I kept my response at a minimum. "Did he?"

"Does it make you jealous?"

Yes. "Why should it make me jealous?" I managed to sound calm.

Erin kissed my neck. "Because I'm pretty sure he's got some ulterior motives."

She drew back to watch my reaction. Maybe she could untangle the ball of excitement and jealousy I was feeling. Maybe she did, saying, "I didn't give him an answer."

"You didn't tell him *no*."

"I didn't tell him *yes*, either." The tease was gone from her voice, concern lingering.

This wasn't what I'd thought he meant by *tonight's the night*. I'd expected him to ask her out for drinks, or maybe just back to his place. I hadn't figured AJ to be in for the long seduction, but it made sense now: *can't rush things with this one*. She would have rejected any offer even remotely suggestive. It was nice to know that Erin still saw right through the bullshit.

"Do you want to do that?" I asked. "You've never mentioned a triathlon before."

She remained non-committal. "It could be fun."

"Fun to do it? Or fun to spend more time with AJ?" My own question sizzled between my ears.

Erin relaxed. "Can I say both?"

"Running, biking, and swimming, right? So he'd see you in a bathing suit?"

"He would." She pushed her hip harder against my cock. "And I'd get to see *him* in a bathing suit."

I took a deep, shaky breath. I needed to tell her about my encounter with AJ. She needed to know the full truth. But before I could marshal my thoughts, she unzipped my jeans and fished my cock out.

"Well look at that." My thoughts scattered as she wrapped her hand around my erection. She gave me a couple tentative strokes, remembering how to give a handjob, before muscle memory kicked in.

I gasped. Suddenly, I remembered where we were. Outside. In the suburbs. Our backyard was semi-private and the houses on either side of us were dark, but panic stabbed in anyway.

"Erin..."

It was like she didn't hear me. She sidled closer, her hand picking up speed. Leaning close, I could feel her hot breath on my neck. I anticipated the kiss. Instead, she teased me with a whisper, low and seductive. "I think it'll be

really challenging, too. He's in really good shape. He'll push me. Hard." She squeezed my cock. "He'll drive me just...the way...I need it."

I groaned. "Fuck, Erin."

"Mmm, maybe. Maybe he'll *fuck Erin*." Her kisses came now, hot along my neck. "Maybe we'll go back to the gym after a long run. It would be empty. He'd suggest we take a shower to get clean..."

Her hand raced along my length. My balls tightened. This wasn't the first time she'd thought of this fantasy, I realized.

"I could wash him down, running my hands all over his sexy body..."

I swear I heard her breath catch. Or it could have been mine. I knew what AJ looked like. This imagined scene sprung easily to my mind.

"I'd finally get to see his...him..." Erin's hesitation in using the word *cock* or *dick* turned me on even more, a reminder of who my wife was.

Threading my hands through her hair, I gently pushed her down and took up the narrative. "He'd push you down to your knees. You wouldn't need any more instruction."

Erin didn't slide down to the deck, but she did dip low and take my cock into her mouth. She wasn't thinking about me. She wasn't on the back porch at night, blowing her husband of eight years. Behind her closed eyes, she had her lips wrapped around AJ's cock and AJ's muscled body rising over her.

"Ohmy—" My breath caught as I came, exploding in her mouth.

Erin choked, caught by surprise, and she raced to swallow. Some hair had escaped the headband and ponytail to tickle along my thighs. She brushed it away. I got a clear look at her sharp beauty as she milked me. Would AJ ever see that?

The rhetorical question shook me to my core. If I could have come again, I would have. Instead, I just gasped and pushed forward, giving the last of my softening cock to my wife.

When she came up for air, she looked bashful. She looked around, checking the neighbors' houses as if remembering where she was for the first time.

"Yeah, we're not actually in the showers," I said. Erin only blushed harder.

"I wasn't..." She rolled her eyes and conceded. "I guess you don't have a problem with me training with him, then."

My locker room conversation returned. I had to tell. Stuffing myself back into my pants, I zipped back up and took a deep breath. Again, she cut me off before I could get it out.

"I tease you about him, but he's a professional. I've asked around about him. He really is one of the best in the area. You know nothing like that would ever happen, right?" She settled onto my lap and put her arms around me again.

"But you've fantasized about it, haven't you?"

She hesitated. "Yeah."

Her confession shot adrenaline through me. Enough to force out my own.

"I think I met him today. At the gym downtown. He's got a big tattoo across his shoulder and neck? And a goatee?"

"Yeah. How—"

Erin's brow tightened. She was confused right now, but in a minute she'd be upset.

"It was totally random. I bumped into him in the locker room." Might as well leave out the homoerotic elements of that encounter. "I had no idea who he was, I swear."

Erin stiffened. "Random, huh?"

"I swear."

"And what did you two *randomly* talk about, hm?"

Uh oh. "Well, you, I suppose—"

"How convenient."

“Seriously, it’s not like that. I wasn’t trying to...” I shook my head, washing my face with my hands. Time to go into full defense mode. “I told you, I didn’t know it was him. And I didn’t know it was *you* he was talking about. Not at first. It was just, you know, locker room BS. He started talking about some hot brunette he worked with. I had no idea it was you.”

“Until you did.”

“Yeah.”

She looked hard at me, her fury yielding to something softer. She opened her mouth to say something, decided better of it, and looked away, blushing.

“What?” I asked.

“Did he really say that I was a...” She trailed off, uncertain.

I smiled, understanding her hesitancy. “A hot brunette? Yeah. He loves your body. He said you’ve got a great ass.”

I cupped her buttocks, squeezing gently.

“I told him I was married. Just so you know.” She finally looked back at me, making eye contact. “He asked me if I wanted to get a drink with him a while back. I told him no.”

I felt my cock begin to grow again. “Why didn’t you tell me?”

“I wasn’t sure how you’d take it. You can get kind of jealous.”

“I could. But I trust you.”

Erin nodded quickly, eager to believe it. “It was early on. He hasn’t done it since.”

“I think that’s what this triathlon is,” I said.

She looked at me sideways. “What do you mean?”

“He told me that he’s been *laying the foundation* with you for a few weeks now, and that *tonight’s the night*. I didn’t know what he was talking about then, but now it makes sense.”

Erin was quick to pick up on it. “He’d been mentioning this half ironman since the beginning of the month.” Her

eyes darted back and forth as she worked out the timing. "I guess I'd never thought of competing in a triathlon until then, but yeah...that makes sense. He's been setting me up."

"You really thought he wasn't?"

"I mean, not really. I know I tease you about it, but I always felt it was mostly one-sided. You met him. He's, like, ten years younger than me. And he's always got these twenty-somethings hanging around him when I arrive. Why would he come up with this elaborate scheme to seduce *me*?"

"He says that he likes that you don't back down from a challenge."

"Maybe he just wants a partner to train with?" Erin didn't sound convinced at all.

"He also said he likes the challenge of a ring. And he told me that you looked like a *sweet ride*."

Erin laughed, but her red face told me everything that I needed. "How flattering."

"How does it make you feel that he'd rather take you for a ride than any of those twenty-somethings?"

"Confused."

As my thumb slid inside the waistband of her shorts. "What else?"

"Incredulous?"

I pushed my hand deeper, tracing the groove of her ass to her sopping wet sex. I easily sank two fingers into her. "Anything else?"

Her voice was barely audible. "Excited."

"You *do* feel excited."

A laugh tumbled forth. "Oh, Tom, this is insane."

"If you're still interested in the triathlon, I think you should do it. Just think of how good it'll be for your ego, spending all that time with a guy who's admitted to wanting you?"

"Tom..." She arched her back. Our roles had reversed from earlier, but the subject matter remained the same: AJ.

"He said that Tuesday and Thursday nights were the best days of his week."

"Really?"

I kissed her neck as I fingered her from behind. Twisting my wrist, I slipped my index finger up across her clit. Her body lurched.

"Yeah, really. Think he knows that you come home each night and fuck me, thinking about him?"

"Oh, Tom..." She twisted and turned, thinking of AJ behind her closed eyes.

"Because you do, don't you?"

"Uh, yes, baby."

"So what are you going to tell him? That you're interested? That you'd love to spend more time with him? That it makes you excited, just thinking about it?"

In answer, Erin bowed her back and thrust her ass against my hand, her pussy tightening around my fingers. She stifled her gasp, letting it get swallowed by the night. She was thinking about him. She wanted him, at least on some primal level. As much as I trusted her, I knew that this training set-up was a bad idea.

We needed to stop.

We had to stop.

Yet I kept drilling her with my hand as I kissed every secret erogenous zone I knew about along her neck.

"Tom... *Tom!*" I covered her mouth in a kiss before she got loud enough to wake the neighbors. She met my tongue with her ravenous own as she ground backwards against my hand. I could feel her world catch fire. She rolled her head along mine, her breath tight and shallow. I jammed my fingers to their knuckles, twisted, and felt her explode on me.

Erin deflated in my arms. I held her close as I listened to her wheezy breathing.

When sanity returned enough to speak, I wondered where we stood. Erin answered that for me. "It could be kind of fun, training with him and knowing what I know."

I welcomed the renewal of danger, bad idea or not. "Yeah. He'd think he was being so smooth and subtle."

Erin smiled, liking that idea. "It could definitely be fun, but...are you sure?"

What a loaded question that was. I wasn't sure about a damn thing anymore. "I can handle it if you can."

Erin raised a brow, as if to say, *A challenge?* Instead, she said, "Guess I'll tell him tomorrow."

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EIGHT

I woke up the next day feeling no different than I had the day before. The sun still streamed in through the windows. My coffee tasted just like it always did. My commute into the city was just as congested.

But it *was* different. Today, Erin would tell AJ that she wanted to train with him, and AJ would read all kinds of things into that. My stomach twisted and churned. My cock stirred.

Just as I managed to settle deeper into my routine—that of Executive Tom's, the commercial real estate exec leading an upstart group to record profits—the world once again conspired to remind me that today was no normal day.

I was called into the CEO's office at noon. Noon on a Friday. Not a good feeling for anyone—particularly when I walked in to find the head of HR also present. Panic boiled inside me. I suppressed the urge to flee and took an anxious step into the room.

"Tom, please have a seat."

The CEO of Lattice Commercial Real Estate LLC, Roger Hensley, had always maintained a friendly yet detached demeanor with me, although I'd never had cause to be called to his office on a Friday afternoon.

"Roger?" I'd never felt so hot or uncomfortable in my life. I didn't want to sit.

"It's not bad news, Tom. At least, not for you."

"Okay."

My mouth was dry. My heart refused to calm down.

"We had to let Al Myers go."

"Okay."

I felt weightless, although maybe it was more like a falling sensation. Al Myers was one of the senior execs at Lattice. He ran the sales department for the southeastern

region and was technically my boss's boss, although my team had little interaction with him.

Roger sat back in his chair. It creaked.

The director of HR, an elderly woman named Linda, spoke next. "We haven't made it public, so please don't share this with anyone until you see the announcement."

"Sure."

I still didn't have a clue why I was here, but I'd begun to develop a theory. It was too exciting to even give thought to.

Roger finally explained. "I've been hearing good things about you, Tom. Since you took over your team, you've continually brought in record numbers. That's damn impressive." He leaned forward, setting his elbows on his desk. "Damn impressive."

"Thank you, sir."

"I want you to take over for Al. Do what he couldn't. I want to see those numbers all over the southeastern United States."

I couldn't keep the shock from my face as my theory was confirmed. It seemed so crazy. That was one hell of a promotion. At 35, I'd be the youngest senior executive at Lattice, and I'd be bypassing my direct supervisor in the process.

"So what do you say, Tom? You interested?"

"Of course." Was that my voice shaking? "Thank you, sir."

Roger smiled, slapping the desk. "Great. And don't thank me yet. This isn't a paper-pushing kind of job. That's what Al thought it was. I'm expecting to see results."

"And you'll see them, sir." As I said the words, it occurred to me that this meant more than just a (significant) pay increase. "Would you mind if I talked this over with my wife?"

"Of course not." Roger stood, and when I started to as well, he waved me back down. "Stay here. I need to run off

to another meeting, but Linda can fill you in on the details. Let me know by next week?"

"I can do that." I shook his hand before returning to my seat. "Thanks again, sir."

"Have a great weekend, Tom."

I got most of the details I needed from Linda, although I had to ask her to repeat a few things when my mind started to drift to the enormity of this promotion. Bullet points included: travel was expected as I represented Lattice during major deals up and down the southern portion of the East Coast; I could take anyone from my current team along with me, which meant promotions for all of them as well; the effective date was immediate, although I needed to transition out of my current job.

Oh, and with bonuses, it could triple my pay. If I was a success.

That was the one I couldn't fully wrap my head around, but kept coming back to. It meant that everything changed.

When the mental parade that accompanied my new salary finally subsided and I was able to do more than repeat *oh my god* over and over in my head, I started to get down to the logistics.

First, there was travel, something I rarely had to do before. It placed a heavier burden on Erin with the kids, and it ate into my family time with them, although it did open up the possibility of some semi-paid family trips. One of our regional headquarters was in Orlando, and we'd been meaning to take the kids to Disney World.

The longer hours weren't trivial, either. Longer hours meant fewer evenings free. I wasn't so sure Erin would be able to keep her Tuesday/Thursday sessions at the gym. With AJ.

Like a lightning bolt, that scenario flashed back to the forefront of my thoughts. Those sessions, which had become such a source of sexual fervor, were no longer necessary. Not if she was training for a triathlon with him.

How I managed to do any work the rest of the day was beyond me. Between the promotion and the AJ thing, my head was all over the place. Somehow, though, the day passed and I was headed for home.

*

When I got there, Martin was playing in our raised sandbox in the front yard with Andy, the Hughes boy. The concerned parent in me wanted to get out of the car and tell them to go play in the backyard, away from the would-be kidnappers out there, ready to crawl off the pages of the newspapers and snatch the boys away. But that wasn't the neighborhood we lived in.

As if to underline the fact, Jerry from the neighborhood watch rolled by, making sure that all was well.

I waved at him, then went up to Martin and ruffled his hair.

"Dad! Check out this sand castle Andy and I built. It's for our Ninja Turtles!"

I started to warn them about getting sand in the toys, but saw that it was too late. Donatello was already half shoved into the sandy bank.

"Looks awesome, guys," I said instead, but they were already back into their imagined world.

Inside, I heard Erin's voice from the den, but when I walked in there, it was empty.

"A half ironman, huh?"

Not Erin's voice. Haley Hughes, from down the street, coming out of the baby monitor we still used in Mary's room.

"I know, right?" Erin said, also heard through the monitor. We must have forgotten to turn it off last night before heading to bed. I crossed the room to the mantle, reaching for the power button when something Haley said stopped me.

"And this has nothing to do with the fact that AJ is leading the group?"

I could hear my heartbeat in the pause. The monitor crackled. The two women burst out laughing.

"Guilty as charged?" Erin said once they calmed down.

"Interesting choice of words."

"Oh, please. It's not like that. He's a professional."

"Was. When he was your trainer. Now, he's just a workout partner."

"Same difference," Erin said.

"If you really believe that."

I heard the whisper of sheets as they made up Mary's bed in silence.

Haley spoke next. "So what does Tom think about it?"

My chest tightened at my name. "He encouraged me to go for it."

"I still can't believe that. There's no way in a million years that Lucas would be okay with me working out with someone like AJ. He's so jealous."

"Yeah, I'm lucky to have Tom."

I smiled, feeling the love through the airwaves, and cut the power to the monitor. Placing it back on its cradle, I made sure to stomp up the stairs loudly.

"Erin, I'm home!"

"In Mary's room, honey."

Sure enough, Erin and our pretty neighbor, Haley Hughes, were folding laundry in Mary's room as our daughter played with her stuffed animals near the window.

"Hey, Tom. How's it going?" Haley asked.

"Happy it's Friday." I kissed Erin in greeting, then went over to Mary. "How are you?"

"Good, now that I got to yoga. Your wife was good enough to watch Andy for me."

It was only then that I noticed how good the willowy blonde looked in her yoga outfit: stretchy black pants and a

top that showed off her pale shoulders and more than hinted at her small, perky breasts.

Erin caught me looking, a smile forming at the edges of her lips. She just shook her head as I shrugged.

"Well, I better get back home to start dinner," Haley said.

"See ya, Hails."

"Good luck with the run tomorrow. Later."

When she was gone, I turned to Erin. "So you told him?"

She batted her lashes at me. "I did."

"And?"

"And nothing. We start tomorrow."

"Was he excited?"

Erin grinned. "I hope so."

I gathered her into my arms. "So I have some news of my own."

"Oh?"

"I got a promotion."

Erin's face lit up. "That's great!"

"Like...a no joke promotion. They're putting me in charge of the southeastern region."

"Wow, really? That's awesome, Tom."

"It'll require some traveling. And probably some later nights."

"Sure, sure. But regional manager...that's what you've been talking about wanting to do since you got there."

I scratched the back of my neck. "I know. Crazy, right?"

Erin pulled me close and kissed me—not like the greeting kiss we'd just exchanged, but a real, soul-searching, toe-curling kiss.

She drew back and glanced at Mary, who remained oblivious. "Tonight, we'll celebrate this promotion more...intimately."

"Sounds like a plan to me."

NINE

I woke to Erin getting out of bed. Shifting, I tried to look beyond her at the clock.

“Shh, go back to bed,” she whispered.

“What time is it?”

“5:30.”

I groaned and rolled over, deciding to take her up on her suggestion.

It wasn't until later that morning, when I'd flushed away the dreams and genuine sunlight slanted through our windows, that I realized where Erin had gone.

To AJ.

Talk about a morning jolt. Espresso had nothing on this sensation. I was up and out of bed in an instant, surveying the room. Erin's pajamas were on the chair in the corner. Her gym bag, usually hung on the back of the bathroom door, was gone.

Some of that panic I felt when I first walked into CEO Roger Hensley's office crashed through me. The sense that I'd done something very wrong—and that there wasn't anything I could do about it—was undeniable. But I had to remind myself that this was only a training session with a guy committed to the long seduction.

Nothing would happen.

Or so I kept telling myself.

Last night, Erin and I had made love. It had been sweet and tender—the kind that a man and a woman share after many years of love. We'd cut out all the noise—the kids, the hobbies, the fantasies.

Which unfortunately meant we didn't discuss AJ and her new training regimen. I knew that she'd have long sessions on the weekend mornings. I knew that she needed to leave

early, but would be back early, too. And that was about all I knew.

None of those musings helped still my rapidly beating heart until I received Erin's text around 9.

-getting breakfast with the others. you ok with the kids?

There were others. Of course. The triathlon training wasn't just a singular thing AJ was doing before he invited Erin to join him. He had a group all training together, and Erin was one of many.

I relaxed after that, texting her back to take her time and enjoy some kid-free time.

She came home around 10:30, more energized than I'd seen her in a long while. As she went on about her group and the things they had in common—and many of the things that they did not—I could barely keep up. Mostly, I saw the beautiful woman I'd married, passionate once again by something I hardly understood.

If this was a seduction technique, it was the strangest one I'd ever heard of. In the end, though, did it even matter? Erin was enjoying herself. She'd hooked up with a group that had nothing to do with kids or school or even marriage. It was an outlet she clearly needed.

"They're all so young, Tom. I feel ancient with them!" Erin laughed.

"Please. I'm sure most of it's in your head."

"No, seriously, I'm pretty sure I'm the only one over thirty. A couple of them are just out of school. And while they were all chatting away on our run, I thought I was going to collapse."

"They've been training a month already, you said? I'm pretty sure that if I had to run eight miles right now..." I shook my head. "There's just no way."

"You're right."

"So are you sad about losing your alone time with AJ?"

“I wonder who’s more upset, you or me?” Erin giggled. “Actually, if you don’t mind, I’m going to meet up with him this afternoon to go bicycle shopping. Need a good tri-bike.”

My chest tightened. “AJ’s idea?”

“Of course. Want to help me pick out my outfit?”

*

I did everything I could to keep my mind off of where Erin was and who she was with, but as one hour stretched into two, then three, that became impossible. I sat on the couch watching *Dora* with Mary as Martin constructed a Batman castle out of Legos and all I could think about was Erin and why it was taking her so long to pick out a damn bike.

When three hours passed, I texted. There was no helping it. It was that, or run around the house screaming.

-find something you like?

Her response came a full five minutes later, and sent a shiver through me every time I read it.

-definitely found something I like

Yeah, I read into that. Then, a second text came in:

-headed home. see you shortly

The previous three hours had felt long. Those following fifteen minutes felt like an eternity. I paced the house. Emptied the dishwasher. Sat with the kids as they played nicely. But my mind was on Erin and what could have happened in the last three hours.

“Success?” I asked as soon as Erin stepped inside our house. I’d helped her pick out her tight jean shorts and the loose, flirty blouse, but she looked way sexier in them after three hours of being with him.

She rolled in an expensive looking bicycle, glossy white and aerodynamic—a lot more space-aged than my Schwinn.

"All kinds of success," Erin said.

"Cool bike, Mom!" Martin said from the doorway.

"Thanks kiddo." She lifted it up. "Really light, too. I'm going to take it out for a spin tomorrow morning."

Martin pointed at the handlebars. "What are those?"

"Aerobars," Erin explained, straddling the bike. I stepped forward, holding the bike steady so she could curl into her aggressive perch on the narrow seat. She grasped the outer bars, which pushed her knees practically into her chest.

"It gets me low," she explained to our son. As she demonstrated, I couldn't help but stare at the way her jean shorts tightened across her ass. The hint of her white panties peeked out along the edge. As she lowered into the armrests and extensions, her shorts tightened even more, unveiling that the white panties were a thong.

"This position helps me go really fast," she said, still ostensibly to Martin, but I wondered if there was a double meaning there. AJ had to have helped her try out bikes, holding them upright just like I was doing. He had to have had this view.

"Cool, Mom. Can we ride together tomorrow?"

Erin hopped off the bike. "Of course, kiddo. I want to give it a spin."

She wheeled it through the house, towards the garage. I followed as Martin went back to his Legos.

"So three hours to pick out a bike? How many stores did you guys visit?"

Erin shot me a look as we passed into the garage. "Oh, I got this at the first store we hit."

My heart trembled. Erin saw the look, a smile forming on the tips of her mouth. She was baiting me, and I couldn't resist.

I said, "And it took you three hours to decide that that was the one?" I glanced at the bike as she leaned it up against her old one.

The way she trailed her fingertips along the tubes of the cycle sent a twitch along my cock. It was then that I realized that I was more than a little hard.

"Oh, no. This one felt right as soon as I took it for a ride," she said.

She stepped forward, closing the distance between us. Her smile grew.

"So...so what did you do the rest of the time?" My heart was trying to claw its way out of my chest.

"Well, I had to thank him for helping me shop, you know." She stopped right next to me, walking her fingers up my chest. Leaning close, until her lips were brushing my ear. "So we went back to his place and I fucked him."

Pow. Like someone had punched me right in the gut. I gasped. My heart practically popped like a grape. But it was my cock, flaring to life, that startled me most—and it was what Erin confirmed with her hand.

"You like that idea, don't you? That I'd be so dirty. You like thinking about me with AJ, naked in his bed. Don't you?" She squeezed me harder. She had all the evidence she needed.

"But you didn't, did you?" This was a test, I realized—a fucked up test that I wasn't sure if I'd passed or failed. "You didn't go back to his place."

Erin relaxed, kissing me on the cheek. "No. We went to Callahan's, the bar he works at, and just talked."

The idea of Erin spending time with another man at a bar was easier to swallow than her in his bed, but it still came with a queasy wave of emotions.

"Just talked?"

"Well, flirted, I suppose. It was fun. Does that make you jealous?"

"Yes," I answered honestly.

"Good. Now come on, let's get this dinner thing started."

*

It was like that for the next several weeks. Erin would work out, tease me a little, then we'd go back to normal life. Well, almost. She was also perpetually exhausted. She went from working out two nights a week—with yoga videos during naps—to doing something every day, be it cycling, running, or swimming.

Erin and I ended up shifting our schedules around to accommodate her new training schedule. Martin went to preschool for a half-day every day and we'd started Mary going twice a week, so those times gave her freedom to get a run in or a long distance ride. On Mondays and Fridays, she got up early and swam laps at the gym and I went in a little late, and we typically didn't see her on weekend mornings.

The thing about Erin was that she didn't do things halfway. She may have signed up for the triathlon mostly on a lark, but once training started, she was regimented. She was a straight A student in school. When she worked, she took her job very seriously. And when she became a mom, she was a mom 100%.

Including AJ and Erin, the triathlon training group was seven strong. They'd meet up on the weekends for a long run or ride, acting as a support network for when things got tough and dropout seemed the only way out.

"You'll appreciate this," Erin said to me one night as we settled down to dinner. "Liz told me that she almost dropped out of the group, until she saw AJ in his swimming trunks."

She no longer just talked about AJ, but she had a whole new cast of friends to report on—friends I knew intimately, although I'd never met them. Liz was single, in her late 20s, and, as Erin put it, looked *really Irish*, although when I asked if she had an accent, the answer was a disappointing *no*.

"So he's that inspirational, huh?"

“You tell me. You’ve seen more of him than I have.” She winked.

Since my confession, I’d told her a few more details about our run in, including the fact that I’d seen him naked. She found that incredibly funny and teased me mercilessly about it.

Erin was the newcomer in the group. Besides her, AJ, and Liz, there was a dating couple, another of Liz’s friends, and a guy AJ knew. They were all younger than Erin, but from the outside looking in, it seemed like this fact only bothered my wife, and after a couple weeks, became a nonfactor even for her.

I’m not sure what I expected when we’d begun this game with AJ, but this was a lot more real. It wasn’t a set-up. Their training schedule was relentless. Her body, which had always been on the sexy side of slender, transformed into a true work of art. She toned and tightened up. She lost the last of her pregnancy weight. She was in the best shape of her life.

I noticed it the most in bed. She took control more than ever, every muscle dancing over me in choreographed perfection. Some nights, I couldn’t keep up with her. Her stamina outlasted everything I had. The nights when Erin brought up AJ were always the most intense.

“He asked me if I wanted to get drinks with him some night.” Nearly a month had passed since the training had started, and while I’d been good and hadn’t mentioned him in the bedroom, Erin used him like a dominatrix with a whip.

Erin was riding me, her hands braced on my chest as she rocked her hips along my cock. She felt me jump at the mention of AJ and his invitation and grinned.

This was the first time since their bike trip that he’d asked her to do something outside of training. I was surprised that he’d had so much restraint.

“Did he,” I asked.

“He did.” She clenched down around me, underlining her excitement before adding, “I suppose he asked all of us. He invited the group out to Callahan’s.”

The bar he worked at. I’d Googled it, tempted to check it out myself before discarding the idea. Felt like that would be crossing the line.

“Yeah.” She sped her hips up half a notch, confident I wasn’t going to slip out. “I told him I’d love to meet him.”

She wasn’t asking for permission. She’d already made up her mind. Part of me was upset by that. The rest of me loved that she hadn’t.

“When?”

“Tomorrow night. Think you can watch the kids?”

This was all happening so fast. I felt like I was watching it unfold from outside of myself. “I can watch the kids. But I’m going to want details.”

It felt like a risk to ask, but it just slipped out.

“Details?” She played the coy wife so well.

“You know. If anything happens.”

Her green eyes flashed wide. “And what do you think might happen?”

“Oh, I don’t know. What usually happens when a man and a woman are attracted to one another and there’s alcohol involved?”

Erin leaned down. “Maybe some of this?”

Her kiss was tight with her smile at first. Relaxing, she pushed her tongue into my mouth. Her hips rose and fell faster as the kiss deepened.

“Is that the kind of detail you want to hear about?”

“Uh, Erin...” *Was it? Could I take that?*

Her voice whispered sweetly against my ear. “You want to hear all about how turned on I get with another man’s tongue in my mouth, don’t you?”

“Erin...” Her hips felt fucking fantastic, but it was her language that was getting me off.

“Don’t you?” The question became more of a demand.

“Yes.”

“I’ve thought about it so many times. He’s got these full, beautiful lips, and if his tongue is as strong as the rest of his body—”

“Oh, fuck, Erin.” I drove my cock up into her tightness, ready to let loose.

“In my head, his kisses always leave me breathless.” I felt her fingers join our union between our legs where she worked her clit, as if my cock wasn’t enough. “Think I’ll be breathless tomorrow?”

Something guttural left my throat. I didn’t even realize I was coming. I kept puzzling out what I was trying to say. When I realized what it was, that it was a growled *do it*, I was already spent and heaving on the mattress, seeing stars in the ceiling tiles as Erin crashed through a violent orgasm of her own.

Coming down, her body bathed in sweat, we cuddled together long enough that I thought maybe, just maybe, we’d fall asleep and not speak about this again. Erin had other plans.

“So Tom, I’m going to need you to do some recon?”

I was drowsy from my orgasm, but Erin’s mirth still registered in my ears.

“Recon?”

She shifted into a cuddle, tickling her fingers along my chest. “I need you to go to Callahan’s and figure out what AJ’s game is.”

When I looked at her, she was grinning.

“You want me to what?” It’s funny. I’d been thinking of doing that myself for days now, but now that it was coming from my wife, I couldn’t comprehend it.

“You’re my in. He doesn’t know you’re with me, and you’ve already got a report—”

“I ran into him for five minutes at the gym, like, more than a month ago.”

“So you’ll have to remind him who you are,” she said.

“Erin, I don’t think this is a good idea.”

Erin laughed. “Please, don’t tell me that you’re not at least a little bit curious to have a chat with your old sauna buddy...”

That was the problem with being married to someone for so long. She knew me too well.

She went on before I could figure out a new angle of protest. “That’s the carrot option. Don’t make me use the stick.”

“Should I even ask?”

“Not if you want to keep hearing about all the dirty things I fantasize about doing with AJ.”

“So what time does his shift start at Callahan’s?” I asked immediately.

Erin laughed. “Four, I think. You can cut out of work early and head over there. Should be pretty slow at first. We’re not going to meet up until later, so you should have plenty of time to get reacquainted.”

“You’ve thought about this, haven’t you?” I said.

“No more than you have, I bet.” She kissed me softly on the cheek, then rolled away. “Night, dear. We’ve got a big day tomorrow.”

Sleep didn’t come for a long while, despite my exhaustion.

TEN

Friday went by in a blur. One moment I was going over reports from the regional offices throughout the southeast. The next I was standing outside Callahan's on an overcast afternoon.

Standing there, I felt the same nervous energy that I did in the moments before I began a presentation in front of an important audience—same tightness in my chest, same sensation that my hair had caught on fire, same urge to flee. But I wasn't in a board room or a conference hall. I was standing in front of a bar where a guy who had the hots for my wife worked.

And I was there because she told me to be there. Me, now a top executive for a major commercial real estate firm, was about to go into the dingy bar and play undercover. It felt as exciting as it was incongruous.

I sized the place up. Callahan's looked like any other Americanized Irish pub I'd been to. The name was presented in Old English block type, painted gold and hung over a green awning. If I walked in and found someone playing the fiddle in the corner, I wouldn't have been surprised.

Instead, I found AJ.

He didn't recognize me at first, which was fine by me. I took a seat up at the bar and ordered a pint of Guinness when he came over.

AJ looked the same as I'd remembered him—and as I'd imagined him in all the fantasies I'd had with Erin. His dark hair was a little shorter than before, buzzed up the sides and styled into a faux hawk. His tribal tattoo peeked out of his black button-up shirt, both at the neck and where he'd rolled up the sleeves. His arms looked enormous, somehow so much thicker looking now that he wore clothes.

"You look familiar," I said.

AJ immediately looked at me suspiciously, and I felt like an idiot. How was I going to do this?

"Yeah?" He poured out the Guinness, sitting the dark drink in front of me.

I stumbled on, committed to this ruse. "You work at City Fitness."

He relaxed a little. "I do. You're a member?"

"Yeah. I'm part of the lunchtime crowd."

"Ah." He nodded. "Start a tab?"

I started to reach for my credit card when I realized that he may recognize the last name. Instead, I pulled out a twenty. "Nah, I'll probably be here only for one."

He didn't remember me. This was awkward enough that I was tempted to just finish my beer and get the hell out of there. I think I would have had I not come for Erin.

So for Erin, I said, "So you ever hook up with that client you were working with?"

This could have gone better. It also could have gone far worse. He stared at me like I'd said something in another language. Then, a flicker of recognition.

"Wait a sec. Now I remember you. Sauna, right? You were checking me out?"

"Yeah. I mean, *no*! I wasn't—"

"I'm just fucking with you. Yeah, now I remember you. I'm AJ."

"Thomas." His handshake was expectedly firm. "Nice to meet you, AJ."

"So what brings you in here on a Friday afternoon?"

I was prepared for this one. "Celebration, actually. I just got promoted."

"No shit. Expected?"

"Not really, no."

"The best things in life are unexpected, aren't they?"

"I'll drink to that." And I did. The Guinness was thick and cold and wonderful.

"I'll be right back. Need to check on the others and pour some drinks."

I looked around the bar as he did his thing. Erin would be in here later that night with the rest of her workout group. It was larger than I'd expected for a pub. Televisions showed baseball and soccer games along the back wall. A stage jutted out of the corner where live music could be played, although it was empty now. I imagined the space that was serving as the dining area was cleared on Friday and Saturday nights to make room for dancing. Erin was going to love it.

"Sorry about that. Work always gets in the way of fun, doesn't it?"

"No worries." He'd been serving a trio of coeds who were now giggling together and shooting glances his way. "If serving them drinks was my work, I don't think I'd mind at all."

AJ followed my eyes. Two of the three girls looked away immediately. One, the blonde, just smiled coyly and waved. AJ returned the smile, but not the wave.

"Too easy," he said.

"So you like a challenge?"

"Love 'em. Don't get me wrong, any one of them would be a lot of fun in bed, but after a while, it's just more of the same. You know?"

I didn't. At all. But I nodded like I did.

"Now, pulling all three would be more of a test, but even that wouldn't be too hard, I bet."

"Really?"

"You haven't spent much time with college girls these days, have you?"

It was mind-boggling. "So what would be a challenge?"

He said, "You asked me about the chick from the gym. The married one. Now there's a challenge."

The hairs on the back of my neck began to rise. So did the temperature in the room. "Any luck? It's been what? A

month or so? You hitting it yet?"

You hitting it? Where did that come from? It sounded disingenuous from my lips, but AJ didn't seem to mind.

"Not yet."

More heat. More hackles rising. "Not yet?" I asked.

"I'm playing this one slow. You can't rush it with a chick like this. You've got to hook her first, and then reel her in. I've got her hooked. Now, I'm just slowly pulling her in."

"You sure? Maybe she's not interested," I suggested. Was that hope creeping into my voice?

"Oh, she's interested."

And was that hope being dashed?

He continued. "You're a good looking guy. You can tell when a chick digs you, you know? And this one, Erin, digs me."

So there it was, her name. Any doubt that we were talking about my wife was gone. This wasn't going to turn into a comical case of mixed-up identities. He wasn't talking about another hot brunette at the gym. He was talking about my Erin.

"So it's just a hunch?"

AJ shrugged. "Here's the deal. She's meeting up for a drink tonight, right? It's with some others, sure, whatever." He waved those concerns away. "What I'm looking for is how she dresses, you know? I'll know for sure whether she's game for some bedroom exercises or not."

I ignored his grin and how queasy it made me feel. Said, "So if she dresses up for tonight, you'll think she's into you?"

"Nah, man. That's too obvious. It's the shoes I'll be looking out for. If she wears something sensible, then I've got more work to do. If she's wearing heels..." He shrugged. "I'd say the over/under before my cock is in her mouth is about two or three weeks."

"Jesus," I said incredulously.

"Hold on, need to check on the customers."

I watched him make his way up and down the bar, his words still ringing in my ears. He certainly didn't lack for confidence. It was clear in the way he carried himself. In the way he stopped to exchange a few words with everyone—especially the females. He spent the longest time with the three coeds, getting them to laugh and open up. The blonde wrote something down on a cocktail napkin and handed it to him with a wink.

"See? Not a challenge," Aj said, returning to me. He folded the napkin up and tucked it into his jeans.

"Not going to call her?"

"Oh, hell yeah I am." Aj laughed.

"What about the thrill of the chase, and everything else being more of the same?"

"More of *that* kind of same is never bad. Especially when they agree to do me all together."

My eyebrows went up.

Aj said, "Told you it wouldn't be that big of a challenge."

"If this is a typical Friday night, why are you wasting your time chasing someone you might not get?"

"You've got to see this chick. Hold on." He pulled out his phone and thumbed into the galleries. "I've got a pic. Here."

He held it out to me, and sure enough, there was Erin. It was a group shot with two other women, all three dressed down in sports bras and short running shorts. The redhead, I guessed, must have been Liz—she was cute with pale skin and freckles. The Asian girl was probably Liz's friend, whose name was escaping me, and of course, there was Erin standing between them. All three were attractive, but my wife was in another league.

"Let me guess, she's the brunette?"

"Totally hot, right?"

I stared at her smile, wide and genuine. They looked like they'd just finished a run, their bodies glistening, their expressions edged with exhaustion. Erin still managed to look beautiful.

“She’s not just a body, either. She’s cool, you know? Different from most of the chicks I’m with.”

I nodded, although this insight more than any other made me truly anxious. This was Aj’s way of saying that he liked her personality.

“You like spending time with her,” I said, tasting that bite of recklessness that had been with me since I’d stepped in here. “You like her.”

Aj cracked up, but I couldn’t help but wonder if there was something genuine there—something his macho act buried as a reflex.

He said, “This isn’t middle school, man. We’re not passing around notes and shit. I’m just saying she’s a cool chick, not some ditz.”

“Or maybe you just think that because she hasn’t spread her legs for you,” I said.

Aj grinned. “If she comes in wearing heels, I’ll have all the encouragement I need to keep on course.”

“Slowly reel her in,” I added.

“The taller, the faster.”

“Well, hopefully you’ll get stilettos. I better head on out.”

Aj pushed my twenty-dollar bill back to me. “On me, bro.”

Success. I was elated.

“Thanks, man. Maybe I’ll stop by next week to see how things are going.”

“Do that. I’m usually here Friday afternoons and evenings. Mondays and Wednesdays, too.”

“Cool. And good luck tonight.”

We exchanged an awkward fist bump. “Take it easy, bud.”

I glanced around one last time, picturing the place packed, brimming with conversation and music. Erin would be in the midst of it all, and Aj would be right there with her.

“You too. Later.”

*

One beer wasn't enough to even make me buzzed, but I decided to walk around the neighborhood anyway just to clear my head. The streets were bustling with an urban energy that we didn't have out in the suburbs. It made me feel young again, and for a moment I could pretend that I was still in my twenties, carefree.

Was this how Erin feels when she's with this group—when she's with AJ? If so, it made me happy for her. I wanted to encourage that even more, not for any selfish reasons, but just to give her a break.

I sat in the park, watching college coeds jog by in skimpy workout clothes. Watching young professionals gather in clusters to share a smoke and celebrate the start of the weekend. Watching the world hum and thrive, and everyone else ready to see where it would take them.

*

The kids greeted me with cheers when I came in the house—although Mary's was more of a happy stomp compared to Martin's hug. They knew they'd be left alone with me tonight, which usually meant that they got to watch more TV than they did with their mother. I suspected that Erin knew my tactics, but kept her disapproval to herself.

Erin walked in putting on a pair of teardrop earrings that drew out the green of her eyes.

"Hey, Tom. Happy Friday."

Her dark hair was loose, held out of her face with a hairband that made her more youthful than the Mom I knew. In her blouse and dark, cropped jeans, she'd fit right in with the rest of the crowd at Callahan's. I could almost believe that she wasn't my wife and the mother of these two kids, if she hadn't crouched down, swept Mary into her arms, and kissed Martin on the nose.

Looking up from amidst the kids, she asked, "Success?"
"Yes."

"Great!" She set Mary down with a kiss on her head and rose, then threw her arms around me, pulling me tight. She'd put on perfume tonight, the smell of lavender and something spicy tickling my nostrils. That perfume wasn't for me alone. "Any insights I should know about before I head out?"

I looked down between us, checking out her footwear. My heart skipped a beat when I noticed that she wore heels, not flats. And not just any heels, either. She wore the black Jimmy Choos she'd worn out with Jo—the last time she'd flirted heavily with another man. Maybe AJ was on to something with the heels.

I kept that one insight to myself, though. Didn't seem appropriate in front of the kids.

"We'll talk later, but he did mention some fishing analogies."

Erin laughed. "So I'm a fish, huh? Being reeled in? That sort of thing?"

"Basically."

"Don't worry about me, Tom. I'll always be your fish." She kissed me, long and sweet. I tasted her lip gloss before it was washed away by the wet brush of her tongue. Would AJ be tasting some of this, too? That uncomfortable thrill ran up my spine at the thought.

"Have fun tonight, Erin. Don't think about me."

"Oh, I wasn't planning on it." She smiled. "I'll call you when I'm on the way back."

"Take a cab home if you've had too much to drink."

Erin touched my face. "I don't think I will. We've got our first river swim tomorrow morning. Don't want to be hung over for that."

"Well, just in case, call a cab."

"Okay. Good night, honey. See you in a few hours."

Her sleeveless blouse showed off her lean arms, and the tight jeans looked painted on. But it was the heels I couldn't take my eyes off of.

Despite the label, they were simple black pumps crafted of fine, black patent leather. The toes were pointed, the towering stilettos even more so. I'd bought them for her one Christmas at a hugely reduced sale, but still they were more expensive than anything Erin would ever buy for herself. She was too sensible to drop that much on shoes.

Now she wore them out for AJ. And to AJ, they didn't just represent expensive tastes. They represented opportunity.

*

The next few hours moved at a crawl. No texts. No calls. No communication. And unlike those Tuesdays and Thursdays I used to suffer through, I couldn't reassure myself that she was working out and unable to communicate. She was out at a bar, having fun with a man who wanted to sleep with her.

I was in bed when she got home, reading something on my Kindle without processing any of the words. When I looked at the clock, I was surprised to see that it wasn't even 10:30.

A part of me was disappointed, but mostly I felt relief.

I listened to her set her keys down in the front hall and pour herself a glass of water in the kitchen. My stomach fluttered at what stories might come up in the next few minutes. What confessions would she share? How would I react? Both questions had unknown answers.

Hearing her ascend the stairs, each step slow and deliberate, I put myself in her shoes. Was she dreading this moment? Was she agonizing over what she knew she had to tell me, racked with guilt?

She entered the bedroom without a word and leaned on the doorframe. Her expression wasn't tight with guilt. If

anything, she looked content—satisfied? The unspoken word sent a not-so-unpleasant thrill straight through me. She sighed, half-smiling, like she'd just set her fork down after a decadent meal.

I lowered my Kindle. "Good night?"

Erin fixed me with a stare. "It was fun."

"How fun?"

The change was subtle. She lowered her head and looked up at me through her lashes. Her voice dropped half an octave. But it made me hard even before I comprehended it. "You really want to know?"

I licked my lips. She carried her heels in her hand. "Yes," I said.

She pushed off of the doorframe and swayed inside the room, carefully shutting the door behind her.

"I'm not sure I want you to."

She dropped her heels to the floor and climbed onto the bed, crawling over to me on all fours. My eyes dipped into her cleavage, where the blouse plunged. Had she left all those buttons undone for me? Or had she done that at the bar?

She trailed her hand up the inside of my thigh, closing it over my cock and balls.

"You want to know if I did something bad tonight," she said.

When her mouth closed over mine, my imagination went to work on the flavors on her tongue. I tasted her sweet lip gloss, the bitter undertone of beer, and that was it before she pulled away with a smile.

She said, "I know what you're thinking."

"What?" I asked.

"Wondering if that taste is him?"

I couldn't deny it if I wanted to. "Was it?"

"Maybe." She unbuttoned her shirt. "Or maybe it was just some chips and salsa we split."

Beneath her shirt, she wore a sexy black bra, fringed in white lace. I'd never seen it before. It looked fantastic on her tits, designed to lift and display. Was AJ treated to this view before her husband was?

Shimmying out of her tight jeans revealed a matching thong.

Erin rose in my arms as our lips met again, angling her kisses down into me, her hands working my scalp. I grabbed her ass, squeezing the smooth cheeks. "So tell me about tonight. Anything fun happen?" I asked between kisses.

"Hmm...not sure you've earned any details yet."

I was confused long enough for her to push me back onto the pillow and crawl over my face. Her excited tang filled my nose and overwhelmed everything else. The gusset of her thong clung to her pussy, damp and dark. She pulled it aside and lowered herself onto my mouth.

I'd gone down on Erin plenty of times before, but it had always involved Erin on her back and me willingly between her thighs. I'd controlled the pace—when to come up for air, when to come up to fuck. I loved to please her, but before, it had always felt like my gift to her.

This didn't feel like that at all. This wasn't me giving her anything. This was her taking.

Not that I was complaining. There were worse things than having a hot woman press her pussy against my lips.

"Mmm...yes... That's a good boy, Tommy. Just like... that..."

She ground her hips against me, rolling forward and cutting my air off for a second. I curled my hands around her ass, trying to regain some control, but she pushed them back down to the bed.

She tut-tutted. "No hands, Tom. Or no details."

I got a brief respite when she knelt up. I thought she was going to move on to the main event. Instead, she just took off her panties and returned to her place over my head.

I decided to make the most of it. It was another part of the game, I figured. She wasn't going to offer me anything until she got off, so I went to work making that happen as fast as I could.

Half the battle was trying to get enough air to stay conscious. Grabbing the headboard, Erin smothered her sex over my face, riding me like a human Sybian. I fought for control, as best I could with no hands and just my tongue and lips as leverage, and lost that battle quickly.

I stopped trying to set the pace, instead focusing everything on Erin. She thrust her hips across me, my tongue dancing like lightning, slithering along her clit and her swollen labia. When she ground her hips in tight circles, I speared my tongue deep into her pussy, simulating what my cock would do. Those were the hardest moments to deal with, when sound and air turned into sweet memories and all I could do was weather the moment.

Erin went wild over me. When I wasn't being smothered in her taut thighs, I heard her squeal and gasp. I heard the woodwork of our headboard groan under her tight grip.

"Ah...Tom. Right there. Right...THERE!"

There was something freeing in my limitations. I didn't have my hands to worry about. I wasn't trying to time my orgasm with hers. My only duty was to get Erin off. In that heated moment, I lived for her orgasm.

Her cries rose like an aria as her thighs clamped down. I opened my mouth wide, covering as much of her pussy as I could. Her world quivered over me. This is what the brink felt like. This was Erin's sexual singularity.

And then I sucked.

I may have passed out—if not a full loss of consciousness, then something damn close. Buried in the throes of Erin's orgasm, my world was reduced to field of stars on a sea of black. The stars choked out everything until the sweet, soft experience of Erin's pussy was yanked away and oxygen returned.

Erin was sweaty and breathing hard at my side. She still wore her lacy bra, but she'd pulled the cups down and her nipples looked red.

"Ah..." she kept saying, her eyes closed, a smile touching the corners of her lips. "Ah..."

My cock raged—and for once, I was hard for something other than my wife-sharing fantasy. Had I enjoyed that? Had I enjoyed being used like a sex toy?

When my wife rolled over and switched out the light, I got confused. I heard her shift, taking her bra off, then settle into the pillow.

"Good night, Tom. Thanks for watching the kids."

"Erin?"

"Mmm hmm?"

Aren't you going to tell me about AJ? Wasn't that the deal? "Do you have something to tell me?"

"Like what?" She already sounded half-asleep.

"You know..." I sounded like a petulant child in my ears, but I had to know.

"I do. Maybe I'll tell you tomorrow. If you're good. Now, good *night*, Tom."

There was finality in her voice. Anger bred out of the frustration, but also something else. Something unexpected. Like my mixed emotions when I thought of her with AJ, something about the situation aroused me. Confused, I rolled over and tried to find sleep.

ELEVEN

Erin got up early Saturday morning for her group workout. She was already pulling her wetsuit on when I opened my eyes a few minutes before six. Her weekend workouts always started as early as possible so that they didn't cut into her time with the kids, but I figured today's would be different. Not only was her group out last night, but today was a river swim and would have theoretically been shorter than a long run or ride.

Beneath the wetsuit, I noticed she'd put on a bikini rather than the one-piece she swam her laps in. She zipped up, removing the bikini from sight, but not her cleavage. Crossing over to me, she leaned down and treated me to more of it. She wore the sexy string bikini that lifted her tits and was more for show than functionality. She smelled fresh from the shower, despite the fact that she was about to go work out and get smelly again. Was she also wearing a touch of make-up?

"I'll see you later, honey. Oh, and when you take a shower, make sure you shave. No more chafing."

Bleary eyed from sleep, I watched her go. The wetsuit hugged her curves like neoprene skin. She'd be with AJ most of the morning, and if something had happened last night...

Last night. What *had* happened last night? The question wasn't just about AJ and Erin, I realized, but about Erin and myself. She'd come home fiery, that was for sure, and something had gotten her there. A kiss with a strange man certainly would have done it, but she would have told me if that's what had happened, right?

I didn't know anything anymore, although I realized as I got out of bed that I didn't have the urge to chase her down the street and stop her from meeting up with her friends. I

trusted her. She loved me, and I loved her, and that would always be true.

I brewed up doubt along with my coffee. This was strange new territory for the both of us. What if she wanted AJ more than me? He was young, fit, exciting. How could I compete with that? I didn't think I could. Not on his level. He'd already affected my wife in subtle ways that I was only now noticing. She'd become more assertive since he'd entered her life. I thought of last night. She knew what she wanted and took it. And then this morning and her directive for me to shave. At some point, this fantasy had become less about myself and more about Erin.

And you know what? That made it even more exciting for me. I was tagging along on her ride for a change, had no fucking clue where we were heading, and for the moment, was totally cool with that.

The kids woke up. They were a great distraction. We had breakfast, walked over to the park, and played on the jungle gym. The birds were still tweeting around us. The sun still sailed through a cloudless blue ocean. I waved as other parents joined us—husbands and wives whose names I didn't even know but whose lives were probably just as complex as my own. It seemed so terribly wrong on the one hand, and so fitting on the other.

Haley Hughes and Andy joined us at the tail end of our park visit. Andy and Martin quickly ran off to play, leaving me alone with Erin's blond mom-friend. This was the first time I'd seen Haley since I'd overheard her conversation with Erin a few weeks back. She probably didn't know anything about the naughty game we were playing, but I still felt the awkwardness of judgment.

"Erin training this morning?" Haley asked.

"Yeah. They're doing a river swim."

Haley shook her head. "I'm not sure how she does it. I can barely keep up with Andy, and I've got Tess to help out.

Erin's got two kids and still finds the energy to train for a triathlon."

And fuck like a vixen, I didn't add. "She's always been a determined woman."

Haley pushed her thumbs into the back pockets of her jeans. She glanced at me, something on the tip of her tongue that never materialized. Instead, she said, "Lucas's like that, too. Driven. Focused."

"Where's Lucas?"

"Home. He's not really a park kind of guy." She laughed. "Now the neighborhood pool...he'll go to the pool with us every single time."

I thought of all those attractive suburban moms in their bathing suits. Lucas and I didn't see eye-to-eye on many things, but that's something we could agree on. "You guys headed there after this? I'm sure Martin would love to splash around in the pool."

She shoved me playfully. "You men are all the same."

"Hey, Erin shouldn't get *all* the eye candy." It just slipped out. Haley looked at me in that same thoughtful way. This time, she did say what was on her mind.

"So that doesn't bother you?"

"What? Going to the pool?"

Haley giggled. Shook her head. "No, I mean Erin and...the training stuff."

"Oh, you mean her personal trainer?"

"Yeah. That. Lucas would never let me do that. He gets so jealous whenever a guy even talks to me."

"I'm talking to you. Should I be worried?" I said, drawing a laugh from Haley. That felt good.

"Maybe, but he's not here."

The mischief in her eyes was surprising. It reminded me that she was not just *Erin's friend* or *Lucas's wife*, but a red-blooded woman as well.

I shook off the observation. "I trust Erin. She loves me. She's having fun. Why should I be upset?"

Haley sighed, more to herself than me. “She’s lucky. You’re a good guy, Tom.”

I waved it off, although it was flattering. “Well, she’s in the best shape of her life, so I’ve got a few selfish motives here, too.”

“She sure is.”

Mary came lumbering over at that point, demanding to be pushed on the swing. Haley and I went our separate ways, and eventually we left before we could catch up any more.

At home, I considered waiting until Erin returned before taking my shower—it was amazing how much destruction a four- and two-year-old could level in just five minutes—but something told me not to disobey her directive. So I jumped in the shower, made sure Martin had an iPad and Mary was flicking through pictures on my phone, and took the speediest shower possible (while still making sure my face was as smooth as razor could make it).

I checked my phone after that. It was past ten o’clock. The river was a good half-hour away, but even factoring that in, they should have been done with their workout ages ago. And no text.

Of course, that made everything harder. I set my ringer on high, just in case I missed a call or a text, and paced the house. I read to Mary when she asked for it and helped Martin build Legos, but mostly I was a nervous wreck. That bikini she’d worn, hot pink with tiny white polka dots, was the most daring one she owned. That wasn’t saying much since Erin had never been one to slut it up on the beach, but it was haltered and tied together in big, loopy bows, and that was daring enough for the both of us.

Why had she chosen that one? My stomach squirmed as I searched for the answer and came up with another question: had she made sure that I saw it on purpose?

I got a text at 11, telling me that she was headed home. It was followed by a photo that instantly got my attention.

There was a caption:

-sorry, we all decided to hang out on the floating dock for a while.

The image was one of Erin, AJ, and Liz. They'd stripped their wetsuits off and were all dressed in the swimwear. Liz had a bikini, too, fire engine red to match her hair; it covered more skin than my wife's, but she had more cleavage to display. AJ had a long pair of tight trunks—not speedos, thank God, but these were bad enough.

What my eyes kept coming back to, again and again, was the way Erin's arm was hooked around AJ's muscular midsection, and his arm was draped about her shoulders. They looked chummy. Too chummy. Sure, Liz was there, but she seemed like a bystander, caught photo bombing another couple's picture perfect moment.

Behind them, the river flowed, wide, murky, and choppy than I'd expected. If my emotions were a river, that's the way they'd look.

The three of them were laughing at something. Having a good time. I zoomed in on Erin's face. That joy was genuine. Even though I wasn't there, I found myself happy for her. Yet...

I swept the photo over, zooming in on her hand, peeking out the other side of AJ's torso. It was loose, her thumb and forefinger not even touching his tanned flesh, but her other three fingers were definitely making contact.

Another text came in, overlaying the photo.

-see you soon. hope you shaved. ;)

*

"So how was it?"

Erin came home around 11:30. She'd stowed her wetsuit in her bag, favoring a pair of short jean shorts and a

loose top. I could see her pink bikini through the gossamer blouse. It wasn't wet, so she'd not gone for a swim in it.

She looked tired, but satisfied. It was a look I'd become accustomed to after her longer training sessions. I recognized it; it was the same way I felt after I'd landed a major deal, but only after long days of relentless negotiation.

"It was incredible."

Of course, there was a darker explanation for her sleepy satisfaction—one that involved Erin balanced on AJ's hard cock.

"Was it harder than swimming in the pool?"

"Oh my God, yeah. The current was insane." She put her bag down and greeted the kids with a hug. "We were swimming against the current, but I think only AJ made it beyond 20 yards."

"Where did you guys swim, exactly?"

It was a conversational question. I didn't even listen to her answer beyond the generalities. All I kept wondering was whether something happened between her and the mighty swimmer AJ.

It took me a moment to realize that she'd stopped talking and was staring at me with a look of amusement.

"What?" I asked, trying to remember what question she'd just asked.

"You're jealous."

"Mommy, what's *jealous*?" Martin asked.

"Something that Daddy said he wasn't going to be." At least her glare appeared to be good-natured.

"I...I'm not jealous."

"And now he's not telling the truth. What do we say about not telling the truth, Marty?"

Martin looked up at me, haunted, and dropped his voice to a whisper. "It's bad."

Erin laughed, tussling his hair.

"That's a good boy." She said it looking right at me, as if to say, *And you haven't been.* Picking up her gym bag, she headed for the stairs, running her index finger along my chin as she passed. "Well, at least you followed through on one thing."

"Are you in trouble, Daddy?" Martin asked when Erin went upstairs.

"I don't know, bud. Can you be a good Big Brother and watch Mary? Daddy's going to go help Mommy clean up."

"I can do that!"

He was such a good kid.

The shower was already running when I got up to the bedroom. I stripped out of my clothes before entering the steaming room, my cock bouncing erect before me.

"I was hoping you'd join me," Erin sang from the stall.

I pushed the shower curtain aside and stepped in. Erin was covered in suds, scrubbing her loofah between her thighs.

"Hello, Mr. Jealous."

She wrapped her arms around my neck and pulled me into a warm kiss.

"I'm not jealous. I'm just..."

"Jealous." She giggled. "A little."

I couldn't lie to her, although I think I was trying to lie to myself more. I thought of that picture she'd texted and the way she'd touched AJ's body. There it was, a tightening in my chest that made it uncomfortable to breathe. There was no denying it.

She said, "Well, you probably have cause."

That feeling tightened a whole lot more. "Something happen?"

"Mmm...maybe."

She ran her soapy hand down across my cock, which jumped at her touch. She stroked it a few times, watching the suds build on the webbing of her hand before glancing back up at me.

“But I wouldn’t want to make you any more jealous.”

I started to deny it until I saw that look in her eye—the one from last night, just before she sat on my face. It dared me to lie to her again. This time, I held my tongue.

“You know what I could really use?” she asked. She stepped back, leaning against the wall in open invitation. I knew what to do.

Unlike last night, when I attacked her pussy in the hope of getting information from her, I was pretty sure she was done sharing for now. So instead, I decided to drag out my oral ministrations. It was amazing what you could do with the showerhead after a few weeks of practice.

Pulling the showerhead from its scone, I stepped close and kissed her deeply before lowering to my knees. I could smell her through the curtain of soap and water, rich and tangy. I brushed her pussy with the setting on spray, sending pinpricks of heat along her blossoming lips.

That’s when I discovered that I wasn’t the only one to shave this morning. Erin had always been good about keeping her bikini line tidy, but this morning she’d gone further than ever before. In addition to grooming her dark curls into a neat wedge, she’d shaved her lips completely bare.

I shot a look up at her. Before I could get a word out, though, Erin threaded her fingers through my hair, pulled me close, and lifted a leg over my shoulder. I pulled the shower’s spray away before it drowned me, swiping my tongue across those buttery smooth lips. Wow, she was silky.

I fumbled to set the showerhead’s setting to pulse, sweeping it across her clit.

“Uh, yes,” Erin moaned. She rose up onto her toes, her hands tightening into fists in my hair. Water flooded my nostrils as she mounted my face.

I directed the drumming water against her inner thighs as I focused my tongue on her clit. When her grip on my hair

relaxed, I pulled back and pointed the throbbing spray against her pussy. Her grip tightened, her muscles drew my face close again, and I cycled back to the softer touch of my tongue.

Literally rinse and fucking repeat.

After a few cycles, I was able to do more than just fight for breath. I was able to admire her pussy, and how the smooth skin yielded to even smoother petals inside. I was able to admire her body undulating over me, and the way her tits bounced as she rode me. Her eyes were squeezed shut. Her mouth hung open and slack. Her chest rose and fell in tight swells.

Was she thinking of AJ right now? Was she remembering the hard cut of his personal trainer body?

Taking a deep breath, I dragged the spray against her sex and drove my tongue deep. She was close; I gave it to her with both barrels.

"Oh, yes. Yes!" The rest of her cry was lost in a garble of tumbling moans. The leg that she'd draped over me tightened, dragging me right up against her. I licked and sucked as my oxygen sputtered. My tongue joined the thudding water on her clit. She needed to get off—I needed to breathe.

"Ah. AH!" *AH!*

I tore my face away as she turned into jelly, smearing down to a crouch along the wall.

"Now that...just proves that how much of a...bad boy you are."

I stood, my knees achy, and set the shower fixture back in place. "Bad enough to deserve a reward?"

Erin rolled her eyes. "You're as obvious as AJ is, you know that?"

Was it possible to grow used to that tightening feeling, or would I just pass out one day from oxygen deprivation?

"You're killing me, Erin."

“So sorry,” she said. “I suppose you deserve something...”

Her face was level with my cock, so it was easy for her to reach out and swiftly suck me into her mouth. I was so wound up that I nearly blew at first pass. I looked down at her, admiring the way her cheeks caved in as she sucked.

Erin pulled back, releasing me with a pop, although she continued to pump me slowly with her hand. “You’re so hard,” she said.

“For you.”

She raised a brow. “Just for me? Or for what you think I did with AJ?”

“What *did* you do with AJ?”

“I told you. We hung out on the floating dock. He liked my bikini, by the way.” She went back to sucking me. When I closed my eyes at the pleasure, I saw the photo she’d sent me. Of her and AJ. Of her arm on AJ’s torso.

“I bet he couldn’t take his eyes off of you,” I said.

Erin pulled off again. “He couldn’t. That was nice.” She stroked me a couple times, pondering her next sentence. “I thought his eyes were going to pop out of his head when Liz, Hope, and I laid out topless.”

My eyes nearly popped out of my head, too. “Topless?”

“Well, we were on our stomachs, of course. But yeah, he definitely got an eyeful. You like the idea of that?” Her handjob grew more rapid. “He even helped me refasten my bikini when the others all left. I may have flashed him. Hope you’re not mad.”

I exploded. Erin was ready for it, directing my blast against the shower wall as she milked me.

“Well, I guess that answers my last question.”

“Did that really happen?” I asked when I’d recovered.

Erin got to her feet and kissed me gently on the nose. “Maybe. Maybe not. What do you think?”

She slipped out of the shower before I had a chance to answer.

*

I'd learned early on in my career that in sales, the pushier you were, the less success you had. I'd built my success on that concept. While I never landed the blockbuster deals of some of my more aggressive colleagues, I'd accumulated a steady stream of smaller ones. People liked working with me. Even though I was selling the same thing as the next guy, they didn't feel like I was selling anything but to their best interests.

I realized that that's what I needed to do with Erin. The more I demanded for details, the less likely she was going to give them. So I decided to stop demanding. In fact, after that shower, I decided to stop bringing AJ up entirely.

Instead, I focused on Erin and her training. And when I did, I realized how excited the triathlon itself made her.

"So how's the training going?" I asked later that day. "Think you'll be ready for race day?"

"The training's great. The program is kicking my...butt." She looked at the kids. "But you know what's weird? I've never felt so in touch with my body. Even when I was pregnant and everything felt alive and new, I didn't feel quite this way."

"So you run a half-marathon, and what else?" I'd been so focused on her evolving relationship with AJ that I'd never really gotten into the details of her race.

Erin nodded her head. "It starts with a 1.2-mile swim, then the 56-mile bike ride, and finally the half-marathon. Crazy, isn't it?"

"You mean that the longest run you've done was the Turkey Trot last Thanksgiving, and now you jumped into an ironman?"

"Half ironman, but yeah."

"Well, you don't do things part way."

"Thanks. Kind of crazy what the body can do when you put your mind to it."

I looked at that body, but it wasn't the race that first came to mind.

*

My strategy helped my sanity a little, but it didn't stop Erin from teasing me. If anything, she seemed to ramp it up. On Sunday, she texted me after her ride that she was grabbing lunch with AJ. She came back three hours later, all smiles and no explanations. She was daring me to ask where she was. I didn't take the bait, although it was hard not to—especially seeing that she'd changed into a flirty top and that pair of skinny jeans I liked so much.

She was fucking with me. She had to be. I found it hard to believe that she'd let anything happen between her and AJ without asking me if I was okay with it first—without explicit permission.

Yet I had my doubts. The woman who'd smothered me between her legs Friday night didn't seem like the type who asked for permission. Had she interpreted my fantasy as consent? I thought about our conversation the night before Callahan's. It had been vague and purposefully salacious. It was words spoken in the heat of the moment. Nothing more, right?

She started texting openly with AJ, laughing at whatever was on the screen of her iPhone. I felt like I was watching one side of the conversation, yet couldn't understand any of it.

Around dinner, she wandered out of the kitchen, phone in hand.

"AJ?"

I couldn't take it any longer. I had to ask.

Erin shot me a sly smile. "He's going to meet me tomorrow morning for my swim at the pool."

Typically, she did her Monday and Friday swims alone before I went in to work.

“Yeah?”

“He says a little competition is healthy.” Her phone buzzed. Erin read the message and laughed, but didn’t share what was said.

Competition is healthy. Was that really what he said? Or was that what Erin was suggesting between me and AJ? As in: our relationship had become complacent, settled, safe—a little competition was just the thing we needed.

That night, I took up the challenge. Our lovemaking was harder, more vigorous, but it was still lovemaking. I was with her, and I intended to make her realize that she was with me, not AJ or anyone else. When she cried out my name into her pillow, I felt the quick tingle of victory.

We didn’t have sex every night, but we probably did it every other. Erin didn’t do anything that should have generated suspicion. In fact, if AJ had been a woman, I wouldn’t have thought twice about the texts and the name-drops, the *AJ says my swimming form has improved* or the *I got a great new recipe from AJ, the perfect pre-run meal*. But he wasn’t a woman. He was very much a man, and very much my competition.

A little competition is healthy. But was this just a little competition?

She didn’t only talk about AJ, I had to remind myself. I was just more sensitive to it. She still talked about the kids over dinner. She showed me videos of Mary dancing at the park and drawings that Martin brought home from preschool. She talked about her training, too. About how great her tri-bike performed, or that she needed to buy a new pair of running shoes.

She brought up the others in her training group—Liz more than anyone—but I started to put together a picture of the other four, painting them in wide generic swaths. Liz’s friend, Hope, was one of the best swimmers of the bunch and the Asian woman I’d seen in the photo from Callahan’s. Lance was AJ’s buddy and dependable wingman, who

apparently was only training for the triathlon for the bragging rights. And Hayden and Ellen were the couple of the group, both employees at the gym. Reading between the lines, it seemed like the three guys had once been one hell of a trio of bachelors until Ellen came in and tamed Hayden.

I had other things to distract me. Big things. Like my new job.

When Roger Hensley said that this wasn't a paper-pusher's job, he wasn't kidding. And when he said he wanted to see results, he meant immediately. The first order of business in those first few weeks was to restructure the southeast sales team. I didn't let anyone go—morale was already strained with such a junior guy getting promoted over all those who thought they'd be jockeying for the position—but I did put in some immediate efficiencies. Under-performers got smaller accounts, over-performers got the fatter ones. Some were happy. Some hated it. Some left. No one likes change, but change is what Roger was expecting and I was going to be its primary agent.

That said, I realized that the best way to manage change was to do it in person. I'd put off my visits long enough. If I wanted to lead this new division, I needed to meet the people that I'd be leading, and I'd put off that trip long enough. We had three remote offices, one in Orlando, one in Atlanta, and one in New Orleans, and I needed to travel to all three.

Erin was awesome when I told her I needed to go out of town for a week and a half. I felt bad, not only because it would be the longest stint I'd left her alone since the kids were born, but because of the impact it had on her training schedule.

"Don't worry about it, honey. I'll figure it out. I've got the jogging stroller when Martin's in school at the very least."

I always liked the idea of Erin running along the bike trail, pushing a laughing Mary in front of her—the

quintessential MILF.

“Are you sure?” I asked.

“Seriously, don’t worry about it. Maybe my mom can come stay with me over the weekend or something. And I have Haley to lean on if I need to. I’ll work it out.”

“You’re the best. And I’ll make it up to you.”

“Yes, you will. Let’s start later tonight.”

I shivered, already thinking ahead to what that meant.

Her eyes flashed. “And besides, I’ve always got AJ to keep me company when I get lonely.”

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TWELVE

-i miss you

-miss you too

Long distance via text was a strange new experience that I got used to pretty quickly. After five days on the road, I was fine wishing Erin a good night without hearing one another's voices. I thought that would have been strange and lonely at first, but it was easier than I thought.

The loneliness did come. The video chats with the children—another marvel of modern technology—helped on the one hand, and actually made things worse on the other. Nothing was as lonely as shutting your computer down to an empty hotel room after seeing your family snuggled together on the other end.

Luckily, work came to the rescue again. Not only were my days filled with meetings as we worked out the logistics of my new expectations, but my evenings were taken up by nervous execs wanting to make sure they still had the same job security as always. I told them all the same thing: if you're doing a good job, there was nothing to worry about.

Erin didn't bring up AJ as much as normal, but texting wasn't as conducive to casual name drops. She'd cut her workouts back a bit, doing what she could at home and with the jogging stroller.

Still, I got this nagging feeling every time we spoke on the phone and Erin *didn't* bring him up—like the absence was purposeful. Was there a reason she didn't bring him up? Or was I being paranoid?

By Friday, I couldn't contain it. After wishing the kids goodnight over the phone, I finally mentioned him. "So no AJ this week? You must be going into withdrawal."

As soon as the words left my mouth, though, I knew it was a mistake.

“Oh, I’ve seen him. We’re getting drinks tonight, actually.”

Ka-thunk.

“What about the kids?”

“My mom is staying for the weekend.” I could practically see the smile that must have been on her face. “I can stay out as late as I want. No jealous husband to give me a hard time.”

“I’m not jealous.” That was the knee jerk reaction.

“Then we’re going to have to do something about that...”

*

Later that evening, while I was flipping through channels in my hotel room, the first text came in. Attached to it was a picture.

-having fun. wish you were here

In the picture, Erin was posing with Liz. There wasn’t anything overt about her outfit. I was sure that I’d seen the sleeveless turquoise top before. But had it always been that tight? Had she always looked so good in it?

I didn’t take the bait. As hard as it was, I didn’t respond. But I didn’t have my phone far and my heightened heart rate settled in like a long distance runner.

That first text came around 9:30. I didn’t hear from her again until closer to midnight—right about the time I figured she’d turned in for the night.

-you still awake?

I considered whether to reply to that one, too, knowing where the conversation would probably lead after she’d sent that photo.

-yes

-have you been thinking about your wife?

Her reply came immediately. Was she at home now? Still out? Or...or at AJ's? With her mom spending the night with the kids, it was technically possible, although the idea made me queasy.

-hello?

I blinked. Then texted:

-yes. have you been good?

-such a relative term, isn't it? if i told you i'm at aj's, you'd probably consider that a 'good' thing, wouldn't you, naughty boy?

My cock strained as I read the text over and over again. She's at AJ's?

-hurry, love. he's taking a shower now, after his shift. we don't have much time

She was at AJ's?! No way. No fucking way! I checked the time on my phone. I couldn't remember if Callahan's held bar hours or restaurant hours. If it was restaurant hours, things definitely lined up.

-you're trying to figure out if i'm telling the truth, aren't you?

I finally answered.

-are you?

She didn't answer, of course. Not directly.

-it makes you hard, doesn't it? thinking about what might happen in just a few short minutes. or maybe you're thinking about what already happened?

She was right, I was hard. Really fucking hard.

-take it out. i want you to play with it while i wait for aj

I did as the text told me. Even in the confines of my hotel room with my wife on the other end of the line, I felt a stab of shame as I wrapped my hand around my cock—after all, it was hard because I was thinking about what my wife was potentially about to do with another man. But that quickly faded as her next text rolled in.

-so is it out?

-yes

-and hard?

-very

-god that makes me wet

I started to type a reply, but hers beat me.

-almost as wet as when i touch aj's bare chest. it's so smooth. did you know he waxes it? i love your little curls, but that only makes the difference even hotter...

My cock jerked in my hand as my balls reacted to her text. I still remembered AJ from the locker room, and her description matched my memory. The guy was all tanned, muscled skin. No hair.

-are you stroking yourself, thinking about me licking down aj's beautiful pecs? he's got abs like a gq model.

I beat my cock faster as my mind filled with the images she was painting. I hadn't come since I was with her last Sunday and was already on a hair trigger. All it would take was a few more—

-gotta go. night night!

Was that AJ coming into the room, wrapped in nothing but a towel? I pictured Erin jumping up to greet him with a kiss, her hand loosening the wet terry cloth before wrapping around him.

I shot all over my chest as the sordid display spiraled into depravity: Erin sinking down to her knees; Erin looking up at AJ with a mouthful of cock; Erin getting bent over the bed as AJ fucked her...

When I opened my eyes and looked around, I was alone again. My heavy breathing filled the quiet space. My suitcase was open on its stand and my laptop sat on the desk, but the rest of it wasn't mine. The rest of my life was hundreds of miles away—would it still be there when I got home?

Darkness tightened the room down to a postage stamp before I remembered to breathe. I cleared it before I even realized it was a panic attack.

I knew Erin was most likely just playing with me—that she was probably at home, texting from our bed before going to sleep herself. That was my safety net. No matter what she said or did, chances were that it was all just an elaborate fiction.

But how cool was that? A year ago, I wouldn't have thought Erin was capable of maintaining this kind of game. It still surprised me to think that it was my wife and mother of two at the other end of those texts, not some figment of fantasy. Whatever facts were or were not behind those texts, Erin was showing a sexual side of herself that was all new to me.

And if she wasn't making it all up? Well, that was what gave this game its edge, right? The risk was what caused my heart to race and my pants to tighten. The thought of AJ and my wife was the imagined monster lurking in what was most certainly harmless shadows. As much as I wanted to know the truth, I knew that I shouldn't.

For example, the next day when I got a photo text from Erin showing her in a figure-hugging pair of running pants and a bright, green sports bra with the caption, *here's what you're missing but AJ gets to see*, I felt jealousy and

excitement slice through me. If I knew without a doubt that there was nothing going on, would it cut so deep?

“Who’s the brunette?”

I was having lunch with the manager of the New Orleans branch, a towering, sandy-haired businessman named Brian Benoit (pronounced with a tee). He noticed the photo come in, but hopefully not the text.

“That’s my wife,” I said with a touch of pride.

“Wow, man. Congrats. Must be nice to have arm candy like that on tap.”

I thought about what Erin would have thought about being called arm candy. I could just see her face, eyes narrowing, mouth working the term silently. Made me laugh.

“It’s pretty nice. She’s training for a triathlon right now and let me report to you that the results are good.”

“I can see that. You got any more?”

I was so proud that I almost opened up the gallery to show more of her off. I remembered the photo of Erin with AJ—which I hadn’t been able to delete despite knowing that I should—and all the questions that would bring up. Brian Benoit was one of my employees now, a guy I needed to supervise. Last thing I needed was him to start raising questions about Erin.

“Maybe later. Let me tell you more about the restructuring.”

Brian set his coffee down and looked at me hard. We went from friendly bro-banter to business.

“Look, not to question your leadership, but I don’t think what you’re proposing is going to work. Maybe it did when you were in charge of the DC office, but that doesn’t mean it’ll work here in New Orleans. Things are different here. Even commercial real estate isn’t one-size fits all.”

I’d heard a similar line from the other two branch managers. No one took kindly to some young upstart stirring the pot—at least Brian looked to be closer to my

age. It was alpha male posturing. They had to put up some fight or their teams would think less of them.

"I hear what you're saying."

"So you'll leave our office alone?"

"No, can't do that," I said.

Brian shifted. He wasn't gritting his teeth, but I could tell he wanted to. "This region has actually made a profit. Don't lump us in with Atlanta and Orlando. You don't need to fix what isn't broken."

"But you can always make it better."

For some reason, I thought about Erin at that moment. Is that what I was doing? Making something better? We were still discovering things about each other, that was for sure.

Benoit went on. "I hear what you're saying, but listen to me for a second. The boys in accounting are projecting record sales now that the economy is finally showing signs of recovery. We know that."

"Okay," I said.

"Tinkering with structure and process now could jeopardize those profits. I love that you're willing to take risks. I really do. But there's a smart time to do that, and then there's now."

He had a good point. I'd been over the numbers at this office. They were up, across the board. In fact, they'd never been down. Not since Hurricane Katrina. I wasn't sure that Roger Hensley had the New Orleans office in mind when he said he wanted to see results. I also knew that I couldn't just bend over for Benoit. Alpha male posturing, I reminded myself.

"Your objections are noted, Brian, and I appreciate you voicing them. But we're going to try it my way."

*

His objections *were* noted. They stayed noted. I kept going back to them over those last few days away from

home. Not about the New Orleans office—I was confident that my restructure wasn't going to be detrimental to profits—but about when was the smart time to take risks.

Right now wasn't the smart time to take risks with Erin. Together, we had a near perfect life. We had financial stability, a healthy family, a dynamite love life, and most importantly, we loved one another. Why had I ever thought that now was a good time to tinker with that?

I called home on my way to the airport Wednesday morning. I couldn't wait any longer. I needed to tell Erin that I loved her, and that I was done playing games.

When Erin's mom, Eleanor, answered the phone, my blood pressure rose. Eleanor was still there? I thought she was just staying the weekend? And where was Erin?

"Morning, Tom. How's the road warrior life going?"

"Lonely, but thankfully over." I took a slow breath.

"Erin's out dropping Mary and Martin at preschool."

"Ah." Right, it was Wednesday. "You're still there?"

"Just getting ready to leave. I actually just came back last night. Erin had some personal training thing she didn't want to miss. That girl is dedicated to this race, that's for sure. You know, Tom, after this race, we need to fatten that girl up. She's so skinny!"

Ice entered my veins. Last night was Tuesday, sure, but Erin hadn't gone to those sessions with AJ since she'd begun training.

"Well, thanks for staying with her and helping her out. I know it's been a huge help for Erin."

"Oh, you know I don't mind at all. I'll take any excuse to see the grandchildren."

"It's good for Erin, too. She doesn't get out enough with her friends." *Keep it casual. Breathe evenly.* "Did she go out much while I was gone?"

Well, that sure didn't sound like a jealous husband much? I tried to cover.

I said, “She’d mentioned some friends asking her to go meet her for drinks last week. I told her she should go if you were around.”

That sounded more reasonable.

“She mentioned friends, but no, she didn’t go out at all. Except for when she was swimming, running, or biking.”

I blinked, confused.

“Not even Friday?”

“Nope. I think she was considering it—and I told her that I could do the bedtime routine with the children—it’s not like I don’t have any experience there—but we ended up staying in and watching a movie.”

So she really had been leading me on.

“Um, thanks. Maybe one of these days, we can get her out of mom-mode.”

Eleanor laughed. “Good luck with that one. Want me to tell Erin you called?”

“No. I’ll see her in a few hours, anyway.”

I felt gutted.

“Well, I’ll see you around, Tom. Take care.”

“You, too.”

I hung up the phone and stared out the window of the taxi as the New Orleans marshland zipped by. So everything really *was* an elaborate ruse. Thinking of something, I switched my phone back on and found the photo she’d sent me Friday night. Armed with what I knew now, I realized that this must have been from the night she’d gone out with AJ and the crew a few weeks back. The top confirmed it—same as what she’d worn back then.

I shut off the phone and shoved it into my pocket.

“Everything cool, *mon cherie*?” the taxi driver asked.

“As a cucumber.”

And it should have been. The news was a good thing, after all. The alternative—learning that she really had gone back to AJ’s Friday night—would have been terrible. Hadn’t I just called home to tell Erin that I loved her and that we

were making a giant mistake? Hadn't my stomach just bottomed out when I'd learned that she went out with AJ last night without telling me? So why was I so fucking disappointed now?

I had a two-and-a-half-hour long flight to think about it. To let the confusion tangle about me. Touching down at home, knowing that Erin was out there, waiting for me in baggage check, I still had no answers.

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THIRTEEN

"I heard you talked to my mom this morning."

Erin's voice was too casual. I studied her as she drove us home, hands at ten and two, eyes on the highway. She felt my eyes on her. The corners of her mouth turned up in a smile.

"Yeah, I forgot you were dropping the kids off today."

"I've had to pick up your slack since you've been gone."

She didn't say it in a mean way, or even in an accusatory way. But it did knock me off balance.

"So you were checking up on me? Making sure that I was being good?"

Here we go again. The game. The tease. Yet this time, armed with what I knew, it lacked the punch it had given me before. Don't get me wrong, my cock still flexed and my heart skipped half a beat, but the sensation was muted compared to where I'd been a week ago. Still, I played along.

"And have you?"

"Depends on what you mean by good."

"If you told your mother what you've been up to, would she think you were still her good little girl?"

Erin laughed. "No, I doubt it." She took her hand off the wheel and reached for mine. "I've missed you, Tom. As soon as the rugrats are in bed, I'm going to show you how much."

"So AJ didn't take care of those needs?"

"Oh, I wouldn't say that, either..."

She went back to driving. I went back to my thoughts. I wish I didn't know what I did. I wish we could have gone back to the blissful ignorance of last night, when it still felt like we were hurtling down the path to ruin. Now, ironically, I felt manipulated. The sexual creature I thought my wife had turned into was just playing the part for me.

It made me think of stockings. Way back when we'd first started dating, I'd tried to get her into stockings—stay-ups, the kind that required garter-belts, anything other than the pantyhose she wore with skirts when it started to get cold outside. I wasn't a fan of the pantyhose, but I loved the idea of Erin in sexy hosiery. I tried everything—bought her thigh-highs for her birthday, for my birthday. For Christmas, I got her an expensive teddy with detachable garters. It wasn't that she never wore the things. She did on special occasions. But I never got the feeling that she was as into them as I was, and ultimately, that killed it for me, too.

Now that I knew she was making up her infatuation with AJ, it killed my fantasy, too. Or at least severely muted it. I liked the idea of Erin having a naughty side—of letting her own desires get the better of her just once and giving in. But she was as in control as ever. This was just another line-item on the list of *awesome things a wife can do*. AJ was just another way to turn me on—like the stockings—not something that turned *her* on, too.

*

Erin arched back, her dark hair fanning out around her. She was close. I felt it in the ripple of her pussy and saw it in the tightness of her abs—now more well-defined than ever. I pulled her leg higher up my chest until it looped up over my shoulder.

“Ugh, yes. Fuck me, AJ, fuck me...”

His name incensed me—but not like before. This anger wasn't arousal dipped in jealousy. It wasn't that inexplicable feeling of self-indulgent betrayal—the cuckold's mental cat-o-nine-tails.

She wasn't thinking about AJ, no more than I was pretending to be him. It was like knowing that she was faking her orgasm.

“Agh!”

I rose onto my knees, taking her off the bed with me. Bracing her leg against my body as I held her other thigh, I drilled down into her, watching my cock dance in and out of her sodden sex. She wasn't going to fake this one.

Wrenching down with the leg on my shoulder, she thrust her hips up as she climaxed. I buried myself in her neatly groomed pussy, wondering if any man would ever witness such beauty. Probably not, but the thought of AJ's bare shaven manhood there was what tipped me over the edge.

"That was...vigorous." Erin looked exhausted as she splayed out beside me. She let out a sighing laugh. "You missed me?"

My anger had fled with my orgasm, but not very far.

"I talked to your mom this morning. I know you stayed in Friday."

I stared up at the ceiling for the longest time as Erin lay silently at my side. When I looked at her, I was surprised to see anger etched in her pretty face.

"You shouldn't have brought my mom into this."

"I didn't...it just came up in conversation. I was telling her—"

"You were digging. You don't trust me."

"No. I mean, of course I do—"

"You don't. You haven't. I knew from the moment we started playing that this conversation would come. You get jealous. I know you, don't forget—"

"Oh, I wouldn't forget that." It works both ways. I knew her, too. "You don't like wearing stockings."

"What are you talking about?"

I shook my head. "Nevermind. It's just that...I knew you were just doing this for me all along. It's just...it's just a little disappointing."

"Ah, stockings..."

She rolled onto her back and stared up at the same ceiling that had me so interested.

"You ever stop to think that I like making you happy?" she asked. "That making you happy actually makes me happy?"

It was not a new concept, but I guess I'd never taken the time to analyze its merits. Did that mean that I wasn't the selfless person I fashioned myself to be?

She went on. "I guess you haven't. Believe it or not, I actually enjoyed the effect that wearing stockings had on you, even though I wasn't crazy about the actual stockings...all that business with the garter belts was too much."

"But that's just it, I don't want you to do something just for me. I mean, don't get me wrong, I love that you do that, and I think you're so sexy in them, but it would be so much hotter if you were as into it as I was. Like, think about last week, when we picked up *The Avengers*—"

"Hey, I actually really do like superhero movies," Erin said.

"I know. Exactly. I like nights when we're watching a movie that we both are into. I mean, how did it make you feel when I fell asleep during *Anna Karenina*?"

"I liked that you chose that one for me?" she said. I let her chew on it until she finally went on. "So your stockings obsession is my period film."

"Hey, I actually really like *Pride & Prejudice*."

"You like *Keira Knightly*. And that was hardly a period piece. Let's put on the BBC version and see if you feel the same way."

"I will if you wear a garter belt while we do."

Erin laughed up at the ceiling. "I love you, Tom. With all your many, *many* quirks."

"Hey, now."

This was good. Without even realizing it, the tension had dissipated. It always amazed me how good talking something through was, especially with Erin. She really was my best friend as well as my lover. Didn't make the real

subject of tonight's agitation any easier to talk about, though. Erin started us off.

"We're not really talking about lingerie or period films, are we?"

"No," I said, drawing it out to two syllables. This time, it was Erin who waited for me to speak. "For a time, I let myself believe that you were actually as into the idea of being...naughty with AJ as I was. It made it easier for me to deal with. I mean, I don't really understand the attraction myself other than that it turned me on."

I paused, playing back what I'd just said in my head and hearing how self-centered it was. Erin turned onto her side, watching me as I worked it out. I kept my eyes straight up. I said, "It makes you happy when I'm happy, right?"

I caught her nod out of the corner of my eye.

"It goes the other way. When you're happy, so am I. When you're turned on, so am I. The thought that you were so...that someone else could..." How the hell was I going to say this without it coming out as terrible? Without saying, *I love that my wife can sometimes be slutty*? Erin did it for me.

"You liked the idea that I had a darker, naughtier side."

"Yes!"

"And when you learned that I'd just been making everything up to tease you, it made you think that I was just doing it for you all along."

"Exactly."

I didn't realize she was so close until I felt her breath against my ear. Her voice was low and husky. "I may have made up the circumstances, but not the attraction."

My cock sprang to life. Erin was there, too, her hand encircling my member as if to check my true reaction. She must have found it, because when her face filled my vision, dark hair spilling around her tanned face, it was lit up.

"I'm going to ask you something, Tom, and I need a solid, honest answer. Okay?"

“Sure.”

“Can I fuck AJ?”

My breath caught. My cock raged. But my answered stumbled at the gate. “I... uh... Let’s stop playing this game.”

She shook her head, quick and short. “No more games. I’m asking you for real. Would you be okay if I slept with another man?”

“Yes.” As soon as I said it, I knew it was true. A lot went into that statement—into that truth—but there was no dancing around it. That’s what I wanted.

“Last night, he kissed me.”

The blood drained from my head and filled my cock so fast it left me spinning. Something was different about this time. Something felt more authentic.

“Erin, no more stories—”

She kissed me, tentative at first, then slow and deep. Then something hungrier, harder. Her hand squeezed around my towering erection, stroking it before pulling out of the kiss.

“Just like that. That’s how he kissed me.”

“Erin...”

She climbed onto me, my cock rising like steel as it split her. Her green eyes never left mine. If she was making this story up, then the story turned her on as much as it did me.

“AJ has been flirting with me since we started training together. I mean, when he was my personal trainer, we flirted, but he’d always been professional. Out of the gym, though, he was just a guy. I’ll admit, it was nice to have someone so attractive giving me so much attention—and I loved the effect my little stories had on you. But that was it. I mean, it wasn’t exactly the same as your stockings analogy, but I can see the similarities.”

“So he didn’t kiss you.”

Erin’s lips curled up, her eyes faraway. “When you went away, I thought it would be fine. I’d focus on the kids, on

cleaning the house. I'd let my body rest a little as I cut back on my workouts—I've been so exhausted these past few weeks and I didn't even realize it until I relaxed. Even if Aj had been successful in seducing me, I don't think I could have managed a marathon session of fucking—not after running *half* a marathon earlier that day."

The *marathon session of fucking* registered like a pulse of heat across my body.

"They all went out Friday, but I honestly just wanted to stay in and take it easy. I drank some wine. Watched a movie with Mom. Teased you on the phone. Other things..."

She raised an eyebrow at me, letting me know exactly what *other things* meant.

"We swam in the river the next day. Of all the parts of the triathlon, the swimming is by far the hardest. I was on the swim team in high school. I thought I had good form—decent form, anyway. But everything's different when the current is against you. You need to have great form or it's going to sap all the energy before you even get on your bike. Afterwards, Aj suggested he go over some techniques at the pool. He still hadn't picked up a new client during his Tuesday nights, so I figured, why not?"

She eased in and out of me, drawing the story out with her hips. I felt dread begin to climb up my chest, even though I knew how this story ended. I loved it.

"Other than Hope, Aj's our best swimmer. He glides through the water like a seal. It's beautiful."

Jealousy got into the mix. I loved that, too.

"We met Tuesday evening. We did some drills. Like always, he pushed me until my entire body was sore, but I already started to feel the difference his tweaks made. I was so excited that when I got out of the pool, I hugged him."

She'd started looking at something distant. When she snapped back to reality, she stared down at me.

My voice caught a little, reluctant to leave my throat. "And then he kissed you."

“It just sort of just happened. I’d been imagining it for weeks, thinking how tempting it would be, but how I’d turn away at the last minute.” She licked her lips subconsciously. “Caught up in the moment with AJ’s hard body against me and you...you gone for the past week and a half...I was horny. And so when he kissed me, I let him.”

I didn’t know whether to believe her or not, but the image that had formed didn’t go away. Neither did the thickness of my shaft. Erin felt it, squeezing her pussy around me as she picked up speed.

“God, you feel so big.” Erin’s brow knitted. She bit her lip, stifling her mews and moans.

I grabbed her bouncing hips, encouraging her to fuck me faster. She bent forward, taking more of me inside with each torrid rock. I pulled her close, dragging her head down to my shoulder. As I kissed her neck, I could feel her blood pulse beneath my lips.

She didn’t say his name, but I knew she was thinking about him now. I knew it the same way that I knew she really wasn’t thinking it earlier. Pulling my knees up and planting my feet flat on the mattress, I rammed upwards with each of her back strokes. Our skin slapped. My cock bore deep, forcing a groan with each thrust.

Panting, she gripped my hair, squeezed her face against my shoulder, and barely contained her squealing orgasm. Dropping down onto my pelvis, her pussy enveloped every square millimeter of my cock. And squeezed.

“Uh, Erin. Fuck!”

She yanked my head back by the hair as I detonated deep inside of her. All the energy that had been building for months—the good, the bad, the forbidden—was released in that moment. It nearly took my head off. I think I may have lost consciousness for a moment before I remembered I needed to breathe to live.

In the aftermath, panting and cuddling in each other’s arms, our conversation slowly returned. She’d admitted to

kissing AJ, but had she really? She'd alluded to doing that—and more—over the last couple months. Was this just another story?

"You don't believe me, do you?"

"I don't know," I said honestly.

She was still straddling me, my softening cock still buried inside her. She shifted to get more comfortable and I popped out.

"Why don't you ask AJ yourself?"

"I don't... What?"

With her face inches from mine, her smile was infectious. "Did I stutter?"

It was exciting, the thought of getting that kind of insight directly from the source again, but still, I wasn't sure. "Seems kind of convenient to me, just showing up like that. Too obvious."

"Hm, you're right." She paused in thought. "You need an excuse. Why don't you..." He eyes went wide. "...go ask him to be your trainer!"

"Uhh..." I didn't know what to say, but this didn't sound like a good idea. Erin disagreed.

"No, no, hear me out. It's pretty great, actually. Not only would it give you a more natural way to be my double agent, but you'd get into shape doing it. And he wouldn't connect us because you'd be at the gym in the city, and I'm out here in Tysons."

"And we just happen to have the same last name."

"Our last name's *Smith*. I don't think it'll be a problem, even if it came up, which it won't. AJ is a first name kind of guy. I doubt he even knows my last name."

For the first time since this began, I didn't feel like I was the driver. Even when Erin had held me down between her thighs and withheld the details of her night out, I'd felt in control of the situation. Now, as I stared at her bright expression, I was pretty sure that I was about to relinquish it.

“Okay,” I said, my chest clenching. “I’ll try it.”

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FOURTEEN

Back before we had the kids, Erin and I played indoor soccer. Actually, I played first in an intramural league in college, and got Erin into it after we'd graduated, more as a way to diversify our dating options beyond dinners, movies, hikes, and sex (well, sex was usually involved in all of those things).

Unlike my attempt to get her into stockings, which never really worked, she took to indoor soccer like a fish to water—or AJ to my wife. She'd grown up playing outdoor soccer, of course, but indoor was a different beast. The confines were tighter, the pacing much faster. Even the play style differed, indoor being chippier—or just plain dirtier. I always thought that I was more competitive until I watched Erin ram her elbow into a guy's solar plexus just to give her an opening to drill a shot through the top left of the goal. It was around that time that I realized: *I'm going to marry that chick.*

Point is, when I'd convinced her to join that league, I had no idea that there would come a day when I would be over the ticky-tack play of the game, and Erin's desire to play would continue to go strong. She only stopped playing, in fact, when she got pregnant with Martin, and probably would have rejoined if her friends still played.

As I walked into Callahan's on that lazy Friday afternoon, I wondered how similar this situation was to indoor soccer. Was Erin more into this than me, only I just didn't know it? Had she made it her own?

I pushed all of it out of my head when AJ looked up at me from behind the bar. This wasn't a choice moment to let my insecurities do the driving.

"Oh, hey man. Thomas, right?"

"Hey, AJ. Been a while."

We greeted each other with one of those masculine handshakes, more a cross between an arm wrestle and high five than anything else. It was a good sign. It meant familiarity.

“So how’s it been?” I asked after ordering a pint of Guinness.

“Busy, man. So busy.”

“Still training for the triathlon?”

He nodded, filling up my pint. “Yeah, that. Got some other things lined up, too. Career stuff. But yeah, still training. Race is only three weeks away.”

He’d changed his look slightly, sporting something closer to a mohawk than the styled crest I’d seen before. The sides of his head were practically shaved clean. He was so different than me—like in every way. I never would have thought that Erin would have gone for his look, but there was no doubt that she did.

“And what about that hot chick?”

AJ grinned. “Erin. Yeah, that’s going real well.”

Hearing him say her name would probably always set a bomb off in my gut. Hearing it along with that grin intensified the emotion.

“You and her...”

“Not yet.”

“More of a challenge than you thought?” I asked.

“Some things are worth the wait. She’s definitely one.” He glanced down the bar, where a couple guys had just settled in. “Excuse me, I need to check up on them.”

I was left alone, that last statement dangling. I swallowed half my beer and waited.

When he was back, I wanted to question him more about Erin, but the probe felt forced, so I moved into my cover story. “Hey, I actually have an ulterior motive for coming in here.”

He suddenly looked wary. “Yeah?”

“Nothing serious. But I was wondering if you could help me get back in shape. You know, like, be my personal trainer.” I could have stopped there, but I was nervous, so I rambled. “It wouldn’t be all the time, since I travel a bunch, but—actually, maybe you could give me some pointers on what to do when I have to travel. You know, like at the hotel gyms. What kind of exercises...” I trailed off, feeling like an idiot.

AJ stared at me for a second as he dried a pint glass. “Sure.”

That was it? “Should I contact the gym?”

AJ barked a laugh. “You could, but you’d pay about twice as much as I’d charge you personally, and they’d pay me about half what you would.” He set the glass back on the shelf, pulled another from the dishwasher, and began drying it. “But here’s the thing. I don’t half-ass this shit. If you want to train with me, then we’re going to take it seriously.”

“Fine, whatever works.”

We settled on the details: how much he’d charge, how often I’d meet. We agreed to meet every other week, starting next week, in the morning at City Fitness. He said it was his personal time, and we’d look like we were just working out together.

After that, we turned to small talk. AJ was a huge football fan, it turned out, so we talked about pre-season. He was a Giants fan, so he gave me a hard time about the mess that the Skins were. I returned with the bullheaded optimism that all DC fans exhibited every year, despite the reality of the situation. It was actually pretty fun.

AJ was a predictable guy. Other than the blind spot I had for whatever went on with him and Erin, I could usually anticipate what he’d say before he said it. It came second nature to me after years in sales—this wasn’t a corporate setting and AJ was a different beast than most of my customers, but the skills translated.

I bought him a beer as we talked. Earned his trust. And all the while, I kept my focus on the ultimate prize.

"Anyone drop out of your group? The triathlon training, I mean?"

"Naw, man. We're a tight bunch. No quitters."

"Think everyone'll be ready? Three weeks isn't much time."

"Yeah, we'll be ready."

"And you and the brunette? That's not much time for you to close the deal, either."

He laughed. "Sales guys like you always see things as black and white. The deal is either on, or off. When it comes to the body—training, conditioning, dieting, whatever—it's more a transition. A constant work-in-progress."

That was more poignant than I thought AJ was capable of. I wondered if he'd read it in a book.

"So you and her are still in *training*? Must be tough on you."

"All training should be. Otherwise, you're doing it wrong. But it always should be worth it, too. And let me tell you, I got a taste last Tuesday and fuck, man, it's so worth it."

"Yeah?"

"Oh yeah. She has these perfect lips, right? Like, not thick, Angelina Jolie DSLs or anything, but nice and soft. Perfect for kissing."

I shifted a little closer to the bar to mask my erection. "I take it you tested that theory?"

"Oh yeah. Poolside. I'd shown her a few techniques on her stroke—you know, how to move her arms, position her hips, that sort of thing. Gives me an excuse to touch her."

I'd heard all this from Erin, yet it was still so damned exciting to hear. "That's nothing new though."

"Right. Chicks like her make my job worth it. But Tuesday, she was so excited. I swear, man, I could have taken her then and there."

"But you didn't?" I asked, heart in my throat.

“Naw. I let her off with a kiss. But damn, man, it was some kiss. She’s so ready for it.”

I took a deep breath, looking around, like all the guys around me were judging. Was she so ready? Or was AJ projecting? Probably a little bit of both.

He pulled out his phone, checked the text, and laughed. “Speak of the devil.”

“That her?” I asked. She knew I was here, talking to him. That text was as much for me as it was for AJ.

“It is.” He tapped a quick reply and got a fast response. I wanted to grab the phone out of his hand. Instead, I sat there like a dolt, drinking my beer.

AJ let me in on the conversation a minute later.

Erin: we still on for our monday morning swim?

AJ: most def

Erin: don’t forget what you promised me

AJ: as long as you remember what you promised me...

My mouth was parched in a way that no beer could quench (but I tried anyway with the rest of my Guinness).

“What did you promise her?”

“She wants to see me wear Speedos.” AJ shook his head. “I never should have admitted that I owned a pair.”

Erin wanted eye candy. That was a funny thought, but not the first on my mind. “And what did she promise you?”

AJ grinned. His phone rumbled again. Then again. He checked, smiled even broader.

“Check it out.”

Erin: holding up my end right now

The photo was equally as cryptic. I studied it quickly, my face hot. Legs, I realized, emerging from foamy bath water. Erin’s legs. I could recognize them anywhere, her tawny skin glistening. She’d had a pedicure at some point, her toenails painted bright red. And in the foreground was a razor, held in her hand—her left hand, complete with the rings that symbolized our life-long bond.

“I don’t understand...”

He took the phone back and slipped it back into his pants. "She knows I'm a bit of a freak about hair."

"How did *that* conversation happen?" I asked.

"Oh, you talk about all kinds of shit. You have no idea."

I swallowed hard.

"Anyway, she wanted to see me in Speedos, so we made a deal." He grinned.

"That mean you're doing to seal the real deal Monday?" I asked. I lifted the pint to my lips, only to find it empty.

"It's definitely tempting. And I definitely could, but I'm not going to. I'm saving that special moment for race day. She's going to be so ready by then that she'll be begging for it." He looked at my empty glass. "Can I get you a refill?"

"Nah, I better..." I pulled out my phone, intending to pretend to have received a text from my wife when there was one at the ready:

-so smooth... ;)

"I need to get home. How much do I owe you?"

"It's on me. Thanks for the chat. One day, I'll see if I can arrange for you to see her. You'll see what I'm talking about."

"Sounds good."

I waited until AJ was serving some other customers and my erection flagged enough that I could lope out of there without being too obvious. Then I loped the fuck out of there.

*

On the drive home, it was the imagined details that ate at me. The playful banter. I could hear Erin's mocking laughter and the way she must have teased him. *Why am I not surprised that you own a pair of Speedos?*

Want to see them? You're going to have to do something extra special for me...

And then there was that text, so perfectly timed. She could have sent that at any time, but she chose the moment that I was with AJ. It was evil. It was hot. By the time I got home, I was on fire.

She and the children were already sitting down at dinner. “Look, kids, your father’s home.”

Martin and Mary were still young enough to get excited about that. Martin jumped out of his chair and gave me a hug. Mary smiled and waved from her booster. But it was Erin I focused on. Her amusement was quieter, but no less real.

“So how were the drinks?”

“Informative.”

“Come on and join us. We can talk about it later.”

*

As it turned out, *later* didn’t come until much later. After dinner, Martin wanted to watch a movie—apparently Fridays had turned into a regular movie night over the last two weeks—so I popped in *Despicable Me 2* as Erin put Mary down.

When Erin joined me, she couldn’t stop from smiling at me, laughter dancing in her eyes as she passed us a bowl of Pirate’s Booty “popcorn”.

Good thing kids’ movies are short. I kept looking over as the light of the television washed over her face. All the exercise had given her a chiseled beauty that made me pinch myself to think that she was my wife. She didn’t look ten years younger or any of that nonsense, but I didn’t want her to. She was more striking now, at 33, than she’d ever been in her life.

I put Martin to bed as Erin cleaned up. She finished before me, and I walked into the bedroom just in time to witness her shimmy out of her tight jeans.

“That’s new.”

Her panties were something between a thong and boy-shorts and did sinful things to her ass. The chocolate brown satin matched her hair and the strap of her bra.

"I thought of AJ when I bought them."

The look she offered over her shoulder bordered on cruel. She released her lustrous hair from its ponytail and shook it out. When she turned, I caught a glimpse of the bra before she peeled it off: the way it plunged, the touch of lace along its fringe. Classic, yet updated—like so many aspects of Erin.

Her nipples sat high and hard on her round breasts.

"AJ shared an interesting text with me," I said, approaching her.

"Oh yeah?"

We met each other at the bed. I collected her in my arms, leaning down to kiss her. I held her close as it turned into more, pulling her near naked body against me. Her tanned skin was hot beneath my hands.

"Did you really..."

"Shave myself for AJ?" she completed. "Why don't you feel for yourself?"

She took my hand and pulled it toward her panties. I slipped my fingers beneath the band, sliding lower. Her landing strip was gone. Nothing remained but smooth, supple skin.

"You like it?" she asked. She started to unbutton my shirt, teasing out each button one by one. "It makes me feel so naughty."

I licked my lips. "Why didn't you tell me about your deal?"

She pulled open my shirt, pushing it off my shoulders. "You were going on about the *Avengers* and stockings. Besides, wasn't it more fun to discover it this way?"

It was, but it wasn't. "You should have told me."

"Next time I decide to shave myself for another man, I'll make sure to let you know," she said. She pulled the belt

free, then undid my pants. "But you'll be the first to experience it, lover."

She positioned me on my back and slipped out of her panties. I held my breath as she straddled my face, putting me face to face with what she'd done for AJ. Her lips were glistening, her pussy shaved completely bare.

That nearly ended me. It was as beautiful as it was wrong. So clean. So plump. And all for another man.

Erin smothered me with her sex before I could say a word. She rocked her hips forward, filling my mouth with her tangy sweetness. I pushed my tongue between those succulent lips, marveling at how supple her bare skin was, and was rewarded with a moan.

"That's good, Tom. Eat me, you sexy man."

I did as I was told, the complications of the previous moment falling away. I loved giving Erin pleasure, and there was something sexy about her aggression.

"You like it?" she taunted above me. "You think AJ will approve?"

She crushed me between her thighs, cutting off sound and air for one uncomfortable moment.

"It feels so good. Think I should keep it like this?" She ground her clit against my mouth. "I think so, especially if I'm going to be entertaining guys like AJ. Guys with certain expectations."

Oh, my God. Guys? Plural?

She wrapped her hand around my cock and stroked it, saying, "You like that idea, don't you? You like thinking about me with other men?"

No! Yes! I didn't know?

"Or maybe you haven't thought that far?" She jerked me faster. I felt my balls swell. "Well, I have. You think all their stares have had no effect? You think that AJ's the only guy who's hit on me?"

Fuck, I mumbled against her cunt. She shuddered. She was close, too. This talk was getting her off as effectively as

it was me. Her hand flew along my cock, tightening to the point where pleasure bordered on pain.

“There’s this one really cute guy, Mike, who’s asked me for drinks a couple times. Maybe I should tell him yes next time.”

“Uh, fuck!” I erupted all over my stomach and Erin’s lower back. She laughed, pulling her hand away to lick my come from the webbing between her fingers.

“Are you serious about...the others?”

Erin looked down at me between her legs. She was enjoying this torture. She raised her eyebrows with a smile. “There are others, yes. But no, I’m not going to fool around with any of them. Not yet, anyway. I’m having too much fun with AJ right now. Now, did I tell you to stop?”

I realized that she still hadn’t come, and she was still straddling my face. To emphasize the point, she pressed her sex against my lips. I went back to work, clamping my mouth around her smooth pussy and sucking hard. Her eyes fluttered shut.

I held her by her firm ass cheeks as she rocked along my mouth and tongue. She dabbled her fingers across her clit, and up above, I knew she was twisting her nipples with her free hand.

She moaned above me, muffled by her thighs.

I couldn’t keep up. I felt myself slipping behind, my air running out, as I worked every trick I had on her. At last, I knew I had to go nuclear before I passed out. I ran my thumb down the crack of her ass. All it took was a little pressure and the gasping and thrashing above turned to screams.

She thumped down next to me, breathing hard and slick with sweat. “Ah, that was fun.”

I stared at her. She looked like my wife—same long dark hair, same stunning green eyes, same high wattage smile—but nothing about tonight seemed real.

“Where did you come from?” I said.

"I'm the same girl you've always known. You just forgot about this side of me."

"Shame on me."

"Oh, definitely." She turned to me so we faced each other on our sides. "I love you, Thomas. No matter what happens, remember that."

I would. I promised myself that.

She asked, "So did you learn anything else with AJ? Anything I can use?"

"Actually, yes, now that you mention it. He said that he's not going to sleep with you until race day. Says he wants to make you beg for it."

"Is that so?" Her eyes lit up. "Well, we'll see about who's going to be begging who..."

*

Three weeks until the race. This was the final stretch, the last 10% that was always the hardest. I wasn't training for the triathlon, of course. My home stretch was a mental one, but I felt the strain as surely as Erin's body did.

I bided my time like that's what this was, too: the last leg of the race before it was over, whatever *it* was. Like once the training was done and the competition run, things would go back to the way they always were—like Erin and I wouldn't be changed once she'd taken a lover.

And yet I knew it wouldn't. This was only the beginning. Erin's words kept coming back to me, over and over: *You think all their stares have had no effect? You think that AJ's the only guy who's hit on me?*

I needed to focus. One stretch at a time. August 22 was the day. August 22 was the end of my next stretch. I needed to make it that far before I could deal with anything else.

Erin made it fucking hard on me just to make it there. The day after she'd sent me out to talk to AJ, she went for a

long ride with her group. Time stretched on, but I thought nothing of it until I got the text.

-AJ invited me over for lunch. At his place.

My first thought was that this was another game. But we'd talked about that. We were past that. Still, I replied with a question.

-really?

Her response was quick.

-Yes. Really. See you a little later.

I couldn't shake the image of Erin walking into AJ's apartment. Of AJ throwing his keys on some table he had beside his door before sweeping her into his arms. Of AJ fucking her right there against the wall. She'd text me if she went there, right?

Erin dragged herself in, exhausted.

"Long ride? You were gone a while."

Erin smiled knowingly. "Really long. In the last few weeks, we're supposed to ride longer than we're going to do on race day, and it's killing me." She was dressed in a pair of yoga pants and loose blouse. "AJ's place was nice. Little masculine for my tastes, but typical for a guy like him."

My stomach fluttered. "So you really did go back there?"

"No more lies," she said. "Right?"

"Did anything...did anything happen?"

Erin glided up to me. I could smell her freshly washed hair—it smelled differently than the fruity scent she'd used since I'd first met her. AJ's shampoo. Why did she smell like AJ's shampoo?!

"Are you asking me if I fucked him?"

I couldn't even answer that.

"No, I didn't. But I did take a shower over there, before lunch." She kissed me on the cheek, whispering, "And he may have seen me naked just after."

Erin was teasing AJ as much as she was me. "You're evil."

"He likes me shaved, by the way."

And with that, she was on her way, searching for the kids as she shifted back into mom mode.

*

Erin came home Monday morning with a smile on her face. She'd gone out for her early morning swim at the gym, and hadn't come back until just minutes before I needed to leave for work. I'd already dropped the kids off at preschool.

"What?" I asked as she breezed in.

"He kept his word."

"The speedo?"

"Mmm hmm." Her hair was wet from the pool. She smelled like chlorine when she kissed me. "I don't usually go for that look, but he's got the body for it."

"Uh huh. Did anything...did anything else happen?"

She grasped the front of my trousers, feeling my erection bloom. "We kissed." She smiled as she felt my reaction. "And we made plans to meet up for lunch tomorrow."

She released me and stepped back, smiling. "Have fun at work."

I didn't have fun at work. In fact, work was quickly becoming a low point in my day. The new job had me working longer and harder than ever...and I still wasn't seeing results. The Orlando and Atlanta offices were showing signs of life, but New Orleans was threatening to show a loss for the first time in years. I considered that Benoit might be sabotaging things, but when I crunched the numbers and made a few phone calls, everything seemed in order. They were just having a bad quarter.

-lunch was fun. :)

Unfortunately, that's all the detail I got because I had to work late and when I got home, Erin was asleep. She got up early again on Wednesday morning and was out the door before I was up. Again, we only had a quick exchange as she came home and I went in to the office. We were ships, passing in the morning.

That said, I *did* learn what happened at lunch. Or at least, what happened was heavily implied when I met up with AJ Wednesday morning for our first official/un-official training session. He ran me through a circuit of machines that he said almost any hotel gym would have. It was a road warrior's workout, and damn did he work me hard.

Towards the end, I finally managed to shift the conversation to Erin without it feeling forced. We ended up on the stationary bikes—AJ's form of *cooling down*.

"So you do the speedo thing?" I asked, trying to sound roundabout.

AJ grinned. "I did."

"And?"

He looked around, seeing that no one was in hearing distance. Still, he leaned forward and lowered his voice. "I'd say she approved."

"Yeah? Did she uphold her end of the bargain?"

"Fuck yeah she did. And I can report to you that the results are amazing."

"So that's it? You did it?" Christ, I wanted to vomit. And yet, it was all I could do to keep my erection down.

AJ shook his head. "I told you, I'm saving that for race day. But dude, it's going to be hard to resist. She's so fucking tempting."

I didn't need to ask him to go on or clarify. He did that all by himself without prompting.

"Yesterday, we met up for lunch—totally above board, out at a restaurant and everything. We ended up making out against my Camaro. Dude, that chick is such a cocktease. It's worse than when I was in high school. Didn't

even get a handy.” He checked. “But fuck, is she going to be worth it. All this talk is getting me hard,” he laughed. He wasn’t alone. He shut the bike off and stretched. “My shift’s about to start. Need to grab a shower.”

“When are you seeing her again?”

“Saturday morning, we’ve got a swim. I think I’m going to avoid her outside of training, though, or I’m going to end up going back on my word.”

“Maybe you should just do it,” I said.

“Nah, man. That’s what she wants. We’ve got a little power struggle going on here, and I intend to win.”

“Well, good luck with that. Talk to you later.”

I sat on that machine for close to fifteen minutes, pretending to check my phone as my erection subsided.

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FIFTEEN

From the outside looking in AJ remained true to his word. Erin stuck to her routine. When she met up with him for her Saturday swim, she didn't connect with AJ after her swim—she didn't even lounge out on the dock with the group. She came straight home, took a shower, and then spent the day with our kids.

We played the dutiful parents, going to the zoo, to the parks, entertaining them until they were in bed. Erin crashed with them.

Most of the last two weeks went like that. This was the last push. The final two weeks before the big day. Erin was exhausted. The last few months had drained her, body and mind.

"After I run this thing, I'm going to sleep for a month," she said.

I was so proud of her—a feeling that went beyond all the stuff with AJ. It was amazing to see her so focused on something.

Those last couple weeks felt like the calm before the storm.

Erin's training program called for the last week to be one of rest. I was in the driveway, taking the trash out, when she rode up on her bicycle. She'd completed the last long ride before race day. Even hot, sweaty, and exhausted, she looked incredible. Wearing a painted-on cycling outfit helped, and I'd discovered a love for racer back sports bras under sporty tank tops.

She pulled off her bike helmet, shook out her sweat-clumped dark hair, and tied it up off her neck.

"Good ride?"

She walked up to me, took a long, deep breath, and nodded. "I'm beat, but yes. Awesome ride."

“Ready for next week?”

She stepped into me and kissed me softly on the lips. “I’m so ready for next week.”

With her Ray-Ban’s on, I couldn’t read her expression beyond her smile.

“Oh, you meant the race?” She giggled. “Yeah, I’m ready for that.”

“Something happen?” My pants tightened.

“Just the usual.” She leaned close to whisper in my ear. “How does it feel knowing you’re the second man I’ve kissed today?”

I kissed her again, harder this time. When I pulled back, she winked. “So that’s how you feel?”

“You’re a tease.”

“I am.” She touched my face. “Put this away for me? I’m going to go grab a shower. Thanks.”

I stood in the driveway alone, holding her cycle and a raging erection that wouldn’t go away.

*

The final week before the race was one of the hardest to get through. Erin was going to fuck another man. It was impossible to wrap my head around it, no matter how much I thought about it—which was pretty much all the time. I recalled all the conversations I’d had with Erin, and even some with AJ. Erin and I were strong enough for this. I loved her more than ever, and it still amazed me that after ten years together, I was still learning new things about her.

This was sex. Just sex. This was her exploring a side of herself that she’d never known she had, and I had front row seats. Watching the sexual creature emerge from my best friend and mother of my kids was awesome. It made me dizzy just thinking about how much a guy like AJ wanted my wife.

I met up with AJ Wednesday morning for my second official personal training day. We agreed to meet up in Rock Creek Park, rather than City Fitness, because he wanted to focus on running this trip.

“Isn’t this your week off?” I said as he set a brisk pace along the path.

AJ shrugged. “This is nothing—no offense. And the race on Saturday’s just a half ironman. Pretty standard.”

I thought about how hard Erin had busted her ass to get in shape for Saturday. Was this just macho guy talk? Or was he really so fit that he could shrug a triathlon off?

“I was thinking about your situation,” he went on.

“Yeah?” I got a little nervous, momentarily forgetting that he had no clue what my *situation* really was.

“Yeah. When you travel, you may not always have access to a gym. Not a good one, anyway. But you can always slap on some running shoes and hit the streets. So I’m going to show you the right way to run, to get the most out of it.”

I had to give it to the guy, he was good at what he did. He pushed. He was instructional. He was aspirational, even. After the morning with him, I wanted to get into shape—not just learn more about my wife. Of course, there was plenty of that, too.

“So, how’s it going with your project?”

AJ grinned, glancing over at me as we ran. “Only a couple more days now. Thank God we’re not training in this last week or I may just explode.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah, man. She’s a fucking temptress. And she knows exactly what she’s doing.”

“Like how?”

“Like how she dresses. Like the way she stretches after our workouts. It’s all designed to show herself off.”

I didn’t want to push it too much, so I changed the subject slightly. “So where’s the race?”

“Out in Annapolis. Not too far away, but I’m trying to get her to stay with me out there for the night. It’s not a good idea to drive back, after all.”

Erin had mentioned the Annapolis location, but not the overnight. Was she planning on ambushing me at the last moment? Or was she just going to call on the night of and tell me to watch the kids?

“So what then? That it?”

“Hell, no. Erin’s too special for a one-nighter. That chick’s got a wild side I can’t wait to tap.”

“Oh, yeah?”

“Yeah. I’ve seen that before. Her life is proper and orderly. She’s one kind of person there: mother, wife. But she’s got a darker side, and it’s not a side she can show her husband.”

“She told you that?” I asked. “Why can’t she tell him? She say he was some kind of—”

“Conservative control freak?” he said.

Is that what she thought of me?!

AJ continued before I could completely go there. “You said it, not me.”

“Did she?”

He laughed. “No, she didn’t. Honestly, I try not to bring him up much. Doesn’t help with the seduction. But here’s the thing. What they have is comfortable, right? She loves him, and loves her life with him. It’s a respect thing, I guess. Like, if she revealed this dirtier side of herself, he’d lose some respect for her.”

I felt like I’d just stepped into Crazy Land. I didn’t need to fake my confusion. “But that doesn’t make any sense. If he loves her, then he should accept her.”

“See, you’re talking like a husband. She doesn’t want his acceptance. Me? I don’t just *accept* that. It makes me hot thinking about a chick like that: buttoned up most of the time with all these wild thoughts. With me, she doesn’t have to deal with the complications of justification or acceptance.

She knows that I don't care. I'm safe, but in a totally different way. I'm safe for that inner slut."

It was a lot to chew on. When I left, I was still shell shocked from the revelation, but other things had crept inside the numbing fold. Doubt, mostly, but also a newfound perspective on Erin. This was a lot more complicated than I'd initially thought way back when I realized that I had a kink for her playing with other men. Had I opened a door that wasn't easy to close?

On the way home, I thought about what AJ had said. It made a strange kind of sense—if I didn't consider Erin my wife. Here was an attractive suburbanite ready for a walk on her wilder side. But she *was* my wife. And she was going to fuck another man. And she really, really wanted it. That little detail made this whole situation much more complicated.

I'll admit it: I was feeling insecure. This was no longer my fantasy. Erin and AJ had wrenched it out of my grasp and twisted it into their own.

*

That evening, after the kids were in bed, Erin walked into the bedroom, holding her phone in her hands, filled with nervous excitement. She handed it to me and I took it without thinking. "What is it?" I asked, turning it over, glancing down at the screen. Her texts were up. Texts from AJ.

"Just...read it."

-booking the rooms for annapolis saturday. last chance. you want in?

I looked up at her.

"This is it," she said. "Last chance to back out."

"Do you want to back out?" I asked.

She said, "Only if you do." She wanted this. She was nervous that I'd say no, I realized.

“Think about it. I’m going to take a shower.”

I stood there, rooted to the floor, as she disappeared into the bathroom. I heard the water cut on, and still I stood, staring down at the phone like a live grenade. *Last chance*, it read. Last chance to stop this. Last chance before everything changes. Last chance...

Steam had already filled the bathroom by the time I walked in. The screen fogged over immediately, but I could still read my reply.

“Okay,” I said.

Erin’s head popped out around the opaque curtain. “You sure?”

I nodded, not trusting myself to speak. Instead, I held the phone up to her, showing her the reply.

“I’m sure.” And there, before her eyes, I brushed my finger across the screen, and felt that sick, sinking feeling of finality, and hit *send*. It had been done, and I’d done it.

Erin and I looked at one another, both frightened at what came next, both excited. Her eyes were so green. So wide and vivid. I began to take my shirt off when the phone rumbled into my hand.

“He replied,” I said, checking the phone.

–awesome! booking now

And then, quickly after:

–so will you be in annapolis alone? or with the fam?

I read the texts to Erin.

“Should I reply?” I asked.

“Yes. Tell him, *No family. All you get is me.*”

I almost couldn’t type those flirty lines back to AJ. My fingers shook too much. My head filled with cotton and something too warm to be comfortable. But I did it, and my erection hardened as I did.

“Okay,” I said.

Erin's head disappeared as the water splashed around her. "This is kind of fun."

"It's a little bizarre." I studied the steamed-up screen as it told me that AJ was typing.

"But you're getting off on it, aren't you?" When I didn't answer, her head emerged behind the curtain again, her dark hair slicked back along her scalp. "Aren't you?"

"Yes."

"Show me."

I licked my lips. The phone rumbled in my hand. I looked down at it, wondering if I should read it first, or do as I was told.

I set the phone on the sink, unzipped my jeans, and dragged them off.

"Very naughty, Tom. Very naughty." Her head disappeared behind the curtain again. "What's he say?"

Remembering the message, I glanced back at the phone. My chest tightened. "He says, *Good. Can't wait.*"

"Mmm, I can't wait, either."

The sound of the shower shifted. Looking over the top of the curtain, I realized that Erin had detached the head. I didn't know what to do. What to say. I just sat there, steam enveloping my naked body as Erin got off thinking about her personal trainer.

Another text came in. My heart quickened. "He says..." I cleared my throat. "He says, *Make sure you're nice and smooth for Saturday night.*"

Erin laughed. "The man has an obsession. That's for sure."

"Want me to respond?"

She rolled the shower curtain back, giving me a full frontal view of her naked body. She braced herself against the wall with one hand, the other holding the showerhead against her hip. Her nipples screamed high and hard on her flushed breasts and her pussy was already blossoming.

“No. I want you to get in here and help me out.” She held out the shower nozzle. I didn’t need to be asked twice.

As I knelt before her on the shower tiles and she draped one leg over my shoulder, I realized how comfortable I’d become with this position. I’d learned how to transfer some of the pressure from my knees to my toes, and how to shift to relieve the rest of the discomfort. I’d learned how Erin liked to feel the hard pulse of the showerhead—where to tease, when to attack. And I knew precisely what to do with my mouth and fingers. I could get her off in thirty seconds, but I got the sense that she wanted to draw this session out.

I pushed two fingers into her pussy and she twisted above me, sniffing loudly for air.

“Yes, just like that.”

She threaded her fingers in my hair and pressed me against her sex. She was right, she was *so smooth*. I attacked her pussy. I wanted to touch it, but knew implicitly that Erin wouldn’t approve of that.

“I’m going to have to teach AJ how to use the shower nozzle. Hope the hotel has the removable kind.”

Even with the deluge of water flowing across her sex, I could feel how wet she was. She was on the edge, and I was done holding back. I added a third finger to her depths.

Erin came, filling my world with water and pussy and the desperate feeling of drowning. I pushed my tongue as deep as it could go between her swollen depths. She lost herself.

I extracted myself at last, sitting back on my haunches as Erin reclined against the wall opposite. I watched her take deep breaths, her eyes closed, lost in another world. At last, she looked at me.

“Thanks for that. You’re really good at that.”

“I’ve been getting a lot of practice.”

Erin smiled weakly. “You really sure you’re good with Saturday?”

“Yes.” I no longer felt the same hesitation that I had when answering AJ’s text. I was sure. I was scared shitless,

but I was sure. “You know I’ll love you no matter what, right Erin?”

“I do.” She shut off the water and stood, offering me a hand. My legs felt rubbery.

“Come on, let’s get to bed. You’re supposed to be resting.”

*

On Thursday, I got a text from Erin on my way home from work. I shouldn’t have checked it, but I was at a light and did it reflexively.

-before you come home, i need you to pick up some condoms

The car behind me blared its horn when I didn’t immediately move as the light turned green. I had to pull off to the side of the road, just to calm my nerves. A second text came on the heels of the first.

-make sure they’re XLs

My stomach did all kinds of crazy things, but I did as the texts ordered. I kept it together, stopped by the CVS, and bought a box of magnums along with a bottle of ginger ale. Thank God for automated checkout these days.

*

The sleeplessness and the anxiety of the upcoming weekend left me ragged at work. I couldn’t focus, even as the numbers kept coming in, lower and lower. I couldn’t focus enough to figure out a solution, so things kept spiraling downward.

I know that I’d woken up Friday morning, gotten into the shower, and gone to work, but I honestly couldn’t remember any of it. One moment, I was replaying the purchase of the

condoms in my head; the next it was Friday evening and Erin and I were putting the kids down for bed.

We walked into the bedroom together, hand-in-hand. It was the very picture of domestic bliss. At the base of the bed was a packed overnight bag. My eyes darted away from it as my gut trembled.

“You ready?” I asked.

Erin took a deep breath. “Nervous, but very ready.”

She felt so slight as I wrapped her in my arms, her body honed to near perfection.

“Me too,” I said.

She pulled me to the bed. “Come on, let’s work out that nervous energy together.”

That night, Erin and I made slow, languid love to one another. We didn’t speak of AJ. She didn’t tease me with talk of giant cocks and consensual infidelity. We didn’t talk about what tomorrow would bring. We were just Tom and Erin Smith, married for eight years, parents to two beautiful children, living a white-picket perfect life.

As the sweat cooled on our bodies and we snuggled beneath the sheets, Erin whispered, “The next time I have sex with you will be after I’m with AJ.”

And like that, we were back here, right before the plunge.

“I can’t wait for that.”

“I can’t either. Goodnight, sweetheart.”

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SIXTEEN

August 22. Race day. A date and day that I will never forget for the rest of my life.

I woke up earlier than Erin, so alert that I wondered if I'd slept at all. Glancing at her, her head pressed into the pillow, her dark hair shimmering around her, I wondered how *she* could sleep at all. It annoyed me almost as much as I envied it.

Today was like Christmas if Santa Claus was from the Jersey Shore and carried a bag filled with powerful, yet contradictory emotions. I wanted to vomit, yet was erect with more than just morning wood.

I slipped out of bed and headed downstairs. The house was quiet. I prepared a pot of coffee, toasted a bagel, and slathered peanut butter over it. This was the meal Erin ate before every long run, ride, or swim—in addition to an energy bar she kept in her bag.

I was filling her water bottle by the time she came down, already dressed, her bag at her side. She wasn't wearing her racing clothes like I'd half-expected, but a tight pair of cropped jeans and a loose, orange blouse. This would have been the first sight AJ would see of his future lover.

"I made you breakfast," I said.

Erin stared at me without saying a word, long enough that I shifted from foot to foot and cleared my throat.

At last, she detached herself from the door frame and walked up to me. "I love you, baby," she said, kissing me slow and sweet.

We didn't talk about stopping this. Erin didn't ask me if she should stay. Or not spend the night. Or not fuck AJ. We were past that.

We had momentum. We couldn't stop even if we wanted to. If we did, there would always be the *what-ifs* and *what-*

could-have-beens. We would never be able to shake the regret.

"You ready?" I asked.

When Erin nodded, I wasn't sure what she was saying yes to: the triathlon, or everything after.

"Text me with your finish time."

Erin's smile was luminous, drawing out her round cheekbones and transforming her eyes into dark-lashed crescent moons. She stepped close, tugging me against her by my t-shirt. "I'll text you with more than that."

"Yeah?"

"Think you can hold out?" Her brow creased as she composed her thoughts. I jumped when she pushed her hand down the front of my pajama pants. Then she looked up at me, her eyes wide beneath her thick lashes.

"Hold out?"

"No playing with yourself until I text you that you can."

She must have felt me twitch in her hand, but said nothing about it. Instead, she added, "And I'm not going to tell you that you can...until you're officially my cuckold."

This time, the twitch was more of a bounce. *Cuckold*? I didn't even think she knew that word existed. And was that what I was?

Her grip on my cock grew stronger. "Jo educatd me a little on how this works," she said with a giggle. "So do we understand?"

"Yes, ma'am."

Erin giggled. "Good."

I took a deep breath, clearing my head. "So I'll see you tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow, although it may be later than earlier."

"Just let me know when you're headed back."

"Will do." She pulled up the handle of her roller bag.

"And Erin? If something goes wrong..."

"I'll call immediately. But don't worry—"

"I'm not." *At least not about Aj.* I looked down at her, so beautiful in the morning light. Had her eyelashes always been so long? Had her dark hair always been so thick and wavy?

I pulled her into me, fists balling into her loose blouse as I kissed her. It felt good to push my tongue into her mouth and feel her open to me. She'd been slowly taking the dominant role in our relationship over the past few months; it was nice to feel her yield, if only for a kiss.

"Have fun, Erin. I'll see you tomorrow."

"I will."

And she was gone.

*

I'm not sure how I got through the day. The first half was easier than the second, but both still felt like I'd accidentally settled myself into a pressure cooker. I took the kids to the park in the morning until it got too hot. I took them to McDonald's because it was easy, and then we went back home and made a mess of toys in the playroom.

I tried not to look at the clock, or check my phone. It was like an itch that I couldn't stop scratching, and wouldn't go away no matter how many times I did. I didn't hear anything until nearly 3 in the afternoon.

-6:49. not the best, but i finished

I texted her back with a congratulations, but didn't get an immediate response. I tried to imagine where she was. She had to be with him, sweaty and stripped down to her running shorts and sports bra, chugging electrolytes. Was he eyeing her tanned curves? Was he touching her exposed skin?

The minutes stretched out into an hour. Then more. I put Mary down for a nap and watched a DVR'ed episode of *Adventure Time* with Martin without really watching it.

Nothing at four. Nothing at five. Nothing at six. The pressure kept rising.

Did he have her splayed out on the bed, driving his cock into her tight, married pussy? Was my wife experiencing the stretch of another man for the first time in over a decade? Did she love it?

At seven, I finally got a text in the form of a picture. It showed AJ and Erin at what must have been the hotel bar. They were standing close enough that their hips touched, holding drinks and smiling. Erin wore a string bikini that I'd never seen before—black with white piping that lifted her breasts up to form a deep line of cleavage. Whereas AJ wore his sunglasses and looked every bit the Player, Erin's were pushed up into her dark hair so that she could fix her green eyes on the camera. *This is happening*, she seemed to say with that stare.

-spent the day at the pool, relaxing. i'm so sore!

I went back to the photo, obsessing over every detail. The drink she held was nearly empty, something pink and summery. Her nails were painted the same red as her toes, which she'd probably done at the same time but I'd failed to notice. I wondered who took the picture. Someone from her training group, probably, Liz or Hope, but what if they'd all gone home? What if it was just a stranger that Erin had handed her phone to?

I typed a response at last, trying to keep it innocuous in case AJ was reading them, too. I wasn't supposed to know about their hook-up, and wanted to keep it that way. I had no interest in being a cuckold in that sense—I didn't want AJ to be the bull in this relationship. Just a lover.

-you should get a massage

She wrote back instantly this time.

-good idea!

I'd had a professional massage in mind, one provided by the hotel, but another thought occurred to me as I read the text sent. Did she just turn to AJ and ask for one? Did I just give him an opening? It was the *not* knowing that killed me the most. All the speculation was eating me alive.

The only thing that I was certain of was that I wasn't allowed to play with myself until Erin told me I could, and that she wouldn't tell me I could until she'd fucked AJ. As I went over that conversation again and again, I realized that all I had was a sequence. She never said that she'd text me as soon as she and AJ were done. They could have fucked already for all I knew and now she was just being cruel.

I thought about the word she'd used: *cuckold*. The word carried a lot of meaning, and until now, I'd considered all of it bad. A cuckold was a wimp. A cuckold was humiliated, forced to watch his wife with her lover. A cuckold was a man who'd lost all respect of the woman that meant the world to him, and was now content to live a second-class existence just to remain in her presence.

That's what I'd thought of the term, anyway. Only now, in the hours leading up to my own cuckoldry, I started to reconsider the starkness of the term. Like everything in life, it wasn't so black-and-white. I had no desire to be humiliated in public, and even less desire to have another man rub his alpha-male-ness in my face.

But I loved aspects of the term. I couldn't deny it—not when my cock stirred every time I thought of AJ taking my wife. I loved the power over me that it gave Erin, and the way she harnessed it. She'd sent me out to chat with AJ. She'd teased me with hints of her seduction. She'd made me buy her condoms to use for him. It was thrilling to think back on, and even more to wonder what came next. How far did her power extend? How much could I take before breaking?

I knew I had a few limits, mostly involving me and bodily contact with AJ. I wouldn't eat a cream pie, for example, and

if we ever had a threesome—something that I knew was next to impossible but intensely erotic to think about—I wouldn't touch him. But Erin knew all that, and while she pushed, I also trusted her to walk the delicate line between uneasiness and the forbidden.

As afternoon faded to evening, I found myself hard more often than I wasn't. I thought about taking care of myself, but knew immediately that I wouldn't. I *couldn't*. Even if she'd never know, Erin's challenge held power over me. She might not know, but *I* would, and it would have felt like cheating.

She called around eight to wish the kids goodnight. We only exchanged a few pleasantries because of their proximity. I could hear laughter in the background. They were somewhere pleasant.

"How was the race? Crowded?" I asked.

"Really crowded. And when everyone jumped in the water, it was insane." Erin laughed. "I got to meet Lamar Williamson."

"The track star? Did he wear his Gold Medals?"

"Ha. No. He started the race, and apparently he knows Aj."

"Why does that not surprise me?"

Before I could ask more about her day, though, she asked me to put the kids on. And then, with a good night to all of us, she hung up.

I put the kids down. I didn't know what to do, so I sat in front of the television and pretended to watch TV. A glass of bourbon helped dull my senses, but I couldn't kick the questions.

What was she doing? Was she busy getting fucked? Had the exhaustion of the race caught up to her and she'd fallen asleep? My phone buzzed as I searched for answers.

My body seized. My stomach squirmed. I felt light-headed. I picked up the phone. I read the message, checked the time—11:15 on Saturday night—and read it again.

-you now have permission to play with yourself

Boom. Those simple words seared through my gut, so powerful that I nearly doubled over. It was done. Erin had fucked another man. I was no longer her One and Only.

Another message followed the first. A selfie, snapped in the bathroom of the hotel they were staying at—Aj's hotel room? It was simple: the reflection of Erin's face and shoulders framed in the bathroom mirror. Her eyelids drooped, the corners of her lips curled up, and her skin was flushed.

I touched the screen, tracing her neck down to her bare shoulders. She was naked—or close to it. I knew that punch drunk expression well. It was her post-sex look, equal parts satisfied and exhausted.

And one final note from my loving wife.

-good night

I didn't respond. I'm not sure that I could have. My hands shook too much. My mind kept blaring an alarm like a ship in distress, a bleating klaxon that resolved itself into three words, repeated again and again: Oh my God, Oh my God...

I kept waiting for the initial shock to fade, holding off from full-on panic by reviewing the past three months and reminding myself that I was as much a part of this decision as Erin. I wanted her to get fucked. I wanted her to unleash her inner wildness.

But the full-on panic was there, one stray thought away from overwhelming me. Every time I started to feel normal, the image of Erin's satisfied expression sent a fresh wave of heat and confusion through me. And with each wave, my cock came alive.

That was the thing: throughout this strange journey, navigating through the tumultuous sea of mixed emotions, I'd never felt this turned on. The lust I felt for Erin bubbled up from somewhere deep and primal. It rose above all my

fears and jealousy. It was so strong I couldn't even think straight.

I called up Erin's last texts again. The photos. The permission to play with myself. The questions came flooding home. How many times have they fucked? Are they fucking right now? I knew he had a bigger cock...was he better than I could ever be?

I poured myself a drink as I thought about that last question. Each time I asked myself I felt a queasy jolt to my gut. I'd never considered myself an insecure guy. It wasn't how to build a successful career and a good life. But that question, without a doubt, was propped up on insecurity so fragile that a single breath could topple it—or a single text.

I kept checking my phone for that text, but nothing came. In a way, I was ready for everything to come crashing down. I welcomed it. We were so far outside of my comfort zone that I didn't know the proper way to react anymore.

I took the bottle of bourbon into the living room. Our mantle was covered with photos of our family. Baby pictures. Wedding pictures. Family portraits. Candid photos from years ago. It told a story of two people in love, then three, then four. We once had a dog together. I remembered how Erin had cried when we had to put him down, how her body quivered in my arms. That was the same woman who was now in the arms of another man, in another city.

The photos helped me regroup myself. She may be having sex with someone else, but he didn't have this history—and he wasn't interested in having it. She'd be home to me, forever changed, yet always the same.

I settled into bed and jerked off. I couldn't help myself. I focused on what it must have been like in the moments just before they crossed the line. Whose room were they in? How much had they kissed? Did she blow him? Did he go down on her? Or did they just start fucking?

I found sleep at some point after that. My temporary release, coupled with the alcohol, helped. My dreams were

filled with more questions, more insecurities—nightmares that could double as fantasies.

I woke sometime in the middle of the night and checked my phone long enough to see that there were no new texts. My stomach tightened, yet I was hard again. I wasn't sure if I fell back to sleep, or just thought about sleep, but eventually morning dawned, casting warm light on my ragged psyche.

And still, no texts.

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SEVENTEEN

Sunday morning, I made coffee for myself and waffles and bacon for the children. I played Dad. It was a role I was good at, and one that required almost all of my attention. I could ignore the terrifying thoughts just on the edge of consciousness.

Not that I could really ignore it. My heart kept skipping. Heat kept flashing across my scalp. I had no appetite. In the mirror, I hardly recognized the pallid reflection staring back at me.

I started having crazy thoughts. Like, maybe I should drive out to Annapolis and confront them. The jealous brute in me liked the idea of pounding my fist into AJ's square jaw—not that I could have taken the personal trainer in reality. I drew up Erin's number half a dozen times, intending on starting a conversation that I wasn't sure how to begin.

She called me first. It was just after ten when my phone buzzed and her profile photo appeared on my screen. It was one from last winter, when we'd all gone to a ski resort. I remember telling her she was my snow bunny—this picture proved it. She had the hood of her ski jacket pulled up, white with downy lining. A few strands of her dark hair had escaped it, curling around her chin.

I shook my head, snapping out of the memory just in time to answer the phone.

"Hello?" I said. My heart clenched as I waited to hear her speak.

"Morning, Tom."

"Morning."

"Did you sleep well?" I could hear her smile in the loaded question.

"Kind of. Not really. You?"

“Actually, yeah. Like a rock,” she said. “I don’t think that I realized how exhausted I was after the race until I crawled into bed.”

I left the living room, where the kids were watching TV. My pants had already tightened as I started compiling the long list of my questions.

“Are you alone now?” I asked.

“Yeah. I just got back from that massage you recommended. AJ’s getting his now.”

So they were together. I knew that they were, but it still registered like a blow—a really sexy blow, but a staggering one nonetheless. “And you two...?”

“Yes.” She didn’t demure. She wasn’t ashamed. “Twice now. Once last night, and once this morning.”

I sat down on my bed, surprised to find myself in our bedroom. “Was it good?”

This time, Erin didn’t answer immediately. “Are you sure you want to hear this? Over the phone, I mean?”

“Please...” If that sounded like begging, I didn’t care.

“Okay then. Yes, it was good.” She paused, then reiterated: “Really good.”

I let her answer sink in, like someone preparing himself for emotional self-immolation.

“You’re hard, aren’t you?” she said.

“Yes.”

“AJ asked me about dinner.”

“Just the two of you?” I asked. The thought of them out on a date like that felt wrong, even after all the lines they’d crossed.

“Yeah. Everyone else went home already.”

“What...did you tell him?”

“What do you think?”

I honestly didn’t know. “Yes?”

She laughed softly. “Yeah? Interesting.”

“Did you?”

"I said I was thinking about it. You just helped me answer it."

My heart fell, but I stubbornly didn't say anything about it. My mouth was too dry. My thoughts on other, crazier, things. "How did it happen? The first time?"

"In his room. He was behind me. I was on all fours. It was raw and hard—like two fucking animals—and just what I needed."

That's not exactly the answer I was looking for, but it nearly did me in. My breath caught, the gasp traveling down the line. "You're incredible."

"You like hearing about me with other men?"

Other men. It registered without registering. "Yeah."

"Tell me more," she said. There was a breathiness in her command that made me wonder if she wasn't touching herself.

"I love hearing how naughty you are. I couldn't stop thinking about what you and AJ were doing last night, and it's driving me insane now."

"I wanted to fuck him all night long, but my body just gave out on me. I passed out after all the orgasms he gave me. It was probably one of the best ways I'd ever fallen asleep."

"God, that's so hot, Erin."

"Yeah, so hot. I can't wait for him to get back so we can do it again. The man has stamina, that's for sure."

"Didn't you say he's done a full ironman?" I asked.

"Yeah. My ironman. He sure has the body for it. He's, like, all muscle."

"He manhandled you?" I prompted.

She sighed. "Yeah, I was definitely *manhandled* last night. I don't think I could have lasted as long as I did if I wasn't."

I groaned.

She said, "I'll stop teasing you and let you go. I need to get ready before he comes back."

“Ready?”

Erin laughed. “I’ll send you a pic. Bye, Tom. I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

“And Tom?”

“Yes?”

“Thank you.”

The photo came through ten minutes later. It was Erin in the bathroom mirror, but the angle was wider this time. She wore a translucent black negligee that hoisted her full tits up and hid little else. Beneath, I could see her black g-string, which was also see-through enough that I had a clear view of her cleanly shaven sex. She’d braided her hair and tied it in back, giving her a brunette-Heidi look that should have been at odds with her sexy attire, but wasn’t.

I could see the front of the phone in the mirror, held out in the foreground with her left hand. And curled around the phone flashed her wedding band.

*

I occupied my time as best I could. I took the kids to the pool, although several of the hotter moms in bikinis stirred my imagination. Last summer, all I would have seen were fit bodies and lives much like Erin’s as they dealt with screaming kids and ambling toddlers. Now, I wondered what their secrets were. Did their husbands encourage them to sleep with their personal trainers, too?

We ran into Haley and Andy, which meant staying longer than I’d planned. That was fine, because I really had nothing to do after. Besides, if anything could take my mind off Erin, it was Haley in a bathing suit could.

We were sitting at the edge of the baby pool, watching Mary. It took a lot of willpower not to glance down at Haley’s body. Her bikini was modest, but it was still a bikini, and Haley was still a stunning blonde.

“Hey, where’s Erin?” she asked.

“She’s still recovering from her race,” I lied.

“That’s right. How did that go?”

Was Haley studying me so closely for a reason? Did she suspect something? Did she know? Or maybe I was just being paranoid.

“Um, it went well. You know how she is, always pushing herself to do better.”

Did I imagine the moment of Haley’s hesitation? “Sounds like Erin. Well, I’m proud of her.”

“So am I. When she sets her mind to do something, she does it,” I said. I wasn’t thinking about the triathlon.

“Yeah. It’s pretty inspiring.” Now she definitely paused, her eyes locking with mine before she looked off, toward the water slide. “I better check on the boys.”

“Good idea.” I watched her walk away. She adjusted her bikini bottom where it had begun to conform to her shapely ass. Damn, was I horny.

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EIGHTEEN

By late afternoon, I'd resigned myself to the fact that Erin had accepted AJ's invitation for dinner, and that I wouldn't see her until late. The blow to my ego registered with that same mix of jealousy and arousal that everything else seemed to come with. AJ had been chosen over me.

So it completely surprised me when I heard the front door open around 4:30 and Mary and Martin squeal, "Mommy, mommy!"

"Hey, kiddos," I heard her say in the hall. A moment later, she walked into the den with Mary on her hip and Martin tugging at the ragged edge of her white cut-offs.

"Mommy, we went to the pool and daddy showed me how to dive!" Martin said excitedly.

"Did he now?" she asked, looking at me with disapproval. Then she laughed. "Did you guys have fun this weekend?"

Her question plucked a discordant note at my heart.

Martin answered for us. "We missed you, Mommy."

"I missed you guys, too."

She made her way over to me and gave me a soft kiss.

"Mommy," Mary announced from Erin's arms, "your hair is pretty."

Erin laughed. "Thank you, honey. So's yours."

"When I'm older, can I have pretty hair like yours?"

"Of course."

I didn't know what to say, or how to react as this incredibly domestic scene played out. How could this woman, surrounded by so much normalcy, be the same woman who'd just texted me a photo of herself in a black negligee intended for another man?

So failing to come up with anything poignant, I just said, "Welcome home, honey."

I saw her relax into her smile. She kissed me again. "It's good to be home."

I added, "And we only did cannonballs off the low board."

Erin laughed, but there were tears in her eyes.

*

The next few hours felt hyper normal. I prepared a sausage pasta dinner as Erin did crafts with the kids in our playroom. The meal was like any other, filled with everything and nothing all at once. Erin was exhausted, but that was to be expected after running a triathlon the day before. She orchestrated a bath both kids so desperately needed, filling the bathroom with laughter as I cleaned up the dishes. We put Mary down together, reading her *Where the Wild Things Are* (her latest favorite) and *The Cat and the Hat* (her oldest favorite). After that, I laid in bed and read Martin half a chapter from *A Phantom Tollbooth* as Erin went through the house, straightening up the mess I'd created over the last couple days.

When I finally shut the door to Martin's dark room and entered my own, I half-expected Erin to be posing on the bed in lingerie. Instead, I found her on the back porch, nursing a glass of white wine and looking into our wooded back yard. I grabbed a cold IPA and joined her.

Summers in DC were horrid, even in late August, but evenings were magical. The humidity had begun to burn away, but it was still warm enough to lounge outside in shorts and a t-shirt. Crickets sang. The air still held the sweet smell of cut grass. The world stood still and peaceful.

Erin was sitting on our porch swing, a two-person bench we had installed when we first bought the place.

I slid into the spot beside her, drawing her out of her quiet contemplation. Her hair was still in the tied up braids from this morning's picture, although her outfit was far more

decent: a black cardigan sweater over her t-shirt and white shorts. It was her Mom-outfit disguise.

I had all kinds of questions: about last night, about what she was thinking of now, about how she felt about our fantasy. Every one of them scared the hell out of me, yet demanded to be asked.

Instead, I pulled her close and kissed her. She was too beautiful to resist—the moment too perfect. When she turned into me and deepened the kiss, those questions and their frightening answers faded.

I craved this woman. The more I kissed her, the more I clutched at her ass and felt the bite of her fist in my hair, the more I needed her. We tugged at our clothes, stripping in the syrupy night air. Her cardigan went, then her t-shirt, right along with mine. She stood over me as she worked the button of her shorts and I pushed them down her hips, along with her panties.

Her pussy glistened, even in the low light, and I could see her bare cunt, red and used and open. I ripped my pants down, freeing my steely erection. She grabbed it, positioned it against her pussy, and sank into my lap. Her moan seethed out through gritted teeth, pain registering across her face.

“You’re sore.”

She wrapped her arms around me—for intimacy, I thought at first, only to realize she was seeking leverage. She cranked her body over me, rising and falling on my cock.

“Fuck me,” she hissed.

“You sure?” I didn’t want to hurt her.

“Fuck me!”

Not needing to be told again, I grabbed her ass and guided her rapid gyrations. She felt different, there was no denying it. Looser. Wetter. Hotter. I clung to her, keeping her close. I wanted to smother myself in her body.

Our mouths sought one another, kissing, tongues lashing until it was too much. Arching her back, she pulled me into her chest, smothering me in her cleavage as she clenched handfuls of my hair. It hurt like hell, but only spurred me on. I palmed her ass, digging my fingertips into the taut cheeks, and bounced her fast.

"Yes, Tom. Fuck me. Fuck me, baby."

I groaned. "Oh, Erin."

"Tom!"

I exploded inside her just as I felt the walls of her pussy come alive. She clenched her teeth to stifle her climax. It wasn't enough. I grabbed her head and drew her into a kiss, silencing her. Her body shook with each pulse of come inside her. She pulled back at last, her breath shallow, her eyes luminous.

She sighed. "That's exactly what I needed."

"Didn't you spend all day with a sex god?"

Erin laughed. "Yeah, maybe? But he's not you."

My heart sang. I took a deep breath and moved on. "So no dinner?"

"It was tempting, but I needed to be here. With you." She smiled. My heart sang. Then she added, "So I took a rain check," and my heart seized again.

She giggled. "Want to hear about this weekend?"

"Do you really have to ask?"

"What do you want to know?" She slipped out of my lap, sinking down to her knees. I stared at her, wondering if she was about to do what I thought she'd do.

My head filled with questions—questions tangling with questions so thick I couldn't focus on any of them. I snatched one at random: "Did you have a good time?"

Erin circled my soft cock with her fingers, wet with our combined juices. She'd never gone down on me after sex. Had she done that for AJ?

"Oh, yes. I had a *great* time."

"And you and AJ..."

“Had sex. A lot of sex. We didn’t leave his room much today, after you and I talked.” She pumped my cock as I grew in her hand. “He made me suck his cock so many times my jaw hurts.”

With that, she dipped her head in and took me into her mouth, all the way to the base, then sucked down as she drew back up my length. By the time she popped off the tip, I was hard again.

“I want to hear about all of it. From the beginning, I mean.”

I could tell how exhausted she was as she rose to her feet. “Inside. In bed.” She released a breathy laugh. “I need to be laying down.”

*

We dragged ourselves up to our room without bothering with our clothes. We’d just strip out of them upstairs anyway. Erin flopped into bed, closed her eyes, and sighed. “That feels good.”

I fell into bed next to her, propped up on my elbow. “You’re not going to fall asleep on me, are you?”

She looked at me, batting her lashes. “You’ve been so patient. I owe you a good story.” She touched my chest hair and began. “I was so nervous driving to Annapolis. I swear, I think I was actually shaking by the time I arrived. Part of it was pre-race jitters, but mostly it was because of what I knew I’d be doing after. *Post-race* jitters, I guess.

“The race was *hard*. I mean, I’d done all the legs separately, but putting it all together was nuts. It’s more mental than anything, though, and now that I know I can do it...well, like they say, the first race is all about finishing. Next time, I’m going to kill it.”

That was Erin, always the competitive one. “Aj actually hung with me most of the time, although after the swimming leg, the two of us outdistanced the rest of our

group. I knew he was pushing me—that's just kind of what he does, but I didn't mind it. I'm not sure I could have finished it without him.

"But I did, and it was amazing. I felt so much accomplishment. It's hard to describe. It's just..."

"Amazing," I finished for her.

Erin sighed. "Yeah."

"And then?"

"We all went out after that. Well, actually, first I went back to my room and crashed. *Then* we went out and celebrated. We went to the pool, then had this amazing dinner—"

"Everyone in your running group?"

"Most of them, yeah. Hayden and Ellen had to leave earlier. Everyone else stayed through the meal."

"So they weren't staying in Annapolis?"

"Nope." Erin laughed. "That was a ploy. I called AJ on it later, but by that time...well, the ploy had already worked."

If I hadn't been hard already...

Erin continued her story. One by one, everyone else had left, leaving AJ and Erin alone at the restaurant. I'd have expected him to move fast at that point, but they ended up staying at the restaurant for nearly an hour, chatting about the last few months. It had the delicacy of a first date; they were attracted to one another and knew where this would go, but couldn't work up the nerve to go there. They started with talk about the training and ended up talking about everything from dental hygiene (Erin can talk for hours about this) to the sexiness of each of their training partners.

"He said he'd love to get me and Liz together," she said. "I told him he was getting greedy."

I kissed her. "He sounds like the kind of guy who usually gets what he wants."

Erin kissed me back, sliding her tongue into my mouth. "Kind of like me. We have that in common."

It was funny. I wouldn't have agreed with her a few months ago. Now she was absolutely right. She stared up at me, eyes wide. "Right now, I need you back inside me."

I climbed over her, positioning my cock against her sex.

"Gentle...gentle..." Erin hissed as I slid into her slick embrace once more.

Erin moaned, arching back and rolling her hips to meet mine. She pulled me against her shoulder, her hand gentle yet insistent on the back of my neck. She wanted the intimacy of skin on skin and I gave her as much as I could.

Around her moans, she said, "You feel so good."

My heart sang. I wanted to take my time with her, but my imagination worked against me. I clung to the few details I knew: he fucked her doggystyle that night, and fucked her again some time in the morning...

I looked down at her. Her eyes were closed, her head tipped back just enough to bare her throat. Was she thinking about him now?

She bit her lower lip, stifling her cry, and squeezed her eyes shut. She *was* thinking about him. She had to be.

I nuzzled her neck and considered playing my part as AJ, of whispering something he might say into her ear. But AJ wasn't a fantasy any more—he was a memory—so I left it alone.

She crested through an orgasm that lifted her chest against mine. I slipped my hand around her, pulling her close. Her entire body tightened like a muscle being flexed, then relaxed all at once. She became a puddle beneath me.

"That was nice," Erin said, her breath hard and shallow. I could feel her heart racing against my skin. She kissed my jaw. "Really, really nice."

I started to roll off her, worried that I'd make her even more sore. She grabbed my ass and held me against her.

"No. Stay."

I stayed.

“How many times did you...do it?” I still couldn’t form the words that would acknowledge that they’d had sex.

“How many times in total? Including last night, four, but...he’s got so much stamina. Like, our last time together probably lasted two hours. I don’t even know how many times I came before he finally did.”

Two hours?! Of course I’d set Erin up with a sex machine. “How was he?”

“Different. More aggressive, for sure. *Much* more physical.”

“And you liked that?” I pumped her harder subconsciously.

“Ooh, too much.” She patted my shoulder with a smile. “But yeah, I liked it. I mean, I don’t think I’d like it all the time, but...yeah, it was fun.”

“Was it better?” My insecurity weaseled its way in, leaving its acrid wake.

Erin looked up at me. I couldn’t read her expression beyond an inquisitive one. I got the impression that I was being dissected. My insecurities grew. I glanced away.

She took my chin and forced me to look at her. “Tom, baby, don’t go there. I had fun, but he’s not you. We’re still good, you and me. AJ’s not going to change that. I mean, the sex was good, but...but it didn’t come close to this.” She squeezed me with her thighs. “To what we have. It was like those superhero movies we talked about, you know? It was shallow. A good movie to have with popcorn, but in the end, pretty empty.”

I kissed her deeply, pouring everything into the kiss. I wanted her to feel this in her bones. I wanted her to understand the love I had for her. In that handful of sentences, she’d managed to wipe away my fears and insecurities.

When we broke from one another and caught our breaths, I said, “So you’re saying that he’s Ironman, and I’m not.”

Erin grinned. “Well, he *is* an ironman, and last I checked, you’re not.”

“I can be, if you want,” I said. I drove into her for emphasis. She laughed.

“Of course, honey, but I’m actually glad that you’re not. You’re way more...real. Guys like AJ are hot, but they’re laser focused on the superficial. I don’t want that in a partner.”

“But it’s fine for a boyfriend?”

“Think more: *boy-toy*.”

“Ha. Okay, so let’s talk about your boy-toy. You left the restaurant, and...?”

Erin took a deep breath. I slowly stroked her, waiting patiently. “We left the restaurant and he invited me back to his room. We’d been drinking for hours, so that helped settle my nerves—although my heart still beat faster than it ever got on the race. As soon as we were in his room, he was all over me. I’d like to tell you that I was more of a tease, but after months of build-up, I caved as soon as his lips were on mine.”

I may have lost it had I not come on the back porch. As it was, I started fucking her faster before she stopped me.

“Slow down, honey. Still...sore.”

“Sorry.”

She shook her head. “Never be sorry. Just...be gentle.”

I slowed. “So inside the room...”

“Right. Inside, we kissed a lot, but our hands were everywhere. Before I knew it, we were naked and he was bending me over the bed. I think I already told you about this part, but God, that felt so dirty. There was barely any foreplay, and he probably could have fucked me the second we walked into his room—I’d been soaking all night.”

She paused, her eyes fluttering shut as she took a deep, purifying breath.

“When I felt his cock inside me...” She shook her head. “I thought that it was going to be harder to cross that line. Turned out, it wasn’t.”

She looked at me, her face red and her eyes shimmering in the low light.

“Did he wear a condom?”

“Yes, of course.”

“Did he make you come?”

“Yes, of course,” she repeated, this time with a smile. “Twice.”

“And then?”

“He came with me the second time, we flopped onto the bed, and I nearly passed out. I would have, but I needed to send you a special text.”

“Thank you for that.”

We made love slowly, both of us caught up in the immensity of what we’d just done. *We’d* done it. That’s what I realized. That’s what these past few months had been—Erin may have been the one training, she may have been the one to go to bed with another man, but it was a decision made by the both of us.

“So did he like the negligee you wore?” I asked, thinking about the photo she sent me in the morning.

“Oh, yes. When he walked in, he was like a man possessed. He fucked me on the dresser, my back pressed against the mirror. I remember looking over his shoulder, out the windows—which we hadn’t closed.”

I licked my lips. “Did anyone see you?”

“I don’t think so.”

“But it turns you on that maybe someone did?”

“Hard to say,” she said. “Everything about the experience turned me on. Like how he kept rubbing my pussy where I’d shaved it, and telling me how hot that was. Or how he handled me like I weighed nothing. At one point, I just had my arms braced behind me as he held me up and fucked me.”

I couldn’t help myself. I fucked her faster. Harder. I felt my balls begin to tighten. This time, Erin didn’t tell me to slow down.

"When I came, he carried me over to the bed. I thought he was going to let me rest, but he just pulled my legs over his shoulder, folded me in half, and started fucking me again. It was intense, Tom."

"Intense good?"

"Almost too good." She reached down and grabbed my ass, encouraging me to take her harder. "You close?"

"Yes," I said.

"When he made me come again, he pulled out of me, tore the condom off, and straddled my face. He fed his cock to me, and I sucked it. God, Tom, it made me feel so naughty. I sucked it as hard as I could. I wanted to taste his come. I wanted to get him off so badly."

"Oh, Erin..." I groaned.

"You like that? You like the thought of me swallowing another man's come?"

"Yes."

"Me too. I think I came again, without even being touched. He tasted. So. Good."

I exploded inside of her, and her own orgasm rushed up to meet mine as the echoes of her illicit sex with AJ reverberated in my head. When came down hard, sweat cooling on our skin as we held one another close. I listened to her breathing, happy to have her home.

"Any regrets?" I asked at last.

"Only if you do."

"I just wish I could have watched."

Erin's laugh was soft. She kissed me.

"I've been thinking..." I said.

"Uh oh," she whispered. Yeah, definitely half-asleep.

"I will love you forever, no matter what happens. But these last few months, as I watched this new side of you grow, have been intense."

"Intense good? Or intense bad?"

"Mostly intense good. I mean, there's this lingering fear in me that as you grow, I'm being left out of it. We're

supposed to grow old together, not just age together.”

She didn’t say anything. I pressed on.

“But it’s not really about good or bad. It’s about us. And it’s about *you*. And the *you* that I’m seeing emerge is crazy sexy. I know that you won’t leave me. I’m not worried about us anymore. And you know what that means? It means all that’s left is to have fun.”

“I love you, you crazy, crazy man.”

We kissed. We made love. We crashed together, entangled in one another’s arms. That final orgasm ended me. Sleep tugged me down, down, down. I faded fast. My pillow suddenly felt impossibly soft as it cradled my head. I shut my eyes. Just before I drifted off to sleep, I felt Erin shift beside me, touch my face in the dark, and whisper, “Thank you.”

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Epilogue

"I saw AJ tonight," Erin whispered as she swept into the bedroom. It was Wednesday, just three days since her trip to Annapolis—just three days since she'd turned me into a cuckold.

The intensity of that boundary being crossed hadn't diminished, although it had started to feel surreal. Her whispered confession, though, snapped it back into focus. My stomach churned.

"Yeah?" I said hesitantly. She hadn't mentioned a possible meeting today. She hadn't even mentioned the possibility of a second hook-up. I didn't actually believe that they were done after one night, but it was a safe idea to cling to in the meantime. Now...

"Yeah. For lunch." She put a hand on my arm and leaned in. "And after, we did something *really* naughty."

My cock sprung to life, and Erin's hand was there to feel it.

"That idea excites you, doesn't it?" she asked. Her hand squeezed my shaft.

"Oh, Erin..."

She lifted up on her toes to kiss me sweetly. "I'm going to grab a shower. Join me."

She turned on the balls of her feet and floated gracefully towards the bathroom. Her khaki shorts were snug and short, showing off her long, golden legs. My eyes were glued there until she pulled her loose blouse over her head. She wasn't wearing a bra, which only partially surprised me. Instead, I was drawn to the small bandage tapes to her left shoulder blade. My breath caught. That couldn't be—

"Told you I was naughty," she said. She was looking over her shoulder, seeing my shocked expression.

"Is that a—"

“Tattoo. We all got one.”

“We?”

She reached up and peeled the bandage away. The skin beneath was angry red—this was for real, not a tease. She winced as she pulled it completely off, and I got my first view of my wife’s tattoo.

It was small and tasteful—a red, blocky M with a dot over the top. The M was filled in with an orange and red tribal pattern. I wasn’t a huge fan of tattoos—and *never* thought that Erin would get one—but it was actually very tasteful.

“It’s the ironman logo,” Erin said. “And I wanted to always remember the day that...I ran my first ironman.”

Her wink was so dirty. I had no words to respond.

Erin laughed. “Actually, everyone in our training group got one after lunch. Team-bonding.” Then, with a smile, she added, “AJ suggested it.”

My stomach squirmed. AJ had suggested it? AJ had literally branded my wife? That thought was about as uneasy one as any.

“It’s cute,” I said.

Erin called me out on it. “Just cute? You look awfully turned on for something that’s just cute.” She unbuttoned her shorts and slipped them off. Beneath, she wore a white, workout thong.

Looking at her ass, I said, “So did anything, um...happen? After?”

Erin smirked. “You mean, did AJ take me back to his place and fuck me silly?” She peeled her thong off and led me into the bathroom. “Or are you asking if I met up with him in his Camaro and sucked his cock?”

The hiss of the water echoed the pressure cooker that was my brain. Had she done those things? She’d given no warning. She’d not even mentioned the lunch gathering of her running group until now.

I pulled off my shirt and followed her into the steam and spray. She turned to me, her hands going to my shoulders as we kissed.

She felt lithe against me, hot and tight, her skin sun-kissed and smooth. She reached down, cradling my cock in her hand, running along its tall length.

"You like that idea, don't you?" she asked.

"Did you...?"

She kissed the top of my chest, stringing me along for half a second longer before shaking her head. "No, I was good."

Yes, that was actually disappointment that I felt, tumbling right along with relief.

She leaned closer. "But I won't always be. Seeing him again..." She sighed, then giggled. "Well, I can't wait to see him again."

"When?"

Erin raised a brow. "I wonder who's more eager, you or me?"

Heat flooded my cheeks. I tried to save face. "Maybe AJ is."

"Maybe." She placed her hands back on my shoulders. "Right now, though, it's just you and me. And after today, I'm going to need some relief."

She pressed down, and I knew what was expected. Going to my knees, I thought about the last few months one last time, and where we were now. It was hard to believe that there was once a time that I didn't have this wife-sharing fantasy. Now, the idea was part of me. Had I been trained? Had it been me doing the training? Erin had crossed the line once, and AJ wasn't going away. What did the future hold? What new lines would we cross?

"That's it..." Erin moaned as I pressed my tongue against her shaven slit. "God, I love what you do to me."

You, too, I thought. The future was bright with terrifying possibility.

End of part one

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